Smoke and Mirrors

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32921302.

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, Gen

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella & Catra (She-Ra)

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Part 3 of 'Cause There's Magic In My Bones (Magicatra AU)

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by catrasredemption (dimensionhoppingrose)

Summary

~~Ma~~gicatra Season 5—
Nothing is okay.

The sword is broken, Horde Prime is invading, and Etheria is falling apart. Catra would've thought having her best friend at her side again would make things better, but something is wrong. Something she can't quite put her finger on.

The stakes are higher than ever, and Catra can't afford to be distracted. The world still needs She-Ra.

She has to be ready to fight. No matter what.

Notes

Here we goooooooooooooooooooo!

Told y'all I'd be back, didn't I?

A quick life update: My doggo is okay and has long forgotten he ever had surgery, and there's been no sign of the tumor growing back, so yay! That pandemic thing seemed like it was going away for awhile, but now it's back, so ¯_(ツ)_/¯ Guess that's a thing. But overall things are pretty okay. I've got about 5 and a half chapters of this written, aiming for a whopping ten, and I am E̸̛̛̛

The Beginning, Again

"You did *what*?!"

A few of the gathered princesses cringe as Catra yells, her voice echoing. Glimmer ducks her head, staring at the table. She doesn't really *have* to say anything. Catra already knows the answer. Which doesn't make anything better.

It's been a long day for everyone. Most of them have kingdoms they need to check on, to ensure they're safe in light of the recent developments. They're *all* tired. Angella is gently holding Micah's hand, rubbing his arm, clearly aware of how fragile he seems. Adora looks ill. There's really no other way to put it. She's pale, dark bruises etched under her eyes, her hair hanging loose in a way Catra hasn't seen since they were too young and too stupid to know how *hair ties* worked.

"You activated a planet destroying weapon because an AI *you* told *me* not to trust said it was a good idea?!" Catra does her best to get control of her voice. She really does. But *she's* tired too. And angry. And somehow, having Adora less than a foot away isn't making her feel as good as it should.

"I was *trying* to open a portal to save *your* friend," Glimmer says through gritted teeth. She knows she messed up. She *knows*. She doesn't need Catra throwing it in her face.

"What, so this is *my* fault?"

"Yeah, maybe it is a little!"

"Oooooooooookay," Bow says quickly, standing to grab Catra's shoulder, holding her back. "Listen, today was not great. And Glimmer *maybe should have talked about that plan* before going through with it." That part is added pointedly in Glimmer's direction.

"But it's done. We can handle things, though. I mean, look! All of Etheria's princesses are in one room. The queen *and* king of Bright Moon. She-Ra! We're stronger than we've ever been."

They don't *look* particularly strong. Spinnerella is sitting in Netossa's lap, their heads resting together. Mermista is leaning on Sea Hawk. Frosta is curled up in Scorpia's lap, sleeping. Scorpia is looking around nervously, her eyes falling now and again on Perfuma, who meets her gaze with a strained smile. Entrapta is fiddling uncertainly with an open panel on Emily. Everyone exchanges uncertain looks until Catra breaks the silence.

"We don't have She-Ra."

All eyes turn to her. Bow's hopeful expression falters. "What?"

Catra pushes away from the table, looking away from everybody as she walks toward the balcony. "The Heart of Etheria was a weapon. She-Ra and the sword were a key. What do you do when you want to stop something? You destroy the key."

She can practically *feel* the disappointment in the room. She's really fucked everything up this time. Maybe she could have found another way to stop the Heart. She probably *should* have. But she had been desperate. The world had been at stake. What else was she supposed to do?

"But...the mask..."

Catra shakes her head. "The mask was meant to help harness the magic. It can't work separately the way the sword did. Not in a way that makes a difference." She turns to look at the gathered group, her gaze falling for a long moment on Adora before she hurriedly looks away. "So, no She-Ra. Just me."

"Catra..."

Glimmer's voice drifts off as Catra looks at her. "Might as well enjoy your time with your dad while you have it," she says simply before jumping onto the balcony railing and hopping down to the next closest one.

"Did she just—"

"She's fine." Adora speaks for the first time, voice hoarse. "She can jump way further without hurting herself. We tested it once." She pauses. "More than once."

"You should see a healer," Angella says, eying Adora, then looking at Micah. "Both of you."

"I'm fine," Adora says quickly. Angella raises an eyebrow.

"Infirmary. Both of you. Now."

Glimmer ducks her head to hide her smile. It's a nice moment of normalcy. Something they all need.

"Raz?"

Catra wanders aimlessly through the woods, assuming she'll find Raz if she's meant to. But it doesn't hurt to make a little effort. "Come on old lady, I don't want to wander around all day"…

She steps by a cluster of bushes, and a broom comes down on her head. "Ow!" Okay it doesn't actually hurt, but she can still complain. "What the hell?"

She whirls to glare at Raz, who's regarding her with a stubborn frown. "That's what you get for calling me old, kitty."

"I mean, you *are*, you were old when *Mara* knew you." Something else clicks in Catra's mind. "Wait, did you just call me kitty? Do you know who I am?"

"Of course I do! Why wouldn't I?"

"Because you *never* do." Is she actually lucid? It's a miracle. Raz waves Catra off.

"I get a little confused. I'm an old lady, what do you expect?"

Catra splutters in disbelief for a moment. "You—You—Why did I come looking for you again?"

"You tell me." Raz hums as she turns away, sweeping the ground. Catra follows, because what else is she supposed to do? Go back and face a room full of disappointed princesses? Pass.

"Light Hope is gone," she says after a moment. "Mara's unfriendly ghost."

Raz sighs. "Mara always believed the best in people. Did she suffer?"

Catra opens her mouth to point out an AI can't really suffer, then pauses. It certainly had seemed like suffering, the way she had glitched and struggled against everything the First Ones had programmed her for. And after Catra had broken the sword…

She groans, dragging herself off the floor. Everything is black. She feels like she's been suspended in mid-air.

"*Catra.*"

Her eyes shoot up to see Light Hope kneeling in front of her, form glitching even as she reaches out to touch Catra's cheek. "Thank you," she says simply before disappearing.

"No," Catra says quietly. "I don't think she did." Raz hums, and Catra assumes she's happy to hear that. "I broke the sword," she continues, staring ahead. "It was the only way to stop the Heart." Nothing. "She-Ra is gone."

Razscoffs, catching Catra off guard. "What did I tell you? She-Ra isn't the sword!"

"Uh...you never told me that."

"No?" Razztilts her head slightly. "Must have been Mara. But it's true! She-Ra has always belonged to Etheria, not the First Ones. Your ancestors understood that."

"My." Catra's hand drifts up to touch the mask. "The Magicats?"

"Who else would I be talking about?" Lucid Razzis kind of mean, Catra decides. "They knew She-Ra wasn't something to be *controlled*. They knew more about Etheria than the First Ones ever bothered to learn."

"Great, well, they're all dead, so that's not doing me much good, is it?" Catra asks, losing her patience.

"They're not *all* dead. You're still here."

"And I'm useless!" Catra throws her hands up in frustration. "The only good I've ever been to anyone is as She-Ra, and I don't have her anymore, and I don't know a damn thing on my own!"

The look Razzgives her is almost pitying. Catra hates that more than the sarcasm. "You have plenty to offer without She-Ra," she says after a moment, turning back to her work. "Once you understand that, you might even be able to get her back."

"Get her." Catra shakes her head, taking a deep breath and blowing it out again. "Okay. Sure."

Maybe Razzisn't completely lucid after all.

It's late when Catra returns to the castle. She opts for the front door; the least she can do is face people after the way she walked out. But

the halls are empty, leaving her alone with her thoughts and the sound of her footsteps echoing off the walls.

At least until she rounds a corner and walks straight into another person.

"Ow! W atch"—

Her voice abruptly dies in her throat when she sees Adora watching her, wide-eyed. "Um. H-Hey Adora," she mumbles lamely , rubbing the back of her neck. "Sorry I kind of threw you to the wolves. Anyone give you a hard time?"

"No," Adora says quickly . "The um. the queen made me go to the infirmary, and Glimmer gave me a room. I couldn't sleep, though."

Her hair is still loose, still hanging around her shoulders. Catra raises an eyebrow. "All of that, and you *haven't* ripped the place apart looking for a new hair tie? I'm shocked."

"Oh." Adora tugs at a lock of her hair . "I'm not. really looking for one, honestly. I kind of like my hair like this."

That absolutely floors Catra. "Since *when*?"

"I don't know . I guess I just got used to it like this?"

There's something… *off* about Adora. Something Catra can't quite place. The hair is definitely part of it —Adora has *never* liked her hair down. It's annoying and gets in her face. But she's never been able to cut it either. One of the older, slightly softer cadets had taken a liking to their squad and helped with things like haircuts when they were too young to do it themselves, but Catra had never allowed anyone near her mane, and Adora had only ever allowed a trim at best. Catra has no idea what had happened to that cadet after he went on to be a soldier. She hopes he isn't dead.

But that isn't the point right now .

"Are..Are you okay?" she asks uncertainly , looking Adora up and down. Adora crosses her arms, a little insecure.

"Y eah, Im fine. It' s just..a lot, being back after the portal." Catra swallowed the guilt threatening to well up. This isnt about her . She can stew in her bad feelings later.

"Do you..wanna talk about it?"

Adora shakes her head, and Catra doesnt push. "I'm *okay*," Adora assures her. "I should probably just sleep."

"Probably . Think you can find your way back?" She doesnt know where Glimmer put Adora, but it's easy to just go wake Glimmer up and ask.

"Y eah. Of course." Adora turns to head in the completely opposite direction. "I'll just uh..see you later?"

Catra wants to argue. To push. To insist that Adora stay, and talk to her, and *never* leave her sight again. But the words are stuck in her throat, and all she can do is nod. "Y eah. See you later."

She watches Adora walk away, then changes directions as well, going to a seldom used part of the castle, opening the door only she has the key to. The orbs of light brighten as she steps in, lighting up the mural on the wall. It's stupid. Angella isnt standing in front of *Micah's* mural right now, because she has him *back* (and Catra really needs to ask about that). Catra shouldnt be here, visiting a bad memory.

But it's the only place she feels safe in the moment. She closes the door behind her and slides down the wall, closing her eyes. The world is upside down, and a memorial to a dead person who isnt actually dead is her only safe place.

It's pathetic.

Boom.

Catra nearly jumps out of her skin as the castle shakes and the loud noise jars her awake. She doesn't remember falling asleep, and has no idea what time it is, given the lack of windows in the room. And what was that?—

Another *boom*. Catra stumbles up and out of the room, tearing through the castle on all fours until she finds a balcony with a good view. She skids to a halt, jumping onto the railing. Bots. There are dozens of bots and tanks were rolling through the Whispering Woods, all pristine white.

"What the fu"—

A hand grabs her wrist, and then she's in the war room, nearly falling over. "I *swear*, Sparkles," she groans, catching herself on a chair. "Anyone know what's going on?"

"Not for certain, but if I had to guess, I would say Horde Prime is trying to move in on the castle," Entrapta says brightly. Catra raises her head to look at her; she's far too happy for the current situation.

"Horde Prime?"

"Oh." Entrapta tilts her head. "Right, I guess you guys wouldn't know. Horde Prime is the emperor of the known universe—you know, the place we're in now."

"How. How do you know that?"

"Hordak is one of Prime's clones."

Of course he is. Catra pinched the bridge of her nose, looking around. Bow, Angella, Micah, Scorpia, Netossa, Spinnerella, and Adora are there as well—Glimmer had taken most of the other princesses back to their kingdoms to check on things. That's their army, plus the Bright Moon guard.

She likes these odds even less than she liked them the *first* time the Horde had attacked Bright Moon. And that had been with Adora leading it.

"Okay ."She straightens up, letting out a long breath. Another explosion echoes through the castle. "We dont have time for a history lesson. You can tell us Hordak's tragic back story later. We have to figure out what to do about the army standing on our doorstep."

"Retreat,"Angella says. "We cant take this risk"—

"No way!"Glimmer argues. "We cant give up the palace. Where would we go?"

"This is not the hill to die on, Glimmer ."

"Who plans on dying?We can take them."

Catra peeks over the balcony. They're getting closer . "Uh, guys?I'd say we have about two minutes for this argument, so maybe speed it up a little."

"You, me, and Dad are all here."Micah lights up a little at being called *Dad*. "And we have the Moonstone. We can hold them off."

"Even with the three of us I dont know if we're strong enough"—

"What about the Sorcerer 's Guild?"Catra cuts in. She knows Mystacor has been neutral, more or less, but it's still in their best interest to make sure their planet *isn't* taken over by an alien overlord.

"That..may work,"Angella admits, casting a glance at her husband. He looks like someone got him shower and a new shirt, at least. "We ell need time, though."

"How long?"Catra asks.

"To prepare the spell? At least ten minutes. Not to mention the time it takes to gather."

"Okay . I can buy you fifteen."

"What do you mean — Catra!"

That last part is shouted as Catra launches herself over the balcony. "I know she can land on her feet," Netossa says slowly . "But I really wish she would stop doing that."

Angella shakes her head, standing. "Glimmer , go to Mystacor. Tell Casta to gather whoever she can in five minutes and bring them back. The rest of you get out there and help Catra."

Catra dives headfirst into the middle of the approaching army. No She-Ra, but her claws still work fine, she thinks grimly, cutting down two bots and a tank without a second thought. She bounces up to a tree, landing on the branch, then launches herself off the branch to take out a couple more. A gust of wind blows through, catching a few bots and tossing them away. "You didn't really think we'd let you have all the fun, did you?" Spinnerella asks with a playful smile.

"I didn't really , no." Catra drives her claws right through the camera of another bot, and jumps to avoid being shot. An arrow embeds itself in that bot, and explodes. Catra looks up to see Bow on the balcony, smirking. She gives him a wave before jumping in again.

"Okay , okay," Casta says as she appears with Glimmer and several other acolytes. "I know we don't have much — *Micah*?

Ah. Right. They haven't had a chance to tell her about her brother yet. Micah smiles weakly, raising a hand. "Hi, Casta."

The sorceress covers her mouth with quivering hands. "I apologize for not getting a message to you sooner," Angella says. "And I understand you're in shock. But we have very little time right now ."

"Right. Right. Right." Casta shakes it of f, taking a deep breath. "Shall we?"

"Behind you!"

Catra turns just in time to see Adora driving a staff into a bot. "Shouldnt you be on like, bed rest or something?"

Adora scoffs. "It' s like you dont even know me."

Netossa has joined the fight as well, which mostly turns it into a game of keep away until Bow calls them back. They retreat as a dome forms around the castle, starting at the Moonstone and bubbling out. What's left of the invading army is cut of f, save for a few bots which are easily taken down.

Adora elbowed Catra gently, giving her a faint smile. "Not bad. Y ou almost kept up with me."

Catra looked at her, eyes fixing on the hair *still* hanging around her shoulders. Then, she grinned. "Psh. Give me a break. Y our giant ego will survive if you just admit I took down more bots than you."

She poked Adora's forehead as she spoke, and Adora went cross-eyed to look at her finger. And for a minute, everything felt okay.

Glimmer and Bow appear in front of them, beaming. "I knew we could do it!" she said cheerfully , bouncing. "And the castle' s defenses are up, and Aunt Casta is kind of losing her mind right now so we should maybe not go up there for a bit. But everything's fine!"

"Y eah," Catra muttered, looking at Adora out of the corner of her eye.

Everything is fine.

"The attack on the castle has failed, Lord Prime."

Horde Prime looks down on the clone standing before the throne, gaze cold, calculating. "Is that so." It's not a question. He's already aware of it, of course. Had witnessed it happen, just as he saw everything.

"The Etherians defenses were stronger than we expected." This is the closest any clone can get to *anxious*. Reporting bad news to Horde Prime is always a gamble. This isnt unexpected, though. It had only been a test of their defenses, after all. Getting into the castle and taking their stronghold would have been a pleasant surprise, but it's no great loss at the end of the day.

Little Sister is already inside, after all.

When Everything Breaks

Chapter Summary

Things go a liiiiiiiiiiiittle bit sideways

Chapter Notes

It's fine :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra rolls over to stare at the wall, sighing. She cant sleep. No surprise. She rolls out of bed, heading for the door…

And nearly walks into a full-on wall.

Okay, it's actually Adora. But that's the same thing, really. "Ow! Hey, Adora, what're you doing hovering outside my door?"

Adora stutters for a moment before saying, "What are *you* doing outside your door?" Catra raises an eyebrow. "Okay, okay. I cant sleep."

"Welcome to the club." Catra nudges her along. "Come on."

"Where are we going?"

"My insomnia haunt."

They walk along the halls, Adora looking around curious. "I hate this place," she admits finally. "It's so bright and the windows are too big and I murdered my bed."

"You wait, what?" Catra stops to stare at Adora in disbelief. "What do you mean you *murdered your bed?*"

"I was trying to make it less...less *soft*, and I kept hitting it, and then feathers start flying out of it and—" Adora throws her hands in the air. "What is *wrong* with this place?"

Catra laughs despite herself. "Yeah, it's pretty bad. I slept in the window nook and the library at a lot at first."

"The *library*?" Adora repeats, raising an eyebrow. "What were you doing in the *library*?"

"Reading *books.* We don't all think with our fists, macho girl."

Adora shoves Catra, sticking her tongue out. "So are we going to the library?"

"No, you jerk."

They arrive at Micah's mural—vacant. Of course. Angella has the real thing back now. Adora stops, looking up, eyes wide. "What?..."

"It's a mural of King Micah. Angella had it done when she thought he died." Catra drops onto the bench, curling her knees up to her chest and sighing. "I'm not sure if she had sleeping problems or if she just doesn't need sleep—immortals are weird, ya know—but she was always here when I came around."

"How'd *you* get here?" Adora asks, sitting with Catra. She points up to the rafters.

"Couldn't sleep. Wanted to explore so Glimmer would stop fucking teleporting me everywhere."

"So you and the queen bonded over insomnia?"

"Yeah." Catra leans her head back against the wall. "Pretty much. It's just kind of a comfort thing now, I guess. And one of the only places I know for sure is empty because no one's coming to a memorial for a guy who's alive."

True." Adora looks up at the mural. "It's...nice."

"They've got a thing for abstract art around here."

Adora's eyebrows crinkle in that way they do when she's thinking. "So the queen would just...come here and stare at this thing all night?"

"Yeah. I never got either, honestly. It just seems like it would hurt more, right? But no one we cared about ever really died." The words *Because we only cared about each other* went unsaid. "I think I kind of got it after awhile, though."

"What do you mean?"

Catra hesitates. "...Okay, you can't laugh."

"I won't."

"I don't believe you."

"Catra, I *promise*."

The word stirs something in Catra. She lets out a long breath and stands, walking further down the hall. Adora follows curiously.

The room is a lot smaller and more private. Catra is the only one who knows it exists, aside from Angella. And she's happy to keep that way. She slowly flicks on the light, chewing on her tongue and waiting for Adora's comment.

It doesn't come. Catra turns after a moment to look at Adora, and sees her staring at the wall, mouth hanging open. "Is...Is that me?" Catra nods. "Why"…

"Angella thought it would help. Not that I missed you or anything," she adds quickly when she sees the smug smirk on Adora's lips. "It's just, you know...somewhere quiet to come and be alone."

"Because you missed me?"

"Of course not." Catra scoffs, shoving her away, and goes to settle against the wall opposite the mural. Adora hesitates before joining her.

"Does this really make you feel better?" she asks uncertainly. Catra shrugs, curling her legs up to herself. They fall silent for a moment.

"You haven't talked about it," Catra says finally. Adora looks over, surprised.

"Talked about what?"

"About the portal. About the fact that you almost ended up trapped there for the rest of your life because you're a dumbass with a hero complex."

"I don't have a hero complex," Adora argues half-heartedly. "You were ready to stay there too."

"That's *different*"—

"Why, because you found a stupid sword? Because of the mask?"

"Because it was my fault, you idiot!"

They stop, staring at each other. "I pulled the lever too," Adora says finally. Catra lowers her head, staring hard at the floor.

"Because I wanted to. Because I was so desperate to get away from the sword and this *destiny* and Shadow Weaver that a weird portal world created this perfect place where I'd never have to worry about a damn thing"—she pauses, shaking, and takes a breath. "We're not talking about me."

"Maybe we should be."

"*Oh*. I've had months to deal with things. You're the one who immediately came out of the portal and into an alien invasion."

"Yeah, that was kind of." Adora grimaces, looking out the window. "Not gonna lie, things have been pretty weird. When did we get *stars*?"

Catra laughs tiredly. "Around the same time we got the aliens. Light Hope—"

"The weird castle AI?"

"Yeah. She tricked Glimmer into activating the Heart of Etheria—"

"The *what*?"

Oh boy. Catra sighs, trying to rewind in her mind. "Okay. The Heart of Etheria is a weapon built by the First Ones. It basically turns the planet into a weapon. It's why the Magicats took the mask and went into hiding—the First Ones tried to remake the Heart so it wouldn't need the mask, but it didn't really take. Or something. I don't know."

Adora raises an eyebrow. "I thought the First Ones were the good guys."

"History is written by the victors." Catra repeats the six words hollowly. "They let the Magicats be forgotten and turned themselves into the heroes."

"Of course." Adora rolls her eyes. "Has anyone *ever* told us the truth about *anything*?"

Catra laughs bitterly. "I'm not sure. I know exactly fuck-all about everything."

"No wonder you wanted to get away from all of it." Adora looks back at the mural. "So, the stars?"

"Right. Light Hope wanted to activate the Heart of Etheria, using me and the magic princesses, and she opened a portal to bring us back into the wider universe." Catra waves a hand at the window. "And now we have stars. And aliens. And...you, I guess. Entrapta said something about Light Hope's portal aligning things just right to let her open a portal and get you out."

"I don't really remember her finding me," Adora admits, rubbing the back of her head. "I think I was kind of out of it."

Kind of out of it is a nice way of putting it, Catra things. She and Adora had stood outside the castle, clinging to each other until she had felt Adora's knees going weak, then half carried her inside.

"I remember you hugging me like you"—

"Don't. Say. It."

Adora grins, nudging her shoulder against Catra's. "You can just admit you like me, you know. The world won't end just because you care about someone."

That's not entirely true, Catra thinks, looking at the mural. Adora waits, and when she doesn't get a response, she leans against Catra, resting her head on her shoulder.

"I know I missed you," she murmurs after a moment. Catra's cheek comes to a rest against the top of her head.

"Maybe I missed you too."

They sit in silence for a bit, and Catra starts to think Adora fell asleep before she says, "We haven't really talked about the portal."

"I was *just* saying that, and you"—

"No, not what happened to me. Us. That...That world we were living in."

Catra stiffens. Oh. *Oh*. Right. She's tried very hard not to think about all of that. And mostly succeeded. "Yeah, I can't believe you were second-in-command of Bright Moon's army. How *boring* can you be?"

"I'm sorry, *which of us* was a princess again?" Adora challenges, shoving her shoulder.

"I definitely did *not* approve that choice."

"But you were such a *cute* princess."

"Shut *up*." Catra pushes Adora away, but Adora grabs her, dragging her into a headlock. "Hey! Lemme go you big—"

"What about us?"

Adora's quiet voice stops Catra's protests. Her ear is pressed right up against Adora's chest; she can hear the slightly fast heartbeat betraying the blonde's anxiety.

"Yeah, that...that was pretty weird, huh?" Catra asks with a weak chuckle. "Remember how we always said we'd rule the Horde together? Maybe it was something like that. I mean, if you married me, we would've been queens eventually. Can you imagine that? *Queen* Adora."

"And *Queen* Catra." The easy teasing tone is back in Adora's voice. They've navigated this particular bump, and no one is hurt. It's okay.

Catra wrinkles her nose slightly, tugging at Adora's hair. It's *still* hanging loose around her shoulders. "Okay, seriously, what's *up* with this?"

Adora bats Catra's hand away. "I thought you'd be *happy*. You've been calling my ponytail stupid for years."

"Yeah, but it's *normal* stupid. This is just weird."

I wanted a change. Is that such a bad thing?"

It's a weird thing. Neither of them have ever been particular welcoming to *change*.

"I guess a little brain damage is expected after that shit you pulled."

Adora shoves her, and she laughs. It's normal. Everything feels normal.

"Clones all over the place, but no sign of Hordak," Scorpia reports. She, Glimmer, Spinerella, and Netossa had snuck to the Fright Zone to see what the situation was there. Entrapta's hair droops in disappointment.

"He was trying to get back to Horde Prime," she says after a minute. "That's what the portal was for."

"Well, congratulations to him, it worked," Catra says through gritted teeth. "I'm sure he's being treated like a real hero right now. So the Fright Zone is a loss. That's nothing new. No one wants that pile of junk anyway."

It's hard to miss the sad look on Scorpia's face. That *had* been her family's kingdom. Catra sighs, pushing herself away from the war table and standing. "Are you going to jump again?" Netossa asks nervously.

"No, just need to think," Catra mutters, pacing. "The Fright Zone isn't particularly hard to take over, especially if Hordak is one of Prime's clones – he probably handed it over. But he must have enough power to keep control of that place *and* send armies after us and who knows where else. I'm sure he's tried to hit most of the kingdoms by now, if not all of them. "

"Perfuma, Mermista, and Frosta have all checked in," Glimmer speaks up. "Plumeria's preparing for an evacuation, and Salineas

has ships hovering over it, but Mermista's keeping up a shield. Nothing up North yet."

"Being as far away as they are has its perks." Catra runs a hand through her hair, letting out a long breath. "Okay . It's fine. I mean, limbo sucks, but we were in limbo for years before the sword. It could be worse."

"Is that your attempt at optimism?"

Catra shoots Glimmer a glare. Right. They're still on thin ice. Glimmer looks away, ignoring the sick feeling in her stomach. She had messed up so much. This is *her* fault. They don't have the sword, they don't have She-Ra, and they don't have any foot up on Horde Prime the way they did with the Horde. He's completely unknown.

"Wait." Catra straightens up, ears twitching, tail going still. "Where's Shadow Weaver?"

"Mystacor ," Angella says simply . "Castaspella reminded me that they're better equipped for that kind of prisoner , and Mystacor is almost unreachable. And I saw no point in continuing to keep her here."

"Shame. If I'd known she was leaving, I would've punched her one last time."

"I'm certain you'll get another chance."

Knock-knock-knock-knock —

Glimmer jerks awake as the fist banging on her door echoes through the room. "What?" she asks stupidly before remembering she's alone. Catra still isn't speaking to her , and Bow is clearly on Catra's side. He's trying to be friendly, but it's tense.

And it's certainly not either of them trying to punch her door down.

"Okay , okay," she says, teleporting to the door and throwing it open. She isn't sure what she's expecting, but *Adora* isn't it. "Wha — Adora? Are you okay?"

"I saw Catra leaving." Adora's tone is frantic, eyes wide and panicked. "I — I don't know what she's doing, but" —

"But she's being stupid," Glimmer growls. Of *course* Catra is sneaking off to try and deal with things on her own again. "Where'd you see her?"

"Um... around the north side, I think? She was sneaking out of her room" —

Glimmer grabs her hand, teleporting them down below Catra's balcony. There's no one in sight, of course.

"Uuuuuuuuuuuuugh." Glimmer lets out a groan that would make Mermista proud. "Come on, maybe we can catch her ." She drags Adora out beyond the protective dome. "Thaymor isn't that far from here, she's probably" —

Adora drags them to a stop, pulling hard on Glimmer's arm. Glimmer turns to protest, to say they don't have *time* for this —

A fist connects with her temple. She drops.

Catra is doing her best to relax. It's not like there's *much* she can do. Not alone, not without She-Ra. Damn it. She hates thinking like that.

She's curled up in bed, half doing. Too shallow for nightmares, just deep enough for her to tune out most things. The sounds of animals outside, the rushing waterfall, it's all white noise, comforting her to rest, assuring her that everything is still, and the problems can wait.

The magic dome *shatters*.

It's not as dramatic as it feels—the shimmering shield simply drops, but the feeling that shoots through Catra is like shattering glass. She's out of bed before she's totally aware of being awake, running to her balcony, watching the barrier fade away. An army of clones is waiting to cross as soon as it's open;they swarm in on all sides, immediately overwhelming the guards on duty with mere numbers.

"*Fuck*," Catra hisses, whirling and running to the door, barely remembering to grab her mask as she goes. Her ears twitch, reacting to every single little noise, every crash, every yell, every—

Glimmer's door is open. Catra stops, staring at it. Glimmer's door is almost never open, not when she just teleports to come and go as she pleases. It certainly has no reason to be open like this in the middle of the night, unless Bow's already gotten to her and they're trying to fight. Yeah, that's probably it. Several clones come running around the corner, and Catra's attention snaps to them. She has to find everyone else. And if that means tearing through every clone she sees, then so be it.

She runs. Scorpia, Entrapta, Spinnerella, and Netossa are staying down the hall;she can reach them. They can deal with this together. Where does Angella sleep? Catra's never had to worry about that—

The sound of bells hits her ears—the blessedly familiar sound of teleporting. She skids to a halt, relief flooding through her as she says, "For fuck's sake, Sparkles, I was"—

Violet light blinds her in the split second before a blast of magic throws her into a wall. She slumps to the ground, groaning, blinking rapidly to try and clear her vision. "*Down*, Glimmer, it's *me*"—

The words die in her throat when she sees Glimmer. Magic is sparking around her hands, preparing for another attack. But that's not what catches Catra's attention. She's drawn to Glimmer's eyes.

To the solid, bright green eyes.

Catra's voice is small. "Glimmer?"

Something solid connects with Catra's temple. Stars burst to life in her vision as she staggers, slumping against the wall. She shakes her head, trying to focus and see what hit her. It's Adora, with a staff, her eyes glowing the same, solid green. Catra feels like the world is spinning out under her feet. *How*…

A hand claps down on Catra's shoulder, and the world turns again, sickeningly this time, as Glimmer teleports her. That hand is the only thing that keeps Catra from collapsing.

"So *this* is the mighty She-Ra."

The condescending voice sounds like Hordak, but worse somehow. If Hordak had ten times more confidence. Catra grimaces, raising her head. And there's Hordak. Sort of. Maybe. A clone with the same solid green eyes as Glimmer and Adora and the other clones. But this one has bright white pupils.

"Horde Prime, I presume?" She speaks through gritted teeth. The clone smiles.

"My reputation precedes me. I apologize for having to meet this way, but I didn't believe this moment should be delayed."

Catra snarls slightly as she says, "Yeah, I was *really* looking forward to this. Maybe you could let my friends go now that you've got me."

"Let them go?" He looks between Glimmer and Adora. "I've brought them to my light. They're happy with me." He steps closer. Catra flinches away, but Adora doesn't move as he pats her head. "I rescued your friend from the void, you know. You left her to die, but I saved you, didn't I, Adora?"

"Yes, Lord Prime." Catra suppresses a shudder at the flat tone of Adora's voice.

"I... I didn't leave her—" It's not even close to what the main point here is, but she feels the need to say it. To tell Adora. "I didn't leave you, Adora, I swear—"

"It's okay." Adora's lips curl into an almost cruel smile. "I'm with Lord Prime now. I'm happy."

Catra stares at her helplessly for a moment before whipping around to look at Glimmer. She already knows it's useless. But she has to *try*. "Glimmer, c'mon, snap out of it. You don't want this. I know you don't."

"Of course I do." Her voice is *worse* somehow. "Lord Prime has freed me from all my burdens. All my bad decisions don't matter anymore. It's better this way."

"You see?" Prime brings Catra's attention back to him. "This is what they want. Soon it's what *all* your friends, and then all of Etheria, will want. Don't you want to join them in the light?"

Ice is running through Catra's veins. "No." The answer is immediate. It surprises her; she'd been so willing to give everything up for the portal world, where she could just be married to Adora and be happy. But this? She won't do this. She can't give up again.

Horde Prime simply smiles. "You'll see sense soon enough." He turns away, leaving Adora and Glimmer to pull Catra along in his wake. She takes a deep breath, and lets her body go slack, her knees giving out from beneath her. Adora and Glimmer stumble, not prepared for the sudden movement, and Catra takes her chance; she elbows Adora in the chest, and kicks Glimmer, throwing them both off of her.

She runs.

She can hear yelling behind her, can hear footsteps as Adora gives chase, but none of that matters. Adora wont catch her . She’s never been able to. What’s more important is—

Bells.

Catra skids to a halt and jumps to the nearest tree branch, just barely dodging as Glimmer teleports in front of her. She jumps down when Glimmer teleports to the trees, then up again, this time going higher.

Please let staying alive be more important than catching me .

Glimmer can teleport higher, sure. But that doesnt mean she can do anything when she’s fifty feet in the air.

Catra hears the bells above her and looks up to see Glimmer bearing down on her, fist clenched, shining with magic. She launches herself off the branch she’s on, heading for the ground again as the sound of branches snapping echoes through the sky. Catra grabs a branch to slow her fall a bit, then swings back down to the ground.

“Y ou cant get away , Catra,”she hears Glimmer calling behind her .

“Oh yeah?”Catra calls over her shoulder . “Y ouve never been able to catch me, even with teleporting. What makes you think youll do any better now?”

The princess disappears again, and Catra pulls a sharp right to avoid her. Her head is swimming, her heart pounding in her ears, and she knows the only things keeping her going are adrenaline and spite.

Itll have to do for now .

Chapter End Notes

> “But how was Adora able to have a normal conversation with Catra about the portal if she's being controlled?”
> It depends on your definition of normal. They really haven't even

scratched the surface of went on there, especially not the part where Adora continued to live a happy life married to Catra and they had a kid together. And Horde Prime's control through the chip at that moment was mostly subconscious - like a voice in the back of Adora's head that she's not questioning. But Prime can still see, and that conversation was important for him to witness.

It's fine, really.

Lost in the Woods

Chapter Summary

Catra runs

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The woods blur around Catra as she runs, still playing cat and mouse with Glimmer. They're about evenly matched—Glimmer has magic, but Catra has the strength and stamina to stay ahead. Even with the added boost from the Moonstone, Glimmer's going to run dry eventually. It's a race to see if adrenaline can outlast magic.

A race Catra is becoming more certain she's going to lose.

Her head is swimming from multiple blows. Her chest hurts where Glimmer blasted her. Her hands are raw and bleeding from the number of times she's swung off of tree branches. She's one wrong step away from toppling to the ground and never getting up. Well, not getting up of her free will, anyway.

"Come on, Glimmer!" she shouts breathlessly. "Don't tell me you're really just going to *listen* to that guy!"

A ball of magic blows apart the tree branch Catra is jumping off of. She lands and looks back, zeroing in on Glimmer's eyes. The horrifying, glowing green eyes. How is he controlling her? She jumps to avoid another blast; this one is weaker. Glimmer's running out of juice.

"You *will* bow to Lord Prime." Her voice is flat. Catra hates it.

"Gotta catch me first."

She hears bells as she takes off again, and decides it's time for a new tactic. Glimmer will forgive her when this is over. Probably.

She doesn't jump when Glimmer appears in front of her. Instead she rears her fist back and punches as hard as she can, knuckles slamming into Glimmer's cheek. She doesn't feel *too* bad; if the positions were reversed, Glimmer wouldn't have held back either. She'll understand.

Hopefully.

Glimmer goes down with a yelp and a grunt, and Catra takes a sharp left in the other direction, running as fast and as hard as she can. Her ears twitch, taking in every sound around her, but there are no bells. Glimmer isn't coming.

Shit, did I hit her too hard?

Catra skids to a halt, looking around. Nothing. Nothing. And nothing. She's in the clear. For now.

The adrenaline crash hits her like a tank. The world goes blurry and dark around the edges as her knees buckle, and she drops to the ground.

Her eyes snap open. She doesn't remember closing them.

She's still in the woods, although it has a slightly hazy quality to it now, as if a blanket of fog has settled around the trees. Catra pushes herself up, surprised to find that nothing hurts. Not what she would have expected after the workout she'd just put herself through…

Her thoughts drift off when she sees a shining light in the distance. The outline of it is vague at best, but somehow...familiar. A form Catra knows well. *She-Ra*.

She takes a few steps forward, mouth hanging open, then a few more as she reaches out. Any ability to speak has fled, but what would she even say?

Help me.

Im not strong enough for this.

Ican't do this alone.

Im useless .

Bright light shines in her peripherals. She yelps, surprised, and yanks the mask off to look at it. It's not just glowing;it' s *turned gold*. Catra gapes at it, then looks back at the glowing figure. Is it… closer?Whispers carry on a warm breeze;her ears twitch, trying to discern what is being said, but it's too low. Meaningless nonsense.

"Help."Her voice cracks as she speaks. "I cant.I dont know what to do. *Please* ."

"*What did Itell you?She-Ra isn't the sword! Y. our ancestors understood that.*"

Raz s words echo in her head. RazShe hopes that crazy old lady is okay.

The golden figure steps forward;Catra does the same. "You're… more than the sword."Because she has to be talking to She-Ra. Right?What else would this be?The sword was the First Ones' tool. But you exist beyond that, dont you?"

She doesnt get an answer , and she's not really sure if she expected to. The figure glows brighter, forcing Catra to cover her eyes…

And she bolts upright with a yelp. The sound is echoed by two familiar voices;Netossa and Spinnerella are kneeling next to her , wide-eyed. Spinnerella has a roll of bandages, and had apparently been in the process of wrapping Catra's hands.

"Easy ." Netossa has her hands up in surrender . "Are you okay?"

Catra narrows her eyes. "Are *you*? How do I know Horde Prime didn't get to you too?"

"We're not chipped." The words make no sense. Netossa sighs, turning to expose her neck. It's bare. "They got to Scorpia. We saw the chip on her neck."

"Creepy glowing green eyes?" Netossa nods, and Catra sighs. They got Scorpia. Catra looks at her hands, noticing the palm of the sleeve on her right arm is ruined. She stares at it for a long moment before ripping it off and tossing it aside. Spinnerella gently takes the hand to wrap it up as well. "Have you found anyone else?"

Spinnerella shakes her head. "You're the first person we've come across. And we can't get in touch with Perfuma, Mermista, or Frosta."

Great, so that's three princesses missing, plus Bow, Angella, Micah, and Entrapta unaccounted for. If Scorpia hadn't made it out of the castle, it's easy to assume no one else did either. Catra tries not to let herself go down that road.

"Okay ." She pushes herself up, tail moving to try and balance her out as she wavers. "If they weren't caught, they probably made it into the woods too. We just have to find them."

"Easy ," Netossa says dryly .

"I never said anything about it being easy ." Catra reaches up to adjust her mask, frowning slightly. She remembers dreaming… something about the mask? Golden light? The details are already slipping through her fingers like sand.

"You okay?" Spinnerella asks, tilting her head. Catra lets out a long breath and nods.

"Yeah, I'm fine. Let's get moving."

They walk mostly in silence, save for Netossa on her tracker pad, still trying to call the others. No one is answering.

"Plumeria was evacuating," Spinnerella says, grasping for some bit of hope. "Maybe Perfuma is busy keeping her people safe. Frosta might be sleeping. She said the North hadn't really been touched yet."

"And Mermista?" Netossa asks, raising an eyebrow.

"Also sleeping?"

Spinnerella is trying, and Catra appreciates that, she really does. But she's not exactly feeling *hopeful* at the moment. Her mind keeps going back to the dream – the dream that fades more and more as she tries harder to focus on it.

"*What did I tell you? She-Ra isn't the sword! You... our ancestors understood that.*"

She's ripped from her thoughts as green light sweeps through the forest. For a minute, she thinks they're under attack – and then she sees the giant hologram forming in the sky.

"Is that?..."

"Our lord and savior," Catra says, lip curling in disgust.

"*Rejoice, Etheria, for Prime has come to you.*" The voice is calm, almost a normal volume, but the words still ring loud and clear. "*Do not fear, for you have been given the opportunity to share in a world soon to be remade in my image.*"

"What does *that* mean?" Netossa hisses. Catra thinks about Adora and Glimmer. About their glowing eyes. Their words.

“*Im with Lord Hrme now . Im happy .”*

“*Lord Hrme has freed me from all my burdens. IA my bad decisions don’t matter anymore. t’ s better this way.*”

“I can guess.”

“*But first, you must prove yourselves worthy.*”He’ s *smiling*, and Catra would give anything to punch him. “*Your leader, your…* She-Ra*, she would see you suffer in darkness for her sake*.”

Netossa and Spinnerella look at Catra, who’s still scowling at the hologram. “*Cast aside this false hero and deliver her to me. Hrme sees all. Hrme knows all. They will not escape my judgment.* ”The hologram flickers, continuing to repeat *Hrme sees all* and *Hrme knows all*.

“Did he just put a bounty on Catra’ s head?”Netossa asks slowly .

“That’ s definitely what it sounded like to me,”Catra says.

“No one would listen to that, though,”Spinnerella insists. “Right? She-Ra’s a hero.”

“Y eah, and look where we are now.”Catra waves a hand around them. “She-Ra is gone, the planet’ s being invaded, and this egotistical asshole is offering to be their new savior. Of course people are going to listen. She-Ra’s abandoned them.”She paused for a moment, her shoulders drooping, her ears flat against her head. “*I* abandoned them.”

“That’ s not true.”Netossa rests a hand on Catra’ s shoulder, sqeezing tight. “Y ou saved the entire planet.”

“No one cares if I cant save it *now*.”She turns away , shrugging Netossa’s hand off. “Come on, we need to keep moving. W e’re not going to find anyone by standing around.”

The odds of them finding anyone at all are slim, but after all this time, Catra trusts the Whispering Woods. It always leads her where she needs to go, even if she doesn't know she needs it. The fact that she hasn't found Razz already either means the woods are protecting the old lady, or…

No. Don't think about that. Razz is fine. She's literally a thousand years old, somehow. A silly little thing like an alien invasion isn't going to stop her now.

She-Ra isn't the sword.

Catra reaches up without thinking, pulling her mask off to stare at it. *She-Ra isn't the sword*. Then why does she need the sword to summon her? The mask has always allowed her some access to She-Ra's magic, for a price. But the sword hadn't been *broken* at that time. There had still been a connection between them.

"*Your ancestors understood that*."

Her ancestors had come from a planet full of magic – a planet strong enough to drive off Horde Prime, though not without losses. Her mind flashes back to Melog, alone on the desolate planet, waiting for their people who were never coming back. She looks up at the stars.

Krytis. I wonder if we could get there…

Also not the time to think about that. She needs to keep her mind on Etheria. Where everything is wholly and completely *screwed*.

"There's no way they got *everyone*," Netossa is saying, trying to sound optimistic. "I mean, we all escaped. We just have to find them."

Catra remembers the hordes of clones flooding the castle, and bites down a shudder. Her head hurts. Adora had probably given her a fucking concussion. It's not the first head injury she's had, but it's a

frustrating development on top of everything else. Her hands tighten around the mask, edges cutting into her skin. She-Ra's healing had made her weak. She can't even handle a concussion now? Really?

"Catra?"

She looks up to see Netossa and Spinnerella watching her, open concern in their expressions. "Are you okay?" Spinnerella asks gently. "You look a bit…"

"You look like hell," Netossa supplies, ignoring her wife shoving her shoulder. "We can take a break, if you need."

"I don't," Catra says forcefully, pushing forward. "And *we* don't have time for a break. If the others are out here, we need to find them before the clones do. Unless you want to fight Angella and Micah and Scorpia and Glimmer and Adora and whatever Entrapta can make with whatever insane technology Horde Prime probably has."

"Okay, good point," Netossa says slowly. "But you're not going to fight anyone if you collapse."

"I'm *fine,"* she grits out, fingers tightening further around the mask. They don't have *time* for this.

Netossa and Spinnerella try to argue with her, but it's all noise. She looks up, staring ahead, and frowns. Is that fog? No, it's light. A vibrant, golden light. She blinks a few times, bewildered…

And the forest disappears around her. The trees vanish in the space between blinks, replaced by stars and blurs of color. The golden light intensifies, and she takes a step back. The surface beneath her feet turns rocky.

You've found yourself in quite the predicament, my child.

Catra gasps, whirling to see the giant maroon cat standing behind her, mane swirling blue and wild. "Melog!"

She swears the ancient guardian almost smiles. *It is good to see you too*.

The golden light grows brighter;Catra turns to see a figure stepping out of it. *She-Ra*. "The sword' s gone,"she says, tone desperate as she looks back to Melog. "What can I do?"

Melog tilts their head, ear flicking. *I do not know anything about Etherian magic or First One technology*.

"But the mask,"Catra pushes. "You have to know *something*. The first time I met you was.was during the battle of Bright Moon. Adora knocked me out, and then I was here, with you."

Your ancestors wove some of their own magic into the mask, Melog says, nodding. *They wanted to keep Mytis' memory alive.*

Catra looks back at She-Ra. "Then their magic would have mixed with She-Ra's magic."

Correct. But the First Ones sought to interfere.

"Because they wanted She-Ra to be a weapon. They made the sword to control She-Ra."

Which would have filtered out any other magic.

Thoughts and pieces of the puzzle fly around Catra' s head, slipping through her fingers every time she tries to grasp them. "*She-Ra isn't the sword!"* The magicats wove their magic into the mask, making it part of She-Ra, but the sword canceled it out. Now.Now it could be something completely unique.

She turns back to the golden figure again, a new determination shining in her eyes. "I'll fix this. Somehow."

The figure simply nods, and begins to fade away. Catra looks back at Melog, who is also disappearing. And a thought hits her.

"Wait!" She hurries forward, dropping to her knees in front of Melog, reaching for them. "Etheria is back in the wider universe. Is there a way we can get to you?"

The alien cat turns to her, pressing their snout into her hand. *If I told you not to, would you listen?*

Catra considers it for a moment, then shrugs. "Maybe?"

A buzz of amusement runs through her head, and she hears, *Then I'm sure I will see you soon,* before everything goes black.

Awareness comes back slowly, and Catra is happy to let it take its time. She's earned this moment of reprieve. And then voices started filtering in.

"Are we sure she's okay?"

"Has she *ever* been okay?"

"Her vitals are all normal! Although she *does* have slightly high blood pressure."

"Catra has high blood pressure? *Shocking*."

A low growl rumbles in Catra's chest. "Fuck you too, Mermista."

"She lives. Huzzah."

"Catra?"

It's Bow's pleading voice that finally makes her force her eyes open. Netossa and Spinnerella are on one side, Bow on the other, while Mermista and Entrapta (and Entrapta's robot friend – Emily?) stand over her. Bow grins, relieved.

"You're awake! How're you feeling?"

"Like I could sleep for another year ," Catra mutters, forcing herself to sit up. She looks around, raising an eyebrow. They're in a cave stacked with boxes, and she sees the Horde symbol on a few . "Is this a Horde supply cache?"

"That' s what we're assuming," a gentle voice says. Catra looks over to see Angella sitting on a crate, watching her with a smile. "W elcome back."

"I'd say it' s great to be back, but"…

Catra shoves the blanket aside and stands, ignoring everyone's protest.

"Y ou've been out for like, twelve hours"—

"Y ou need to relax"

"I'll relax when I'm dead," Catra mutters, looking around and noting the missing people. "Where' s"—

"Scorpia and Frosta were both caught," Bow says. "W e dont even know how long Frosta's been chipped. She's been telling us everything is fine for a week."

"They got Sea Hawk." Mermista does her best to sound unaf fected, but Catra hears the slight tremble in her voice. "And about half of Salineas."

"Perfuma' s got most of her people in safe places," Netossa says, holding up her tracker pad. "She' s on her way, hopefully."

"Glimmer and Micah are missing," Angella says. Catra ducks her head, feeling a sharp pain in her chest. Angella just got her family back, and now…

"They have Glimmer ." All eyes turn to her . "I saw her ."

She's not sure what's worse—the open pain in Angella's expression, or the sorrow Bow tries to bury. "How did this even happen?" Netossa after a minute. "The North, Salineas, Plumeria, *and* they managed to get through the shields in Bright Moon? It doesn't make any sense—"

"Adora."

It's Catra's turn to hide her pain as everyone looks at her again. "Adora and Glimmer caught me and brought me to...well, one of the clones, but Horde Prime was possessing it or *something*. I think Adora's been chipped since you took her out of the portal."

"But… *how*?" Bow asks, voice cracking. "We barely managed to get one open on this side—"

"I've been looking into the data from that portal, actually," Entrapta speaks up. "I believe it may have just been...well, luck, and I usually hate that word."

"What do you mean?"

"The First One AI—Light Hope?" Catra nods. "She opened a portal to bring Etheria back into the universe so she could activate the Heart. I believe we may have opened our portal at the same time she was pulling us through, which stabilized the portal capabilities, and allowed us to go in. Portal technology has always been stable in the wider universe, though. Horde Prime could have easily opened a portal into the place between dimensions, taken Adora, and put her back for us to find."

"How would he even know to look for her?"

"When...When the first portal lever was pulled, it was ultimately a failed experiment, but a signal *did* get through from Hordak to Horde Prime." Entrapta is staring intently at her tracker pad as she speaks. "Horde Prime would have known that something happened, and

likely came to investigate, finding Adora in the process. It would have been just as easy to put her back and use her as a bait."

"So we let someone working for him walk right into the castle and sabotage us."

Catra growls, shooting Mermista a glare. "She is *not* working for him. She's chipped, just like everyone else."

"It's undeniable that she knows things others do not, however," Angella points out. No one needs her to elaborate on that—Adora knows *Catra*. That makes her a valuable asset all on its own. "Which may make her more dangerous."

"She'll have already passed on whatever information she has," Catra mutters. "Between her and the other people he's taken, he probably knows *all* of our secrets by now."

No one needs to say the words, but they're all thinking it—Horde Prime will know all of their weaknesses by now. He has *Frosta*, one of the strongest princesses, Glimmer, who knows everything about She-Ra and the Heart of Etheria, probably Micah, who's the most powerful sorceress in the world, and Scorpia, and while Catra has never actually seen Scorpia use her newfound Black Garnet powers, she remembers perfectly well how Shadow Weaver had used the damn thing. Not to mention the bounty on Catra's head. In one night, he's managed to turn everything in his favor.

How are they going to win?

Chapter End Notes

> So uh..... no update next week. YOU SEE my birthday is on Monday, and we're going to California to see friends (yes we're both fully vaccinated and so are they and we are doing literally everything we can to make sure we're basically in our own little bubbles the entire trip), and Friday we're going to Disney for literally my first time ever and that's going to involve chasing

around a seven year old (who I promised to go on EVERY SINGLE RIDE WITH and he'll hold my hand if I'm scared y'all my nephew is so fucking cute), so that's going to be exhausting, then we leave on Saturday and it's just easier to take a week off than it is to try and update somewhere in all the madness.

BUT I will try to get something else up between now and next Thursday to maybe make up for that. I hope. We'll see. Don't be mad?

Regrouping

Chapter Summary

Everyone's favorite person comes back

Chapter Notes

Vacation was great, Disney is the best, and I'm 30 now!

"Catra," Bow sighed, watching the Magicat pace in front of the cave. "When was the last time you slept?"

"I'll sleep when I'm dead."

"That's going to be a lot sooner than you think if you don't sleep."

"I'm *fine*."

Bow sighs, pinching the bridge of his nose. He knows Catra is stressed. They all are. But Catra's putting it all on her shoulders, and that *can't* be healthy. "Do you even have a plan?"

"I'm thinking about it," Catra snaps. She runs her fingers through her hair, and Bow winces; he's pretty sure she's digging her claws into her scalp. "I just...need a minute."

"You *need* to take a break."

"Taking a break isn't going to rescue our friends or stop Prime."

"Neither is putting it all on yourself." Catra growls under her breath. Bow knows he's getting into risky territory, but he's spent months watching Catra tear herself apart. He's tired of not doing anything about it. "Catra"—

"I *know*, Bow, okay!?" She whirls to glare at him, throwing her arms up in the air. "I know! Everything is fucked up, and there's nothing I can do about it!"

"Maybe not alone," Bow agrees carefully. "But you're *not* alone." She blinks a few times, uncomprehending. "You still have me. All of us. And we've always done our best work *together*, right? So stop pushing us out. You're not alone. You never have been."

Catra stares at him until something in her expression breaks, allowing Bow a rare look into the vulnerability she's been masking since *long* before they met. Years of pain and grief and anger all bubble to the surface, making it impossible to tell one from the other in her expression.

"You promise?" she whispers, and there's a weight in the words that Bow doesn't *quite* understand. But he knows it's important. He knows he can't mess this up.

"Promise."

Her entire body sags for a moment before she darts forward, wrapping Bow in a tight hug. Bow is surprised for a moment, but quickly responds in kind, wrapping her in the tightest bear hug he can manage.

And if a few tears disappear into the fabric of his shirt, well... no one else needs to know.

Perfuma, thankfully, arrives in one piece and un-chipped, though obviously a little frazzled. She's as distressed as everyone else when they catch her up on the situation.

"What do you think he's doing with the people he captured?" she asks nervously, looking around. No one answers for a moment.

"He's not going to kill them," Catra says after a moment. "They're useful. Except Sea Hawk. No offense," she adds quickly in Mermista's direction. Mermista shrugs, trying to look unbothered by the whole thing.

"Whatever. Maybe he'll finally stop singing his stupid sea shanties."

Her voice is toneless, almost bored. But Catra is an expert at hiding behind apathy. She can hear the waver. Sea Hawk is important to Mermista, whether she'll admit it or not.

Entrapta is in a nearby corner, tapping away at a computer she had produced from who knew where. Maybe her suspenders have inter dimensional pockets. Nothing would surprise Catra at this point.

Her ears twitch when she hears approaching footsteps. She holds up a hand to silence everyone, points toward the entrance of the cave, then exchanges a look with Bow. They nod, and he knocks an arrow into place before following Catra to the entrance. Mermista grabs her trident and follows, with Netossa bringing up the rear, a netball at the ready. Catra pulls ahead a few feet, claws unsheathed, pushes back the moss covering the cave opening…

"Oh!"

Castaspella immediately puts her hands in the air when she finds herself facing four would-be attackers. "I come in peace?" she says uncertainly, eyes flicking around nervously. Catra narrows her eyes, looking at Castaspella's companion.

"Of fucking course you escaped."

"It's *so* good to see you as well, Catra," Shadow Weaver says dryly.

"She wasn't my first choice of people to save," Castaspella says, slightly bitterly. "Prime's clones were invading, and Micah was leading them. I thought it would be better that he not get to Shadow Weaver."

"Just don't move," Netossa says, making her way forward to check their necks.

"Don't bother with Shadow Weaver," Catra says, tone dripping with disdain. "Prime wouldn't need a chip for *her* loyalty. She follows whoever lets her live."

Castaspella looks slightly confused as Netossa checks the back of her neck, but doesn't move. Netossa nods after a moment, then moves to check Shadow Weaver anyway. "Believe it or not, I would rather avoid Horde Prime destroying the planet," Shadow Weaver informs Catra. "I live here, too."

"They're clear," Netossa says, stepping back. The others relax their stances, but Castaspella sees the glare Catra is giving Shadow Weaver.

"She's contained," the sorceress says, waving a hand. Invisible shackles momentarily flash to life around Shadow Weaver's wrists, the chain connected to a point on Castaspella's arm.

"Please, continue to talk about me like I'm not here."

"Happily," Catra says, turning to go back into the cave. "Let's go."

Castaspella immediately goes to Angella even as her eyes scan the room. "Where's"—

"They got Glimmer," Catra mutters, staring at the ground. "You said Micah is in Mystacor?" Castaspella nods. "If Horde Prime knows what he's doing"—

"Hordak said he's conquered countless planets," Entrapta speaks up. "It's safe to assume he has some experience."

"Right. Then he'll keep people where he knows they're strongest. Micah in Mystacor, Glimmer in Bright Moon, Scorpia in the Fright Zone, Frosta in the North, Sea Hawk in Salineas, probably"…

"And Adora?" Bow asks quietly. Catra's jaw tightens. That's a good question. The Fright Zone with Scorpia? It would make the most sense. Or maybe Salineas to act as backup. Sea Hawk isn't, as far as Catra knows, the strongest fighter. But she's never really seen him fight. And Prime might be counting on their unwillingness to hurt friends to keep Sea Hawk safe. If he's even still alive.

Don't think about that.

"Adora?"

Catra growls, her eyes snapping up to glare at Shadow Weaver. "What did I tell you about saying her name?" she snaps, starting forward. Bow quickly grabs her wrist to keep her back. "I don't know where he'd put her," she says, taking a deep breath and trying to refocus. "The Fright Zone or Salineas would be my best guesses. Does Sea Hawk actually know how to fight?"

"He does," Mermista says, sighing. "He's actually a pretty amazing swordsman – don't ever tell him I said that. He just doesn't *like* fighting if he doesn't have to."

Catra sits on one of the bins, chewing the inside of her cheek for a moment. "We need to start *somewhere*."

"Thoughts on where?" Bow asks, tilting his head. Catra sighs.

"Salineas would be the obvious choice. It's the only one not being guarded by a princess or sorcerer. But…"

"Water," Mermista says. "I'm the only one who can get there without Sea Hawk. I could go alone—"

"No," Angella says firmly, catching them all by surprise. "No one goes anywhere alone. We've been divided enough."

"She's right," Catra agrees. "If Horde Prime gets you, we're fucked."

"So, what, we stand around and wait for him to find us *here*?

"No, we're just not going to be stupid about this," Catra shoots back. Mermista raises an eyebrow.

"That's a bit much coming from you, isn't it?"

"Okay!" Netossa says quickly, standing. "Let's not—"

"No, let's." Catra stands, gaze hard as she glares Mermista down. "You got something you wanna say?"

Mermista folds her arms, leaning against the cave wall. "You've built your entire hero thing on being stupid and not knowing what you're doing. It's a bit late to worry about it now, isn't it?"

"I didn't hear you complaining about it when I fixed the Sea Gate," Catra half snarls. Bow rests a hand on her shoulder; she shrugs it off without looking at him. "But I guess it's convenient enough when I was fixing everything for you guys."

"Maybe everyone should stop and take a breath," Perfuma says nervously, wringing her hands together. "Before someone says something they regret—"

"And what's *that* supposed to mean?" Mermista asks, cutting Perfuma off.

"That you had no problem with the way I did things when it was *helping* you! But the minute things get hard, you turn on me and—"

"Wow, paranoid much? No one's *turning on you*—"

"*Enough*." Angella's sharp voice cracks through the room like a whip. "Both of you step back, *now*." A moment of silence falls as everyone exchanges looks; Catra and Mermista finally look away from each other, glaring at the ground. "Now is *not* the time to be arguing with each other. Nothing is going to be accomplished this way."

No one argues. "Maybe some recon would be a good idea," Netossa suggests after a minute. "Find out what we're getting ourselves into

before we jump in headfirst."

"That's true," Angella agrees. "We need to know what things look like around us. There are several villages nearby—"

Catra groans. "Thaymor's probably already been captured again. I swear, it's the Isle of villages."

"Are those words supposed to make sense?" Mermista asks dubiously. Catra deflates a little. Adora would've gotten it and laughed. But she's not here. Right. She had only been back for a couple of weeks, and Catra's somehow already forgotten life without her.

She tries not to think too hard on that.

"Never mind. How close is the nearest village?"

Bow taps on his tablet, bringing up the map. "About ten miles. Kinda miss Glimmer's teleporting right now."

"Got an extra trackerpad?" Catra's amazed when Entrapta actually produces one from somewhere, handing it to her with a lock of hair. "Okay. Send me the directions. I'll check it out."

"Didn't we *just* agree not to split up?"

"I'm not going to fight," Catra protests, ignoring the look she gets from everyone. "And I can travel faster on my own, *and* I know how to stay hidden."

"Check in every ten minutes, and let us know when you arrive at the village," Angella says. "And do *not* engage in any attacks. That's an order."

Catra salutes tiredly to Angella, turning to head out of the cave. "Yes ma'am."

Angella *hates* letting Catra go.

She absolutely hates it. Even if she *does* have to concede to Catra's point – she'll move faster and quieter on her own than she will if anyone else goes with her. That doesn't make her feel any better about it.

"I hope you're not putting *all* of your hope on her," Shadow Weaver drawls. "She rather famously does *not* do well under pressure."

"*Don't*," Angella says in a lower and more threatening voice than anyone has ever heard. She knows what happened with the portal. She knows that seeing Glimmer and Bow working with Shadow Weaver is a large part of what drove Catra to the choice she made. She knows that Shadow Weaver has haunted Catra ever since she left the Fright Zone. "Your opinion is not necessary, nor was it asked for."

"And yet it's the best advice you'll get today. She's going to let you down. She already has."

"Isn't there a way to make her shut up?" Mermista grumbles. "She's not great for team morale."

Casta draws a spell rune in the air and presses it against Shadow Weaver's throat. If she attempts to speak again, no one can tell. Good. Casta sighs, going to join Angella on the crate.

"Micah…"

"I know."

Angella isn't completely sure Casta has even adjusted to the thought of her brother being alive. There had been shock and tears when she had seen him, but she had almost immediately claimed that she need to go back to Mystacor. Micah had tried not to be *too* hurt by it.

"*It's fine, she's never done well with surprises,*" *he says with a forced chuckle as Glimmer and Casta disappear from the war room. "She*

has time to deal with it on her own. It's not like I'm going anywhere."

What a cruel joke the universe had played. Giving Micah back, only to tear him away again. Angella wonders if Catra is thinking the same thing about Adora. If she's letting herself feel anything at all. It's hard to tell with her sometimes.

"We'll get him back. We know where he is. We know he's alive. It's different."

"I know." Casta keeps her gaze firmly on the wall. They sit in silence for a few minutes. "I blamed you, you know. For so long." Angella had, in fact, known that. Casta isn't a particularly good actress; she'd made it clear, after Micah died, that Angella wasn't welcome in Mystacor anymore. And she had maintained that exile until Bow and Glimmer brought Catra there after rescuing her from the Fright Zone. "I was mad at you for so long. It wasn't fair to you."

"Casta—"

"Mystacor has remained neutral in this war for years. I thought I was doing the right thing when I chose to continue not engaging. Micah always hated that attitude. I think he would have left to fight the war even if he hadn't met you." Casta sighs, shoulders falling. "There's so much more we could have done. It didn't have to come to this."

This. Letting children fight their wars for them. Sending their family out to be cannon fodder. *Hiding*.

Angella rests a hand on Casta's shoulder, squeezing gently. "We can't change the choices we've made. But we can certainly make better ones going forward." She raises her voice to call, "Entrapta? Do you have another trackerpad?"

Bow looks up from his own pad, bewildered. "Um. your majesty?"

"Catra's not the only one who can get around easily." She smiles as she takes the offered tablet from Entrapta. "If all we're doing is

recon, there's no reason for me not to make use of my own skills."

"What are you thinking?" Netossa asks warily.

"Horde Prime has captured many of our key areas. Taking them back, and rescuing the people he's taken, is a priority. And we need a place to start."

Bow is the first one to catch on. "Glimmer."

Angella nods. "As you said, her teleporting is quite useful. If we save her, we have a better chance of taking back the palace, and it will make any trips to Salineas, and anywhere else, much easier."

Mermista crosses her arms, huffing. "Why are you and Catra allowed to do stupid things?"

It's a fair question. "If today goes well, you can set out for Salineas tomorrow. *Just* for recon, however. Do not engage."

"*Fine*."

Catra stops outside the small village, settling on a tree branch and sending a quick message to Bow to let him know she was safe. The same could *not* be said for the village. There were clones swarming the streets, looking down on petrified villagers, guarding all entrances into the village. Catra's claws dig into the bark, a growl building in her throat. It's tempting to throw Angella's orders out and just jump in.

But she's learned her lesson about that. And she doesnt even have She-Ra to help her this time. The reminder is a bitter pill to swallow.

All she can do is watch these people who think their hero has abandoned them, getting pushed around in their own villages by a bunch of Hordak lookalikes. She takes out her tablet and sends another ping to Bow to let him know she's okay.

What now?

They're outnumbered and fighting something *far* larger than they had ever faced. They'd lost some of their strongest fighters to Horde Prime, She-Ra was gone ~~or~~ not gone, but definitely not *here*. And even if she were, Horde Prime has a bounty on her now. She's stuck.

She hates it.

Seeing Glimmer is painful.

Angella hovers, staying well out of sight, but she would know her daughter anywhere. She's almost grateful she can only see the top of Glimmer's head;she can pretend that everything is okay for the moment. She doesn't have to see the horrible, glowing green eyes. It's already taking most of her self control not to swoop in and take Glimmer and fly her away.

She lands beside the Moonstone, resting a hand on it. Glimmer has slightly more power now, but only because Angella lets her. If she could cut Glimmer off completely…

She'd still have magic, a voice in the back of her head reminds her. She's still Micah's daughter, after all. And Shadow Weaver had been teaching her for who knows how long ~~.~~Angella has no idea what Glimmer knows now. ~~.~~Just another reason to hate the woman.

Clones are marching along the grounds, following guards Horde Prime is presumably controlling. Between the guards and Glimmer, he probably knows the palace inside and out. The only other person who *might* know it better is Catra, given the amount of time she's spent wandering the halls and climbing to the roof. It won't give them much of an edge.

Glimmer looks up, and Angella shifts to hide behind the Moonstone, holding her breath. She's far enough up that Glimmer shouldn't be

able to see them, but she can't take chances, either. And she *can't* fight her daughter.

Instead, she waits.

"She *what*?!"

Catra's voice breaks as she half-shrieks, and Bow takes a step back, hands up in a calming gesture. "She's been checking in just like you, and it's *good* to know what's going on, right? If we can take back Bright Moon"—

"Sure, if the *entire royal family* isn't chipped!" Catra throws her hands up in disbelief, storming back toward the entrance. She stops short of stepping out, blowing out a long breath and raking her fingers through her hair. "She's checking in?"

"Every ten minutes. Which you *didn't*, by the way"—

"Ten, fifteen, same thing." Catra waves him off. "Fine. I'll wait for her to get back, you guys just…get some sleep."

She ducks around the moss, stepping out and looking up at the stars. She's never going to get used to that.

"Hey."

Mermista steps out behind her, arms folded across her chest. There's a weariness in her gaze that Catra can relate to. "Hey," Catra replies cautiously.

"I'm…ya know, sorry about earlier. Or whatever."

It's probably the most sincere apology Mermista has ever given anyone. Catra will take it. "I'm sorry, too. Things have been"…

"The worst." Mermista leans against the cliff wall, sighing. "Yeah. And I know you're doing your best."

"My best just isn't good enough."

"*No* , your best just isn't prepared for a crazy alien overlord." Mermista waves a hand above her head. "And everything isn't all on you. This is what the Princess Alliance is for, right?"

"I mean, I don't think it was formed specifically for fighting an alien overlord"…

"Okay , fine, so we adapt." Catra turns fully to look at her . "What?"

"Just not used to you being the optimistic one."

Mermista scoffs. "I'm *not*."

"Uh huh." Catra bites the inside of her cheek to keep from smiling. They stand in silence for a moment, watching the stars. "We ll get Sea Hawk back," she says finally , daring to look at Mermista out of the corner of her eye. She catches a moment of sorrow in the otherwise blank expression.

"We ll get them all back."

A shadow passes over them; they jump, automatically assuming fighting positions as Angella lands in front of them. "I know , I know," she assures them, turning and gathering her hair to uncover her neck. There's nothing there. "You were right. Glimmer's in Bright Moon."

Catra nods, relaxing slightly . "Let' s start with confirming we know where everyone is, and work from there. We're going to fix this."

Taking Back Ground

Chapter Summary

The Rebellion fights back

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

They spend the next few days scoping out various areas, trying to get a feel for what's going on around them. Mermista sneaks into Salineas to confirm that Sea Hawk is leading things there, and Spinnerella sneaks into the Fright Zone, finding Scorpia there. Catra sticks to finding nearby villages, trying to put together the story from the bits of gossip she can gather. Prime's forces are spreading fast, and so is resentment toward the Princess Alliance. There are even mutterings about turning She-Ra over if they find her.

Catra tries extra hard to stay out of sight after she hears that.

"Looks like we were pretty much right," Catra says, leaning over a map of Etheria and placing Bow's handmade figurines as she speaks. "Sea Hawk in Salineas, Scorpia in the Fright Zone, Glimmer in Bright Moon, Micah in Mystacor."

"Frosta is almost certainly in the North," Angella says. "It wouldn't make sense to move her somewhere else."

"That just leaves"…

Catra picks up the Adora figurine, lips pressed thin. "Doesn't matter right now," she says as forcefully as she can, setting it aside. "We need to focus on what we know."

"Taking back Bright Moon first would make the most sense," Netossa points out. She's a constant enabler of letting Catra ignore the Adora

issue. Catra's grateful. "It's basically our home base, and having Glimmer's teleporting would be great."

"Assuming we can get the chip off," Mermista says doubtfully.

"That shouldn't be a problem!" Entrapta pipes up. "Well, theoretically. I obviously won't know for sure until I try."

Angella, rightfully, looks vaguely horrified at the thought of letting Entrapta experiment on her daughter. But *one* of them needs to be the first one. "Bright Moon's not going to be easy," Catra says, returning her attention to the map. "We'll have to figure out their patrols and try to find weak spots in their defenses."

"And then fight Glimmer." Bow's voice is weighed down with emotions Catra tries not to think about.

"Leave that to me," she says simply. "The rest of you focus on taking down the clones."

"You can't take Glimmer alone," Netossa protests. "You should at least have someone as backup."

"It's fine. All I need to do is knock her out, right? Then Entrapta can get the chip off. Easy."

"Fighting Glimmer by yourself. Hard," Bow argues. "You barely got away last time."

"I had a head injury, it wasn't a fair fight."

"And you'll have another if you do this alone," Angella says. "Netossa is right. You need someone with you."

"*Fine*," Catra huffs. "Who wants to beat up Sparkles with me?"

"I'll do it," Bow says without hesitation. Somehow, Catra isn't surprised. It *does* give her an idea, though.

"Do you have any dull tip arrows? Or could you make one?"

Bow tilts his head, thinking for a minute. "I have some regular arrows I could swap the tip out on, yeah. Why?"

"If I can get Glimmer to hold still long enough, do you think you could hit the chip? Maybe it'll be easier if we take *that* out of the equation first." And Catra's claws aren't exactly built for something like that. She'd probably accidentally cut Glimmer's neck open.

"That might work, yeah." A slow grin spreads across Bow's face. "I think I have an idea."

"Great. So me and Bow will go after Glimmer." Catra put their figurines next to Glimmer's. "Everyone else work on taking down the clones."

"That still leaves kind of a big problem," Mermista points out doubtfully. "Even if we drive the clones off and get Glimmer back, how're we going to keep the palace?"

That's a good point. The shielding they'd used had been the combined efforts of Angella, Glimmer, Micah, and Casta. There's no telling how long Glimmer is going to be out of commission once the chip is out. And Casta has her hands full keeping Shadow Weaver contained. Catra throws the masked sorceress a dark look.

"Don't suppose *you* can make yourself useful in any way?"

"Oh, are you asking for *my* help?" Shadow Weaver raises a hand to her chest in mock surprise. "I'm flattered. But no, I'm afraid I don't have the resources for a shield of that magnitude. The risk to my life would be substantial, and since there's no She-Ra to heal me anymore"…

Catra growls, turning fully to face her. "Bold of you to assume I'd waste my energy doing that again."

Shadow Weaver chuckles. "Of course you would, Catra. I know you."

Perfuma grabs Catra's shoulder before she can move to do anything she might regret. "I might be able to use the Moonstone for protecting the palace," Angella says thoughtfully , putting the exchange aside. "But it will require constant focus and attention."

"You can't be on guard twenty-four/seven," Spinnerella says. "That' s unrealistic even by our usual standards."

"If you can maintain it until Glimmer recovers, she and I should be able to create more permanent shielding," Casta speaks up. "I just don't know how long that will take."

"Well, sitting around wonder *what if* isn't going to get us anywhere." Catra steps back from the table, crossing her arms. "It' s not my preferred method of doing things, but we're never going to learn anything if we don't jump in."

"And what will your next step be when this inevitably fails?" Shadow Weaver drawls from her corner. Catra turns to glare at her.

"I don't know . But it'll involve sacrificing you somehow ."

"Ignore her ," Angella says firmly . "This is the best plan we have right now. We can't hesitate."

"Yes, by all means, ignore any voice of common sense."

Catra starts toward her, flexing her fingers, claws still sheathed. For now. "Okay , *common sense*. So what would you do? Any plans that don't involve going back in time and drowning me as a baby are welcome."

Much to Catra's surprise, Shadow Weaver laughs. "You still think your existence makes a dif ference in any of this? How charmingly naive."

"She' s literally She-Ra," Mermista deadpans.

"She *was* She-Ra. But that power's gone now, isn't it?" Catra clenches her fists, eyes narrowing. "All any of you have ever known is She-Ra, but *I* know Catra. And I can assure you, her usefulness runs out quickly if she doesn't have the proper motivation. She'll let you down soon enough. It's all she knows how to do."

"You're awfully chatty for a prisoner," Netossa says darkly, standing. She stops when Catra starts laughing. It's a void, humorless sound.

"I'm exactly what you made me," she informs Shadow Weaver coldly. "I'm also the one who could you slit your throat open and leave you dying on the ground, and no one here would even offer you a fucking band-aid. *I* can fight without magic. When was the last time *you* tried to throw a punch?" Silence. "Exactly. So unless you're volunteering to walk into Bright Moon and take everyone on yourself, sit down and shut up." She turns her back on the older sorceress, walking back to the table. "Getting the drop on them is going to be hard—there aren't really any good approaching points from the outside."

"An aerial ambush might be good," Netossa points out, grinning at Spinnerella.

"It's a bit roundabout, but I can come in from the ocean," Mermista added.

"That should be enough of a distraction," Catra says, taking a deep breath and putting Shadow Weaver out her mind. "I can lure Glimmer out near the cliffs, if you can find a place to set up," she continued, looking at Bow. "Perfuma, can you back him up?"

"Of course," Perfuma said with a nod.

"And that leaves the rest of us on clone fighting duty," Netossa says. "I like it."

"That's a lot of moving pieces and depends on a lot going right," Angella says slowly, eyeing the map. "If we could find a way to communicate with each other while we're separated"…

"Got you covered!" Entrapta pipes up proudly, surprising all of them. Locks of hair reach out to hand each person a small, round device. "Just put it in your ear and you'll be able to hear everything everyone says. I can coordinate communication from here and make sure nothing gets lost."

Catra looks at her ear piece, grimacing. "Great."

"I adjusted the volume on yours," Entrapta assures her. "And they *should* be waterproof and filter out most exterior noise like wind, but I haven't had a chance to fully test them."

Catra blinks. That's...surprisingly thoughtful of Entrapta. No one ever takes her sensitive hearing into consideration.

"As long as it doesn't shock me," Mermista mutters, giving the little ear bud a suspicious glance.

"These are wonderful," Angella assures Entrapta. "Thank you."
Entrapta beams, clearly pleased. "Everyone get some rest. Tomorrow is going to be a long day."

But worth it, hopefully.

This, Catra decides, is the most humiliating moment of her life.

Sure, Angella's carried her before, but that was *different*. Mostly in that Catra had been half corrupted by the portal and wanted to die, and *certainly* hadn't been worried about her dignity.

"I could have walked," she grumbles, resisting the urge to cross her arms and look completely petulant. Angella chuckles.

"No one is judging you, Catra."

She is judging herself. A lot.

They land beside the Moonstone;Catra jumps down, peeking over the edge of the platform, then tapping the ear piece.

"Everyone sound of f."

"*Ive marked where you need to lure Glimmer for me to have the best shot*,"Bow says. "*A bit southeast from where you are* ."

Catra scans the area around her, and sees the arrow sticking out of the ground. Right where she fought Adora during the Battle of Bright Moon. "Got it."

"*Spinny and Iare ready to drop in* ,"Netossa reports.

"*Ready when you are* ,"Mermista says.

"*And Im hearing everyone perfectly* !"Entrapta concludes, sounding thrilled. Catra looks around, frowning.

"I'm not seeing Glimmer . She must be inside."

That made things decidedly more complicated. "I would suggest the throne room,"Angella says. "It seems like a very symbolic gesture. And Horde Prime seems to be all about show."

She isnt wrong. Catra looks around, keying in on a balcony . "Okay ." She nods. "Wait for my signal. Ready?"V arious confirmations of *ready* answer her. She looks back at Angella. "I'm going to get her back."

"*We're* going to get her back,"Angella corrects her gently . "You're not alone here, Catra."

She smiles weakly. "Right."

Catra peeks out again, bracing herself, then launches herself off the platform, landing lightly on the balcony. She immediately takes to the rafters, settling into her familiar pattern of jumping along. The halls are largely empty;she finds a clone here and there, but most of the

forces seem to be focused outside, probably on the lower floors. They aren't expecting an attack from above. Catra smiles grimly to herself. Good. She stops on a rafter to report.

"Not much going on in here. I'm working my way down to the throne room and haven't come across much. I'm guessing what we see outside is what we're looking at."

"*That doesn't mean there aren't nearby forces,*" Netossa points out. True. They haven't had a chance to scope out the entire area, and the woods are impossible to scout even on the best days. Catra arrives at the stairs, pausing to listen for footsteps, then jumps down the entire flight and goes back to the rafters.

"Almost to the throne room. Entrapta, any movement?"

"*Nope. I've been trying to break into Horde Prime's communication system, but it doesn't seem like an external one exists.*"

Catra pauses on a rafter right above the throne room doors. She can just faintly make out the familiar, warm, almost sugary smell of Glimmer's magic. If she isn't here, she's been here *very* recently. She takes a moment to orient herself and map out a path to the spot Bow had picked out. She takes a deep breath, closes her eyes, and nods. "Move on go," she says, muscles coiling as she prepares to launch herself at the door. "Three. Two. One. *Go*."

She jumps, barreling straight into the door and throwing it open.

"Ah, *Catra*. How kind of you to join us."

Catra straightens up, wide-eyed. Glimmer is there, as predicted. But she's not alone. A towering form stands beside her, clad in white. Thick cables masquerading as hair fall down past his shoulders. Vivid green eyes stand out against his pure white skin, with an extra vertical set on the right side, one above the right eye, and one below. His claw-like fingers are splayed at his side. A cruel smile pulls at his lips.

No way. There's no way he's just *here*, standing next to Glimmer. There's no way it's that easy.

"Prime," Catra greets him flatly. "I could say the same thing. Gracing our pathetic planet with your presence? You really shouldn't have."

She darts forward, expecting Glimmer to interfere, or perhaps for Horde Prime to hit her. But neither of those things happen. She lashes out, claws ready—and goes right through the hologram.

Fuck.

Prime chuckles. "This doesn't have to be hard, Catra. You can give up. You can surrender, give me She-Ra, and save all your friends. Save *all* of Etheria."

"What, by letting you stick one of those fucking chips on my neck?" Catra snarls, straightening up. "Pass."

The alien overlord *tsks*. "Why must you insist on making everything so difficult?"

Movement catches Catra's attention, followed by the sound of bells; she ducks, barely avoiding Glimmer's punch. She stumbles back, jumping off the dais and steadying herself. "Come and get me, Sparkles!" she calls, jumping back again. Glimmer teleports, Catra ducks, and she runs out of the room. The distant sound of fighting reaches her ears. Good. The chaos should make it easy to avoid Glimmer but still lead her along. She jumps over Glimmer as she teleports to stand right in her path.

"Give up, Catra," she says in a flat monotone. "You'll be happier in Lord Prime's light."

"Not a chance," Catra snarls, steadying herself on a beam for a moment before jumping back down behind Glimmer. The eyes that meet hers are blank, solid green. It's creepy.

"You dont have a choice."

She teleports, and Catra drops to all fours, running for the closest exit.

They play cat and mouse for awhile, Catra always dodging at the last minute, Glimmer's blows barely missing. They barrel out of the castle, and Catra's eyes fall on the nearest princess.

"Netossa, net!"

Netossa turns, and immediately throws a ball over Catra's shoulder. There's a brief cry behind her as Glimmer goes down. It wont hold her, but itll give Catra a head start. "You okay?" Netossa calls after her.

"Never better," Catra replies over her shoulder. She jumps over two clones trying to block her, hears Glimmer teleporting again, and this time she's too slow; a hand grabs her arm, surprisingly strong fingers gripping her bicep. "Hey Sparkles," she says with a smirk, then grabs Glimmer's hand and bites her arm. It's a low move, but hey, nothing's too low for Catra. She shoves Glimmer back and breaks into a run. "Bow, you have eyes on us?"

"*Yeah.*" Bow sounds nervous. "*You okay?*"

"No time for that, just be ready."

Catra ducks a blast of magic, her ears twitching when she hears Glimmer teleport and reappear behind her. She whirls, ready to try and plead with Glimmer, if she can even hear her, but the princess is faster ~~a~~nother shot of energy throws her harshly to the ground.

"*Try to keep her still*," Bow says in her ear. She grimaces.

"Wow, why didnt *I* think of that?"

She jumps, vaulting over Glimmer's head and landing behind her. She grabs her arm to twist it back, only to have it disappear from her

grasp. "Fucking teleporting"—

Catra ducks around another shot and kicks, managing to hit Glimmer in the chest and knock her back.

"*Don't hurt her*!" Bow's voice cracks. Catra's growls.

"Do *you* want to get out here and fight her, or?"—

She cuts herself off to jump out of the way of another attack. Glimmer disappears and reappears behind her.. "There is no point in fighting. You will all succumb to Lord Prime's light."

"I'd rather die," Catra says without hesitation, taking another swing at Glimmer. But Glimmer is faster;she presses a hand to Catra's chest, and magic immediately rushes through her like fire in her veins. It's a sensation she's far too familiar with.

She vaguely hears Bow calling her name over her screams.

It only lasts a few seconds, but it feels like a lifetime. Catra finally collapses to her knees, shaking and winded, one hand pressed to the ground to keep herself up. Light shines in her peripherals as Glimmer gathers the magic for another attack…

"I'm sorry!"

Catra's not sure why she thinks that will work. It's surprising when nothing happens. She lifts her head to see Glimmer staring blankly at her, not moving. "I'm sorry , Glimmer. Im sorry about everything I said. Im sorry I blamed you for Adora. Im sorry I called you weak. I was so lost in my own crap that I didnt see you were trying to help, and everything I said and did just made things worse. You deserve better than that. I *owe* you better than that. You and Bow are two of the best things that ever happened to me, and I..Im a terrible friend. Ill try to be better . I *want* to be better. If you guys are willing to give me a chance."

She hears the faint *twing* of an arrow loosing half a second before the dummy tip hits the chip in Glimmer's neck. She lets out a brief scream as it sparks, her eyes flickering back to their normal color, and she collapses forward. Catra quickly straightens up to catch her. She's unconscious, but breathing steadily, and the chip is no longer glowing. Catra lets out a relieved breath, letting Glimmer rest in her lap, and looking up to see Bow approaching.

"Bow, I—"

He kneels with her, silencing her with a hand on her shoulder. His gaze flickers briefly to Glimmer before he pulls Catra into a hug. He really does give the best hugs, she thinks as she slides one arm around his neck, hugging him tight, and keeping the other hand on Glimmer's shoulder.

It's late. Angella can easily say this is the most exhausted she's ever been, and that's saying a lot.

Glimmer is sleeping peacefully when the queen slips into the infirmary. Entrapta had assured Angella that the chip removal had gone fine, and there wouldnt be any lasting side effects, apart from some possible memory loss. They didnt know yet how the chips would effect that. Perhaps it would be just as well if she doesnt remember any of this.

Angella stands in the door of Glimmer's room, smiling faintly. Her daughter is home and safe, and she has no doubt that shell be climbing the walls by tomorrow trying to get out and do something. She truly is her father's daughter.

But something is missing, Angella realizes with a frown. She hasnt seen Catra or Bow since they came back with Glimmer, and had assumed they were with her. She looks around the room, her eyes settling on one of the corners. And her lips twitch up in a small smile.

They're on the floor together , Catra's head resting in Bow's lap, mask knocked askew. Bow' s hand is loosely tangled in Catra's hair, and they're both sleeping soundly . Catra looks more at peace than Angella's seen her in months.

The qeen steps back, silently leaving her kids to rest. They deserve this brief respite. She wont do anything to take it away .

Chapter End Notes

Emotional growth!

Gone

Chapter Summary

Things get worse, somehow.

Chapter Notes

Mild content warning for a severe panic attack at the end of the chapter, slightly detailed

"*Guys*!"

Catra jerks awake, ready to attack, as something barrels into her, nearly choking her. She relaxes when she realizes it's just Glimmer, strangling her and Bow as she hugs them tight. They'd fallen asleep on the floor of Glimmer's room. They had saved Glimmer. Right.

"Hey, Sparkles," Catra says with a weary smile, patting her back. She looks at Bow, who grins in return. "What's up?"

"I'm *so sorry.*" Glimmer's voice is tight with horror. "Did I hurt you? Are you okay?"

She pulls back to pat Catra down, checking her for injuries. Catra scoffs. "Like you could ever hurt me."

There are still tears in Glimmer's eyes as she looks them both over. "I...I heard what you said." *Oh*. They're doing this already. Okay. "You're not a bad friend, Catra. You never have been."

"Adora might say otherwise," Catra mutters bitterly.

Glimmer shakes her head. She's half sitting in Bow's and Catra's laps now. "She wouldn't, and if she did, she'd be wrong. You're a great friend, even when you're being annoying and moody." Catra lightly whips her tail to hit Glimmer's arm. "I'm sorry. About

everything. About the Heart and not telling you and calling you a bad She-Ra and...and Shadow W eaver."Catra' s ears twitch, betraying her otherwise apathetic expression. "I'm sorry I ever listened to her . At first I just...I just wanted to save you. I never thought about how it would look to see her...and me...I'm so sorry ."

Catra sighs, pinching the bridge of her nose. "Look, I'm not going to say it's okay, because it's not. Getting involved with Shadow Weaver never ends well for anyone. But I'm not mad. I'm done letting her have any control over me."

Glimmer smiles a small, tentative smile. Nothing is *fixed* quite yet, and they all know it. But it's better. It's a *little* better. Bow gathers both girls in a tight hug;Glimmer throws her arms around him again, and Catra snakes one arm out to brace his back. It'll be better , eventually. They just have to work on it.

"So!"Glimmer pulls away , expression eager . "When can I get out of here?"

"Uh...if Angella has her way , probably two weeks from never."Catra rubs the back of her head. "Do you...I mean, your dad"…

"I know ."Glimmer wilts slightly , staring at the floor. "I...I saw them chipping him. And the others. I tried to fight back, I *really* did"—

"W e believe you,"Bow assures her . A lot had happened recently, but they know Glimmer wouldn't *willingly* try to hurt them. "What happened, exactly?"

Glimmer sighs, crawling out of their laps. "Adora woke me up. Said she saw Catra sneaking out."It' s an unfortunately believable lie. "She knocked me out as soon as we were outside the barrier . Being chipped was weird. I remember things, but also kind of...don't. Like it was a dream. And there's a bunch of green fog all around it"…

Her voice drifts off. She shudders. "Y ou don't have to talk about it"—

"No, it's fine. I just...it was weird. It felt like...like I was connected to something. I could hear so many voices and thoughts. I heard the others, and my dad"…

"And Adora"?

Catra hates the almost pitying look Glimmer gives her. "She...She was really lost in it. I think he's had her for awhile."

"But that doesn't mean we can't get her back!" Bow adds before Catra can even think about spiraling into despair. "Right"?

Glimmer looks uncertain, but she quickly smiles. "Yeah. We'll save her. And everyone else."

Catra almost appreciates the lies.

"So how do I get out of here faster"?

Bow and Catra exchange looks then say, in the same flat voice, "Talk to your mother."

"You can take two days"—

"We don't *have* two days! You weren't—you didn't see"—Glimmer huffs in frustration, trying to find a way to articulate the words. "We don't have two days."

"And the whole point of going after Glimmer was to get the castle back and so we could have teleporting." Mermista pauses, then adds as an afterthought, "And to save Glimmer, obviously. But we have teleporting now and we should *use it*."

Glimmer folds her arms triumphantly, giving Angella a look that clearly said *See?* Angella sighed, folding her hands in her lap. "Okay. Does anyone have a *plan*"?

"Salineas and the Fright Zone," Catra says, leaning forward. "And if we hit the Fright Zone first, they won't be expecting a second attack. I know splitting up right now is risky—"

"Yeah, it is," Netossa says slowly. "So *why* are you suggesting it?"

"Home field advantage. Salineas is rough because of the water, but that's Mermista's home turf, and the Fright Zone is mine. Splitting up to hit the North would be risky because of Frosta, and none of us really know Mystacor—" Casta cleared her throat pointedly, "aside from Castaspella, but we're outnumbered and outpowered there. Salineas and the Fright Zone are the easiest places to start. For teams—"

"Oh, wait!" Bow says happily, digging out the various figurines he's made of the entire Alliance. Catra sighs, but takes them.

"All right, I'm going to the Fright Zone, obviously." She puts her figurine down as she speaks. "Mermista to Salineas. Glimmer, Spinnerella, and Netossa are with you. Bow and Perfuma are with me."

"That's spreading it a little thin, isn't it?" Angella asks, frowning.

"Salineas is going to be harder to cover. Glimmer needs to go for teleportation, and Spinnerella and Netossa are better for outdoor fighting. The Fright Zone is probably just going to be the Forge. I'd cover it alone if I thought you guys would *let* me—"

"Absolutely not."

"Exactly. So the bigger team goes to the bigger place."

"I'll go to the Fright Zone," Entrapta speaks up, surprising them all. "I updated a lot of the security protocols, and Emily can provide back up."

"Um, you're kidding, right?" Catra asks slowly.

"Why would I be kidding?" She sounds legitimately confused, and Catra feels a little bad.

"You're not a fighter, Entrapta. You're support. You stay back and handle background things."

"And usually that's the logical way to go, but this is different," Entrapta argued. "You're not the only one who knows the Forge. I lived in the vents for two days."

So did I, you're not special. That's not exactly a productive thing to say, though. Catra bites it down. "We're already spread thin, there isn't going to be anyone to watch your back"—

"That's easy to solve," Angella says. "I'll go to Salineas, you take one of the Salineas people."

"I—what?" Catra is sure she heard wrong. Angella? Going to *fight*?

"Mom?" Glimmer sounds just as stunned. Everyone is exchanging wide-eyed looks.

"Don't look so surprised. I've been fighting this war since before some of you were born." The queen looks at Castaspella. "I assume you're up to the task of defending the castle while we're gone."

"Oh—yes. I can keep the barriers powered alone. Try not to be gone for too long, though."

Catra sighs. This feels like such a bad idea. "Okay. Netossa, you're coming with us."

She sees the woman shoot an uncertain glance at her wife—they don't split up often, and Catra feels bad. But they'll see each other again. And she doesn't *hate* having one more person for the Fright Zone expedition.

"I don't like this," Glimmer says quietly as the meeting ends, and everyone heads off to get ready.

"It's not the best plan," Catra admits, looking to the ceiling. "But it's the best we can do with what we've got"—

"No, I mean I don't like *us* splitting up."

Oh. Catra looks at Bow, who looks just as uncertain. Of course the two of them don't want to be apart again so soon. She turns away, scrubbing her eyes. *Ugh*. Bow is too human and too easy to drown. Salineas isn't *safe* for him.

"Well, we know the power of *friendship* and a good dummy arrow works on the chips," Catra says after a moment, going for levity. "Worse comes to worse, we just have to rescue Sparkles again."

"Wait—why *me*?"

"You're the damsel in distress. Duh."

Glimmer punches Catra's arm, and she laughs. It feels good. It feels *familiar*.

"You're such a jerk," Glimmer grumbles even as Bow gathers them both into a tight hug. Catra wraps an arm around both of them, taking a deep breath.

"Yup. Total asshole, that's me."

"Emily's not seeing anything up ahead," Entrapta reports, looking up from her screen.

"Same," Catra says, dropping down to join everyone. "The path to the Forge is clear. Which is weird. Feels too much like he wants us to be there."

"This whole thing *could* be a trap," Netossa points out. "I'm not saying let's ditch it, just"…

"Proceed with caution." Catra nods. "Let's go."

She jumps back up to the roof of the building they were hiding behind, jumping to the next roof to keep an eye out. Emily is idling for them near the entrance, buzzing and beeping absentmindedly. "Good girl," Entrapta says proudly, petting the bot. Bow looks up to find Catra, perched on the edge of a roof, staring up at something invisible to his human eyes.

"You see something?" he calls quietly. Catra shakes her head.

"Nothing to worry about. Let's go."

She jumps back to the ground and joins them as they slowly make their way inside. Entrapta's eyes are fixed on her trackerpad as she walks, leaving everyone else to do surveillance and make sure they're safe.

"Where do you think Scorpia would be?" Bow asks Catra. She considers it for a moment, looking ahead.

"Hordak's throne room. I know how to get there, but stay close, this place is—"

There's a low *clink* as something drops down to the floor and bounces in front of them. Catra recognizes the sound before she's even fully registered it.

"Smoke bomb!"

Everyone drops to the floor as smoke explodes into the air, obscuring their vision. Catra raises her head slightly, looking around, and sees a faint shadow standing on the landing above them. It's too small to be Scorpia. And Catra would recognize that stupid ponytail anywhere.

He's trying to bait you, he's trying to lure you in. You're smarter than this. Don't—

"Hey Adora." Catra's voice is almost flat as she straightens up, waving some of the smoke away. The first thing she sees is the vividly glowing eyes. Netossa moves fast, throwing a net ball, but Adora is just a little faster. She launches herself off the railing, staff swinging down. Catra blocks it with her claws. "Find Scorpia," she says over her shoulder. "Entrapta, if you can get some of that updated security to work for us, that"—

She's cut off by Adora grabbing her shirt and dragging her forward, throwing her into a nearby wall. "Cheap move," she mutters, pushing herself up to kneel and level a glare with her friend.

"You would know all about that, wouldn't you?" It's so, so close to their usual banter that it almost *hurts*. A hand clenches around Catra's lungs, making it hard to breathe for a moment.

No. No, it's not Adora. It's Horde Prime using her body, and her memories, and Catra needs to get that damn chip off her neck. She can knock Adora out and drag her to Entrapta, and it'll be fine. Everything will be fine.

"Catra"—

"Go!" she snaps at Bow, Entrapta, and Netossa. "All the way down the hall, take a left." She ducked as Adora swung at her, "then the second right, and it'll be the third door on the right."

The three exchange looks before hurrying off, and Catra returns her full attention to Adora. "Just you and me," she says, slowly backing up as she and Adora circle each other. "I know your new boss is listening – this can all be a lot less painful if you just let Adora go."

Solid white pupils fill the green, and a cruel smile that is completely out of place on Adora's face pulls at her lips. "Oh, will it?" Horde Prime's voice echoes over Adora's. "Do you truly believe you can defeat me?"

"If you stop hiding behind my friends, sure."

"Are you afraid of hurting your friend?" Prime sounds almost amused by the thought. "You Etherians. So *sentimental* and emotional. Doesn't it get tiring? Don't you ever want to just *let go*?"

Catra strikes, diving in and aiming for Adora's left ankle with a closed fist. She'd broken it during training when they were twelve and refused medical treatment for three days. It's a weak spot. And sure enough, Adora lets out a surprised, pained cry as she collapses, the white disappearing from her eyes. She recovers far too fast—Prime is pushing her—pulling a stun baton off her belt. The electricity sizzles in the air, making Catra's fur stand on end as she dodges a hit.

"Adora." Catra hates pleading. Begging. It makes her feel weak. But for Adora? She'll do anything. "I know you're still in there. *Please*. This isn't you."

"Have you ever considered that maybe I'm happier this way?" Adora approaches, baton at her side. "That maybe I'm finally at *peace*? But no, selfish Catra. All you've ever cared about is yourself."

She aims with the stun baton again, and Catra jumps out of the way. "That's... That's not true," she argues, voice weak.

"You let me stay in the portal." Adora ducks as Catra makes a move to grab the baton. "You haven't been able to look me in the eye since I got back." The third blast of electricity hits Catra square in the chest, sending fire through her body, to the tips of her fingers and toes. She collapses to the floor, gasping for breath and trying to blink away the darkness in her vision. "You couldn't even bring yourself to ask what happened in the portal."

Adora is kneeling beside Catra now. She raises her head, getting her elbows under herself so she could push herself. "What. What do you mean *what happened*?" She asks, managing to get to get to her knees. She had assumed Adora had just wandered in an empty wasteland. What else had been there? What else could she have done?

The white floods Adora's eyes again. "It's quite sad." The echo is back as well. "Almost tragic. She lived a perfect life in a dream world, married to you, ready to take over as queen. You even had a *child* together."

Catra stares, denial and disbelief at war in her mind. "You're… You're lying."

"Years and years of a happy life together. You were such a *happy* princess. Everything was truly perfect."

Adora-Prime stands, backing up, eyes never leaving Catra's stunned expression. "But now she'll never have to worry about it. I've *saved* her. Who knows how she would have survived after living such a good life only to come back to *this*. This imperfect world. Her selfish, would-be wife. The *pain*."

There's something behind Adora. Catra's eyes flicker to it for a moment, but the shadow isn't enough to keep her attention. She can barely hear Prime over the sudden ringing in her ears. "You're wrong," is all she can manage to say. Adora-Prime just smiles sweetly.

"Is that so?" Green light glows behind her; Catra sees a clone waiting by a machine. "Then why don't you prove it?"

She steps into the machine. Catra realizes a moment too late what it is, springing forward right as a green barrier goes up, separating them. "*No*!"

"Find her. Find me. And then we can talk."

There's nothing to be done except watch, horrified, as Adora disappears in a flash of light. Catra growls, whirling back to the clone operating the machine and grabbing his throat. "Get this thing going again. Send me after her. *Now*."

"I'm afraid Lord Prime as ordered"—

"I don't *fucking* care about Horde Prime! If you don't get that thing working in the next five seconds, I'll—"

Catra would realize later that the machine had been rigged to explode, that she was never going to get on it, no matter what. But at that moment, all she feels is heat on her back, followed by a concussive force throwing her forward; her head slams against a pole, and she worries for a sickening minute that she's going to throw up or pass out. She does neither, barely clinging to consciousness, and shaking her head until she can look around. The clone is down, eyes blank. The machine is a smoldering mess of bent and twisted metal.

And she's alone.

"It should be the same as Glimmer , give her a little time to sleep and she'll be good as new ."

The others had saved Scorpia. Catra isn't entirely certain about the details. She had tried to listen to Bow's recounting of the tale while Netossa patched up her back, but her head hurt, and nothing stuck. She could barely feel the pain as Netossa disinfected her wounds.

The Salineas group had gotten back not long after, decidedly less successful. It turned out having destructive powers wasn't as easy when the city you're attacking is your own, the people your own. They'd been forced to flee when Sea Hawk started firing a cannon at them.

"This just means we get another chance," Angella says simply as she wrings the water out of her hair. "And we'll learn from our mistakes."

Everyone is gathered in the infirmary, talking. Catra feels like there's a wall between her and them. She can see them, but nothing makes sense. All she hears is Prime's words, over and over.

"*She lived a perfect life in a dream world, married to you, ready to take over as queen. You even had a* child *together. Years and years of a happy life together. Everything was truly perfect.*"

The halls are dark as Catra slips out of the infirmary. Good. She needs space from the light, from the noises. She wanders aimlessly down the hall, hand brushing against the wall as she walks.

Is that what Adora would have wanted if things were different here? Is that the kind of life she'd want to have?

The two of them, together. A family with their *child*. Neither of them needed to be princesses to have *that*.

Is that what she thought about when we talked about taking over the Horde? We could've ruled over everyone and been happy. *What more could we ask for?*

Catra is only vaguely aware that she's stopped, leaning on the wall now, her breath ragged and uneven. *He said years. How many years? How much life did she live? Even if I can save her... what if she hates me for not being* Princess *Catra?*

She slides down the wall, doubling over and holding herself tight as she cries deep, almost painful sobs. How selfish can she be, worrying about if Adora cares about *her* while Adora's life is on the line? Her feelings dont matter . Nothing matters if she cant get Adora back.

You couldn't save her from the portal. How are you supposed to save her from space? You don't even have the sword. You're useless. You're a waste. Everyone is going to die and it's going to be all your—

"Catra? Hey , can you"—

—fault. Shadow Weaver was right—

"Careful, she's don't want—"

The voices flit in and out through the hazy static of her brain. Catra's ears twitch, and she grasps tightly to them, trying to stay above the feelings threatening to drown her.

"She hears us! Catra?" A gentle but firm, warm hand is on her back, running up and down her spine. Another, smaller one is grasping her shoulder.

"Can you breathe?" the other voice asks. She can't, she realizes, some part of her brain startled by the realization. She's curled up on the cold floor, gasping uselessly. Her mask had fallen off or been taken off at some point, and her fingers were tangled in her hair, nails digging into her scalp.

"It's okay. You're okay. Take a breath. Follow my hand. In." The hand goes up her side. "Out." The hand goes down her spine. Bow, Catra realizes. It's Bow. Of course it's Bow. She tries to hold her breath, to reset her breathing, to do *anything*. Eventually, she manages blow out a long, shaking breath. She takes another, and it's not stable, but it's breathing, and that's a start. Feeling is coming back to the rest of her body. Her heart is hammering, her eyes burning, her entire body trembling, and she's lightheaded. Is this dying? This has to be dying. She's going to die, and she's never going to see Adora again, and she's going to let everyone down…

"Help me get her up, it should help."

She knows she's completely dead weight as two sets of hands force her up to sit up. She's pretty sure it's Glimmer she collapses against; her eyes are still squeezed shut, but the faint scent of magic is there.

"It's okay," Glimmer assures her, wrapping her in a soft, careful hug. "We've got you. You're okay."

Bow tugs both of them into a hug, sandwiching Catra between them. All she can do is curl up into them and let the tears fall.

Trying

Chapter Summary

> Angella spends some time with her other kids. Catra dreams. A decision is made.

Chapter Notes

> So you may have noticed the chapter count changed. It's very likely going to change again, because I'm in the middle of writing chapter nine and not even CLOSE to the end. I didn't have a solid idea going in how many chapters this would be, so the chances of it changing at least two more times are very high lol

"He took Adora."

Bow and Glimmer exchange surprised looks over Catra's head. She hasn't spoken since they'd found her, and had been strangely content to just stay in their arms.

"What do you mean?" Bow asks carefully. Catra's shoulders jump as she struggles to keep breathing.

"H-He teleported her out of the Fright Zone. I think she's"… *in space*. She doesn't really have to finish that sentence. "She's gone. I can't help her. I can't help *anyone*. I"—

"Catra," Bow interrupts before she can spiral. "When was the last time you slept?"

She doesn't answer for a long time, which isn't good. "The other night. After we saved Glimmer."

"And before that?" Bow gives her an entire minute before saying, "Okay. You need to sleep."

"I don't have time for"—

"You're not going to be able to help *anyone* if you exhaust yourself." Bow looks at Glimmer for support.

"He's right. You've been through a lot. It's okay to take a break."

Selfish. Weak.

Catra tries to shake the words off. "I...fine." Her voice cracks as she speaks. Glimmer puts a hand on Bow's shoulder, teleporting them all to Catra's room. She knows Catra hates the teleportation, but she definitely isn't up to *walking* right now.

"Up you go," Bow says, helping Catra stand so she can collapse into her bed. Glimmer places the mask on her bedside table, and goes to draw the curtains. "Just let us take care of everything for a bit. We've got this covered."

"Mmph," Catra mumbles into her pillow. She's already half asleep. Good.

"One of us should stay with her," Glimmer says as she walks back to Bow. He nods, turning away.

"You stay. I'll go update the others."

"I can move faster, though, wouldn't it make more sense to"—

"You can get help faster if something happens." Bow's voice is weirdly clipped. It's occurring to Glimmer that this is the first time they've been alone together since...everything. "Just stay put. I'll check in later."

He walks out without another word. Glimmer collapses on the edge of the bed, staring at the doors. "Even *Bow's* mad at me."

"S'fine," Catra mumbles vacantly. "He's slowed to feel too."

"Go to sleep," Glimmer says, petting Catra's head.

"M asleep."

"Of course you are."

Everyone is waiting anxiously when Bow returns to the infirmary. They're already on edge waiting for Scorpia to wake up, and Catra's sudden disappearance had nearly pushed them over.

"Is she?..."

"She's resting," Bow says. "There's a lot going on, and she's pretty sure Adora isn't on Etheria anymore, and I think she just needs a break."

No one can argue with that. "What now?" Spinnerella asks after a moment, looking around. It's appealing to think that everything will just be on hold while Catra sleeps, but there's a still a war outside those walls.

"W e re-gather," Angella says. "It won't hurt anyone to take a break. No one is at their best when they've run themselves into the ground. We have our protection spells around the castle, and everyone here has been checked, so we know there are no chips. We can take a day to relax."

Half the group looks unsettled by the idea of inaction, but the rest looks relieved. "W e can go over taking another shot at Salineas," Netossa says, looking at Mermista. "What we really need is a good ambush point. There are too many citizens to take down all at once, but even if we can just get a few..."

"Bow?" He turns to see Angella approaching him. "Do you happen to know where my wayward daughter is?"

"I left her with Catra. Y a know, make sure she sleeps."

Angella almost looks amused. "And making sure she stays still in the mean time because she won't leave Catra defenseless. Very smart."

"Yeah, well." The words *I know her* die on Bow's tongue. Does he? Because it feels like he doesn't anymore. Working with Shadow Weaver, lashing out at Catra, going behind their backs to activate a dangerous weapon…

Angella's gaze is a *little* too knowing. "Would you mind accompanying me for a walk?"

And, well, it's not like Bow can say *no*. He follows her out of the infirmary and down the hall. The few moments of silence are surprisingly comfortable. "I used to get so angry with Micah," the queen says finally, shaking Bow out of his reverie. "I'd hoped Glimmer wouldn't inherit his stubbornness, but I might have made it worse instead."

She's smiling fondly, if not a little sadly. Bow doesn't know what to say, and so he says nothing. "Micah would have done anything to end the war. He's always been a good person, but he would get so focused on things that he would forget actions have consequences."

"Another thing Glimmer got from him," Bow says before he even really thinks about it. Angella chuckles.

"A little, perhaps. I can't deny that some of her tunnel vision comes from me as well. We all like to think we're making the best choices."

Bow's shoulders fall, his eyes fixed on the floor. "So I shouldn't be mad at her?"

"*Are* you mad at her?"

"No. Yes. A little." Bow shrugs helplessly. "She promised she wouldn't leave me out of anything, and then everything with the Heart happened. And she *planned* it that way. She didn't like letting me and Entrapta go to Beast Island, but she still used the chance to

do what she thought was right. And she *had* to know she was wrong, at least a little, or she wouldn't have hidden it from me."

"You're right," Angella agrees. "And if you're angry with her, that's okay. We fight with the people we love. It's unavoidable sometimes. I've spent a lot of time over the years being angry with Micah for not thinking before running into a battle and getting himself killed. Being mad at Glimmer for breaking her promise is perfectly reasonable. And you're allowed to take time to think about it. It doesn't mean you love her any less."

They stop; Bow's so focused on the meaning of the words that it takes him a moment to realize what Angella just said. He makes a completely undignified noise, head snapping up to meet Angella's gaze. "I. You. What?"

"It's not very subtle, dear." Angella rests a hand on his head, smiling gently. "I'd say I won't tell anyone, but even Micah could tell after watching you and Glimmer for a few minutes that there was something between you two. He approves, for what it's worth. As do I."

Bow opens and closes his mouth a few times, stunned. This is a *lot*. "Take as much time as you need to think. It might not hurt Glimmer to use a little of that time to think over her actions. And I'd like to speak to her as well." She gestures to the door they've stopped in front of—Catra's door. "What better time to do it than when she's trapped?"

"Heh." Bow chuckles weakly. "Try not to wake Catra up."

"I won't raise my voice if she doesn't."

And Bow swears the queen of Bright Moon *winks* at him before disappearing into the room.

Glimmer is lying in the window nook, staring at the sky. This really is comfortable. No wonder Catra sleeps her more than she sleeps in her bed. She'd been restless for nearly five minutes, turning in her sleep and wrapping the blankets around herself so intricately that Glimmer is pretty sure they're going to have to cut her out of it. But she's resting now, breathing deep and even and undisturbed. Good. She needs it.

She hears voices outside the door, and then it opens;she sits up eagerly, hoping it's Bow. It's not.

"Don't look so happy to see me," Angella says, half teasingly, as she closes the door behind her. Glimmer smiles weakly.

"I *am* happy to see you, really."

Angella crosses the room, sitting with Glimmer and wrapping an arm around her shoulders. Glimmer rests her head on her mother's shoulder. "I really messed up," she murmurs, entire body slumping. Angella doesn't say anything;she knows how hard it is for Glimmer to admit that. "I just wanted to do something right. It feels like I'm always messing things up, and everybody else has to take care of it, and I'm useless."

"Glimmer," Angella sighs. "You've never been useless."

"I'm the weakest princess, I don't know how to make plans or lead, I'm not smart like Bow, I—" Glimmer throws her hands up, tears filling her eyes. "I just wanted to *do* something. I—I wanted everyone to look at me they way look at Catra. I wanted *you* to—"

"Oh." Angella squeezes Glimmer tight, keeping her head down to hide her own tears. "I've always been proud of you, Glimmer. I know it frustrates you when I don't let you fight, but it's because I'm scared. The idea of losing you—it's terrifying."

Glimmer blinks a couple of times, surprised. She and her mother have argued before about Angella's unwillingness to take action (or

let Glimmer take action), but *this* is new. New, and a little startling. "You're so *very* much your father's daughter, and I love you for it, but honestly." Angella chuckles softly. "I always said he'd be the death of me. Watching you grow into who you are now has felt similar. And I've never loved either of you less for it."

"Mom"…

Angella finally looks up, letting Glimmer see her cry for the first time. Her mother has always been regal, stoic, larger than life. But now? Now she seems…human.

"I couldn't protect him. I didn't want to make the same mistake with you." She clasps Glimmer's cheeks in her hands and kisses her forehead. "I knew you were too stubborn to be satisfied with inaction, and I thought I was doing my best. I should have realized I was hurting you. I'm sorry."

Glimmer lets out a shuddering breath, then throws her arms around Angella, hugging her tight. Angella gently folds Glimmer into her chest, holding her in a way she hasn't been able to since the first time Glimmer had teleported. She hadn't realized how much distance had come between them. Hadn't realized how much it hurt.

"I love you," Glimmer whispers into Angella's hair. Angella presses a kiss against the top of her head.

"I love you too, dear. And I would appreciate it if you would refrain from doing dangerous things unless absolutely necessary."

Glimmer laughs weakly, wiping her eyes over Angella's shoulder. "I'll do my best."

"That's all I can ask sometimes."

Catra's eyes flutter open.

She's not in her room. Well, she is, but it's not real. She just knows she's dreaming. She uncurls slowly, stretching and looking around. The curtains on her windows are pulled back, revealing a vast darkness outside. She stares out it for a moment before making her way to the door and opening it.

A field is sprawled out before her. Grass tickles her feet a she steps out, a light breeze ruffling her hair. She rubs her eyes, blinking a few times, and then there. In front of her. A light. She takes a few steps forward, uncertainly calling, "*Hello?*"

No answer. Creepy lights in dreams *never* answer. Why had she expected anything different? She grits her teeth and starts forward, eyes fixed on the light the entire time. It's not shaped any particular way but it looks familiar. Her fingers itch to reach out for it.

"I don't *understand*." There's a note of frustration in her tone. "I get that She-Ra wasn't the sword and she's part of the planet, but what does that even *mean*? Was it only First Ones and Magicats because they were the only ones *allowed* to control She-Ra? Would you have picked someone else if you had a choice?"

No answer. She doesn't know why she's trying to reason with this shining light. Or ask questions. She really is desperate.

"Would you have picked someone else if you could? Trust me, I get it. I've never been anyone's first choice. I *know*. You don't have to keep reminding me." Silence. Catra's feet are still carrying her forward, almost automatically. "I wouldn't pick me either. No one would! I'm not a hero. I'm not even a particularly good person! You don't need to stand there and remind me how fucking useless I am!"

She's almost in front of the light now. It should be overwhelming, too bright for her to even keep her eyes open. But it's not. It's gentle. Peaceful. Warm.

"I *tried*." Her voice cracks as she speaks. "I did what I thought was right. I tried to be the hero everyone said I was. I tried to be She-Ra.

I know I failed, but I tried. Isn't that worth *something*? Can it be worth something, just this once?"

The light expands, surrounding Catra. It's familiar, but also not — she had stood in this exact position so many times as Shadow Weaver's shadows rose to close her in, trapping her. But she doesn't feel *trapped* now. She feels good. *Warm*.

"She-Ra has always belonged to Etheria, not the First Ones. Your ancestors understood that. They knew She-Ra wasn't something to be controlled. They knew more about Etheria than the First Ones ever bothered to learn."

Catra raises a hand, fingers grazing the edges of her mask. The sword controlled She-Ra. The mask worked *with* She-Ra. It had allowed her to channel bits of magic even without the sword. The Magicats understood magic in a way the First Ones never had. Maybe because of where they came from. Maybe because they *tried*.

Maybe Catra isn't the problem.

Small orbs of light dance around her. She raises a hand to let them swirl around and in-between her fingers. It tickles. She laughs, bringing her hands together to cup the orbs. *Magic*. It's magic. It's not cruel or judging or cold. It's gentle. It wants to be understood. It *loves*. Tears fill Catra's eyes.

"Okay," she whispers. "I don't know if I deserve this, but... I'll try. I promise I'll try."

The energy around her vibrates, electrifying the air. And she knows that's the right answer. *She'll try*.

Glimmer finds Bow in one of the towers outlining the edge of the castle grounds, wedged between the middle spire and one of the

upward pointing wings. Well, she doesn't *find* him so much as teleport into his lap.

"Whoa!"

"Oops!"

Bow steadies himself as Glimmer quickly disappears and reappears, balancing precariously on the inward curve of the wing. Okay this is probably where Bow comes to be alone and she's kind of invading, she just...really needs to talk to him.

"Glimmer." Bow sighs. "You're supposed to be watching Catra."

"She's been sleeping for like fourteen hours. I think she's fine. And I wanted to talk to you."

Bow looks down at his tracker pad, expression unreadable. "I'm busy."

Busy with *what* is a mystery, and Glimmer is tempted to challenge it. It's not worth it, though. "We're supposed to be taking a break."

"I *was* taking a break," Bow says pointedly. *Away from you*, goes unspoken. Glimmer tries to ignore the hurt that wells up in her.

"Just for a minute?" She feels like she's pleading. "I really want to talk."

"Well, maybe I don't. Did you think of that?" The words catch Glimmer by surprise. They're not mean, just...hard in a way Bow never is. "Maybe I just need time alone right now."

Glimmer's shoulders fall. She ducks her head to hide her tears. "Okay. I'll just..."

She disappears without another word. Bow collapses against the tower, sighing heavily. He knows Glimmer just wants to fix things.

And he does too. He just needs time to think. He wants to do this *right*.

He needs time.

The second time Catra wakes, she knows it's real.

Sunlight is creeping in through a crack in the curtains. It had been night time when she'd collapsed into bed. How long has she slept? Her muscles feel a bit stiff, probably from being curled up for however long it had been. She had a feeling it had been awhile.

It's a bit of a struggle to untangle from the blankets, but Catra manages, tossing them aside and stretching her limbs, flexing her fingers and toes. Apparently the world really didn't end if she took a break. Good to know.

The mask is sitting on her bedside table. She reaches for it uncertainly, and is surprised to find the metal as warm, as if it's been sitting in the sun. Catra swears she sees a flash of gold as she settles it back in place on her head, taking a deep breath. And she raises a hand.

For a minute, she just feels stupid, sitting there staring at her empty hand, waiting for something to happen. She opens and closes her fingers, never looking away. And ~~t~~here! The smallest shimmer of gold sparking between her fingers. She blows out a long, stunned breath, eyes wide. The dream is too vivid in her mind to just be something she made up. Maybe there *is* still something she can do.

"What we really need is a way to fry a lot of chips all at the same time." Netossa looks at Entrapta, who's tinkering with the two chips she's managed to get her hands on. "I don't suppose you've got a way to do that?"

"No," Entrapta admits. "But I'm working on it. It'd be easier if I could get access to some of Horde Prime's tech and see what I'm working with."

"We could ambush one of those spires"—

Netossa stops, looking up from the war table as one door opens, and Catra slides in. Everyone stares at her. She shrugs.

"What're we looking at?"

"Oh. Uh...another go at Salineas. The problem is there's just too many chipped people for us to handle all at once. Even if they're all civilians, they have numbers, and we don't want to hurt them."

"Right." Catra takes her usual seat, crossing her arms on the table and looking at the map. "Can't just drown a kingdom full of innocent people."

There's a small, electrical crackle, and Entrapta makes a noise. "Please don't somehow reactivate it," Angella says nervously.

"Oh, that's not possible. I mean, even if I did, it'd be useless without a host. It's basically a robotic parasite." Entrapta is picking away at it as she speaks. "Just got a bit of a shock. It's like they have built in defense mechanisms."

Catra's eyes fixate on the chip, jaw clenching. *Adora*. Her mind can't help going back to Adora. Under Prime's control for who knows how long. One of those fucking chips in her neck. Prime controlling her.

"*Find her. Find me. And then we can talk.*"

But she can't do that, can she? She can't abandon the entire planet to save one person. Even if she had a way of reaching them — which she *doesn't* — she can't just leave Etheria when they need her most. Even if most of them hate She-Ra. She has a responsibility.

She certainly can't leave now. She promised she'd try. Running away isn't trying. Being *selfish* isn't trying.

"Um"…

Everyone looks at Scorpia as she raises a pincer. She blushes slightly, folding in on herself. "It's just…what about Adora?"

And all eyes go to Catra, who looks down at the table. "There's nothing we can do. We don't have any way of getting to space."

"Of course you do!" Entrapta pipes up. "Bow's been letting me play with that First One's ship from the Crimson Waste. It's old, but I could get it running."

Catra's head snaps back up, eyes wide. *Mara's ship*. Of course. How had she forgotten that? If anyone can get it working, it's Entrapta. They could *go to space*. They could get to Horde Prime. They could save Adora. They could—

Don't be selfish.

"Even if you could, which isn't a guarantee, we don't have that kind of time to waste on one person. We have an entire planet to think about."

Silence falls. Catra looks back at the table, closing her eyes. Adora's lost. She just has to accept that.

"Nope."

The loud declaration throws Catra off. She looks up again, eyes open and swiveling to Netossa, who's standing with her hands on her hips. "W-What?"

"I said *nope*," Netossa repeated pointedly. "That's not an acceptable answer."

"Excuse me"—

"Netty's right," Spinerella said, standing to join her wife. "You're not happy with the idea of leaving Adora behind."

"That—That doesn't matter"—

"Of course your happiness matters!" Perfuma piped up, standing as well. "You're our friend. It matters to all of us."

"Also you've been hardcore moping since the portal," Mermista added, pushing her chair back to stand. "It's kind of bumming me out."

Scorpia looks a bit bewildered, but she stands. "I'm all for saving Adora! I'll do whatever I can to help."

Entrapta has nothing to say. She just stands, her hair unusually still. Catra opens and closes her mouth a few times before managing to say, "What. What are you all"…

"I believe," Angella says gently, pushing herself up, "we're overruling your decision."

"Heck yeah we are." Glimmer immediately joined her mother, with Bow right behind her. "No one gets left behind."

Catra stares at them, then looks around the table. "You. We can't"…

"Too late, we're doing this," Netossa says. "Entrapta, how long do you think that ship will take?"

"No clue," Entrapta says cheerily. "I'd have to start working on it right away and possibly not sleep for several days."

"You should definitely sleep"—

"And I'll need an assistant. Bow, will you help?"

‟What — *whoa*!”Bow yelps as he’ s pulled away by a lock of hair, disappearing out the door with Entrapta. Catra does her best to wipe her eyes without the others noticing;Angella’ s hand on her shoulder tells her she doesnt succeed.

She’s too relieved to care.

Launch

Chapter Summary

Everyone looks for answers

"*Working on some anger management*?

"Shut up," Catra grunts as she lands beside the clone she just punched. "It was too close to the castle."

"*Uh huh*."

"At least I took communication with me."

"*I do have to give you that one,*" Netossa admits. "*Credit for some common sense, I guess*."

"Wow, thanks," Catra grumbles, straightening up. "Bare minimum is the best I can ask for."

She starts back toward the castle, rolling her shoulders. Maybe she's a little restless, but at least she's doing something *productive* and not sitting in Mara's ship pointedly watching Bow and Entrapta.

Anymore.

She's *trying*.

She has to keep telling herself that, because she's driving herself out of her mind. All she can think about is Adora. In space. On that ship. Going through who knows what. She cant think about it. So sometimes she goes out and patrols the woods, and if she finds a clone too close to the perimeter? It goes down. It's a good workout, and it keeps her busy. They should all be grateful for that.

"I wish you'd at least take someone with you," Angella says, frowning. They're in the war room, empty except for the two of them. Catra is lying on the balcony railing, staring at the shimmering dome overhead.

"I move faster alone."

"That doesn't do you much good if you're caught."

"You think I'd get caught?" Catra scoffs, tail swishing lazily. "I'm insulted."

Angella is quiet for a moment before she softly says, "I'm worried you don't care enough for your own life anymore."

And there it is. Catra closes her eyes, letting out a long breath. "It should've been me staying behind in the portal. Not Adora. Everything since then has just been borrowed time."

"That's not true."

"Why did you stop me? Why did you let her go?"

"Because I couldn't hold both of you back at once." Catra frowns, lifting her head slightly and opening her eyes. Angella sighs. "I couldn't let you go. The world needs you, Catra. Not just as She-Ra, but for who *you* are and what you bring to it. And Adora was determined. I'm almost certain she set it up so I'd have to hold you back."

She *had* kneed Catra in the stomach and pushed her back. Catra supposes she can see that. Still. "If I thought I could let go of you to stop her, I would have," Angella continues. "I'd have taken her place without hesitation. You both deserve better."

"Like we've ever gotten what we deserved." Or maybe they had. Maybe *Catra* had. Maybe this has always been what she deserved. Maybe she deserves to hurt. But do the people around her? How is

that fair? How long is it going to *last*? We've grown up with this war. Our entire lives have revolved around it. The universe doesn't care about what we *deserve*."

"No," Angella agrees. "But that doesn't mean nobody else cares."

"Yeah." Catra lowers her head, looking back at the dome. "I know."

That possibly makes it even worse.

"Hmmmn."

Bow looks up from his work, not liking the look on Entrapta's face. "What?" he asks nervously.

"In order to find Prime's ship, I've been tracing the signal from his communication spires." She holds up her tablet. "Buuuuut I can't get a good enough signal to follow it the entire way."

"So we have no way of getting there?" Bow asks, heart sinking. The idea of finding Adora had visibly lightened something in Catra. She's held herself a little higher the last few days, breathing easier. She's impatient but *hopeful*. She can't lose that.

"If I get closer, I should be able to triangulate it," Entrapta says brightly. "We just have to—"

"Get close to one of those spires."

Bow sighs, looking out the window. That's not exactly going to be easy. There's an entire forest and who knows what else between them and the closest spire. Not to mention having to keep track of and protect Entrapta. And it can't be just the two of them. They'll need more help.

"Maybe Glimmer can get us close enough?" Entrapta suggests. It's a thought. They'll still need cover when they're actually *there*, but

having a quick in and out will be good.

"Okay . Well talk to the others later ."

Unsurprisingly, most of the others are unimpressed.

"You want us to get through hundreds of bots and clones and not die long enough to get that signal?" Mermista asks skeptically , looking at Bow, then Entrapta, eyebrow raised.

"I'm in," Catra says immediately , straightening up.

"No, you're not," Bow informs her . She stares at him in disbelief.

"Are you kidding?"

"We need to keep the group small and contained. All of your fighting styles involve getting in someone's face and then ripping it off."

"It's what I'm good at, why change?"

"I'm not saying change," Bow says. "But it's a reason to keep you *here*."

"I'm not *sitting around* while the rest of you"—

"I think it's a good idea," Angella interrupts before Catra can get too far. "You have Glimmer's teleportation, then one or two of the others, and that should be enough."

"Mermista and Perfuma are probably the best choices." Bow already knows his suggestions arent going to be well received, and the look on Mermista's face says everything.

"Why are *we* the best choices for a suicide mission?"

"Water and plants make good cover. Between the two of you, you could probably keep us completely shielded while Entrapta works."

Perfuma curls her fingers together, frowning slightly. "He's not wrong," she says after a moment.

"I *know*." Mermista groans. "I still hate it. And how do we know she's not just leading us to our death?"

Entrapta looks up from her tablet, blinking in surprise. "Me?"

"*Yes*, you. No one else here joined the Horde just for good technology."

Entrapta's hair wilted slightly as she shrank back in her seat. "Hey," Glimmer cut in, frowning. "Lay off. She and Scorpia helped us."

"And fighting with each other isn't going to help," Angella adds. Mermista huffs, looking away.

"*Fine*."

Catra stands, walking out of the room, tail lashing behind her. Bow had known she wouldn't be happy about being left out of this. But it won't kill her to take a break before they launch themselves into space, possibly toward their deaths. He catches Glimmer's eye; she gives him a small, hopeful smile in return. They should really talk.

He really doesn't know what to say.

"Uuuuuuuuuuuuuuuuugh."

Glimmer appears beside Catra, groaning. She looks up from the book she's trying to read. "Hey, be quiet. This is a library."

She's ignored, of course. "Bow hates me," Glimmer laments, dropping into a chair and burying her face in her hands. "I ruined everything."

"He doesn't *hate* you. Do you know how worried he was when you were chipped? It was the perfect chance to punch you, and he told

me not to hurt you."

"*Wow*, thanks," the princess mutters. Catra rolls her eyes.

"I'm just saying. Yeah, he's probably mad, but you've kind of earned that. And clearly he still trusts you if he's letting you help with this stupid mission."

"Are you really that mad you're not going?"

Catra gives up the pretense of reading, lifting her gaze to look at Glimmer. "Sort of. Not *mad*, just it's Adora, you know? I *should* be going."

"You're going to *space*, Catra. That's easily more than enough."

"I *know*, I know." Catra closes her eyes, shoulders hunching up. "It just feels like I keep letting her down."

Glimmer rests a hand on her friend's shoulder, trying to sound reassuring. "You haven't let her down. Not now, not ever."

"You don't know that." Catra can think of plenty of times she had been a terrible friend. Glimmer hadn't been there for their childhood.

"Well, we'll just have to ask her when we save her, won't we?"

Glimmer sounds so optimistic. Catra takes a deep breath, and nods. "Yeah. We will."

Catra waits until she knows the group is gone, and nobody is looking for her, before she slips out onto her balcony, jumping up to balance on the railing. No, she isn't going to try and go after them. That would be stupid. She'd never keep up with Glimmer's teleporting.

She's going to do something stupider.

She jumps down to the next floor, then hops from balcony to balcony until she found the what she was looking for. A mostly empty room, save for a pillar of blue light in the middle. She clenches her fist and steels herself before announcing her presence.

"Shadow Weaver."

The witch is sitting in a cushioned arm chair, and Catra takes some satisfaction from knowing that she is *bored*. She's used to solitude, but she has no idea what's going on around her, and for someone as controlling as Shadow Weaver, that has to be driving her out of her mind.

"Catra." The sickly sweet voice still makes Catra flinch. "To what do I owe the—"

"Save it." Catra walks around to face Shadow Weaver, crossing her arms. "I have questions, and you're going to give me answers."

"And why, pray-tell, would I do *that*?"

"Because I—" Catra knocks on the magic cylinder, "can get you out of this if you play nice."

She can see the war going on in Shadow Weaver's head, even with her face hidden. Shadow Weaver's too prideful to do anything that even *looks* like defeat. But the allure of freedom is too tempting. Catra folds her arms, waiting, unable to keep from smiling smugly.

"What do you want to know?"

Success. "Everything you know about the magicats."

There's a long moment of silence. "You know the stories," Shadow Weaver says finally, neutrally.

"And I know you know more. You found Half Moon. You knew about the connection between the mask and the sword. What else is

there? Did you know She-Ra was a weapon? What the First Ones were doing?"

"You're asking if I was aware that an extinct race of people created a weapon using the planet thousands of years ago?" Shadow Weaver's tone is dry. "Your faith in me is admirable. No, I wasn't aware that the First Ones had created a weapon."

Catra's eyes narrow. There was something there, about the way she said it…

"You knew about the Heart, though."

"I'd heard of its existence, yes. Rumors of all the planet's magic collected in one place? Any sorcerer or sorceress worth their salt would know about it. And before you ask, yes, I suspected it had something to do with why the magicats went into hiding. They were always rather pacifist in their approach to everything."

"How convenient for you," Catra says through gritted teeth. "You've been to Half Moon. Did you ever find anything about their research on Etheria's magic? How they created the mask?"

"I never thought to look. It's not *easy* to get there—one trip was all I could manage. And we both know how that turned out." Catra narrows her eyes, growling. "So dramatic."

"How did you find out about the mask?"

"The same way I find everything—years and years of study. Say what you will, but I come by my knowledge and power honestly."

Honestly. Catra rolls her eyes. Yeah right. "And what made you want it?"

"The *idea* was to use it to tap into some of Etheria's trapped magic. Unfortunately, it would seem the First Ones considered that possibility as well and created a way to block it."

"Then —W ait." Catra takes a step back, blowing out a long breath. "The mask works with She-Ra' s magic, She-Ra's magic is part of Etheria, and Etheria's magic has been trapped by First One technology." She ticks the points of f on her fingers as she speaks. "But I've done it. I've used the magic without turning into She-Ra."

"Another wrinkle I hadn't thought of," Shadow W eaver admits begrudgingly. "I assume it' s because you were the mask's and sword's chosen bearer. Even unconsciously, you have more control. I assume the sword also allowed you some access once it had bonded with you."

Catra nods slowly. It feels like it lines up with so much of what she's figured out on her own. But where does it leave her?

"This was a terrible idea!"

Appearing close to the spire had given the group a *slight* advantage —mostly in that it had allowed them a split second to put up various forms of cover while Entrapta did her best to boost herself higher and get the signal. Glimmer is focused on sniping clones while Bow lets Entrapta stand on his shoulders.

"Just a little bit more"…

Glimmer isn't sure they have time for *just a little bit more* . She peaks through their shield of water and vines, then back at Entrapta, then up to the spire. There's a small platform jutting out about halfway up, maybe…

"I have an idea," she calls over the chaos. "Can you hold out for a few more minutes?"

Mermista groans; Perfuma grimaces. They're both exhausted. "What're you going to do?" Bow asks uncertainly .

"I can get Entrapta up there," Glimmer points up to the platform. "And that should be high enough, right?"

"Should be!" Entrapta agrees cheerily.

"Uh, we can't shield you up there," Mermista reminds Glimmer.

"I know. Entrapta, you ready?"

"Ready!"

Glimmer grabs her hand and teleports up to the platform, immediately drawing a hasty shield as the clones and bots re-aimed.

"Entrapta?"

"It's coming through!" Entrapta nearly squeals in excitement. "Just need to wait...one second...one second"...

"Entrapta!"

"I've got it!"

Glimmer immediately drops the shield and grabs her, teleporting her back to the ground. Entrapta uses a lock of hair to grab Mermista, Perfuma, and Bow, and they all disappear.

She gets them as far as she can, but today's been a workout, and Glimmer is tired. They reappear somewhere in the middle of the Whispering Woods, falling in a heap on each other and groaning.

"Did we do it?" Bow asks, voice muffled by his face being buried in the ground.

"We sure did!" Entrapta bounces a little, holding her tablet up. "Not only did I get the coordinates of his ship, I even intercepted a message!"

"What's the message say?"

Entrapta looks at her tablet, tapping a few buttons. "Oh. Um. It says more forces are being sent. Today."

Great.

"I can't believe you thought talking to her was a good idea."

"Well, it worked didn't it?" Catra grumbles, resting her cheek in her hand. Angella sighs.

"Is any of the information she gave you actually *useful*?"

"I'm not sure yet. I'd have to..." To what? What exactly could she do with everything Shadow Weaver had told her? It wasn't anything ground-breaking. It definitely wasn't going to get She-Ra back. "Okay, I don't know, honestly. But there has to be *something*—"

Her ears twitch at the familiar sound of bells right as the group returns in a shower of sparkles. "Good news and bad news," Glimmer says hurriedly as Mermista and Perfuma collapse into their seats.

"Bad news first."

"Horde Prime is sending more ships. Like, a lot more."

Angella raises an eyebrow. "And what's the good news?"

"We got the coordinates!" Entrapta pipes up happily. "We can go any time!"

"Like *right* now."

"*Now*?" They'd been packing the ship little by little, storing food and water and things they knew they would need, but were they really ready to go?

"Yes, *now,"* Glimmer repeats, emphasizing. "Before Horde Prime realizes what's going on and arranges to shoot us down."

Catra stared for a moment, stunned, before nodding and standing. "There's still some work to do," Entrapta says, working hurriedly on her tablet. "But that shouldn't be anything too difficult."

Mermista lifts her head to look at Entrapta. "Hey, geek princess. Good work."

Entrapta straightens up a bit, eyes bright. "Be careful," Angella says nervously. "Watch out for each other."

"We will," Catra says as Glimmer grabs her arm. "Promise."

And then they've left the war room, reappearing on the deck of the old ship. Entrapta immediately runs to the controls, hitting buttons with far too much confidence. "Everyone grab on to something!"

"That's not reassuring," Glimmer says, fingers tightening around Catra's arm.

"On the plus side, we won't have to worry about Prime shooting us down if we blow ourselves up."

"Not helping."

"Lift off in three...two...one!"

The engines of the ship roar to life; it raises surprisingly fast into the air, knocking Catra, Bow, and Glimmer down in the process. They yelp, and Bow grabs the girls, holding them tight.

"Bow I know you don't want to talk right now." Glimmer rushes to get the words out. They fall back against a wall as the ship accelerates. "But I just need you to know I'm sorry and I don't want to die before I get a chance to apologize. I was stupid, and wrong, and I should have told you everything, and I'm sorry I didn't, and if we live long

enough Im going to do better , I swear! Ill do whatever it takes to earn your trust back, no matter how long it takes."

Catra really wants to be anywhere but stuck with the two of them as Glimmer says all this, but her options of places to go arent plentiful. Entrapta is clinging to the control panel as the ship goes higher and faster. "We're almost through the atmosphere!"She announces. "This is going to be the *really* rough part!"

She's not wrong. The ship shakes and shudders worryingly, as if it's going to fall apart at any second. Catra squeezes her eyes shut, waiting…

And then it's over. She dares to open one eye, and sees Entrapta standing straight up, staring out the window in disbelief. It's dark. Dots of white light up the velvety blue backdrop.

"*We're in space*,"Entrapta whispers in awe. Catra pushes herself up slowly to peek out the closest window.

"Yup, that's definitely space."

Glimmer and Bow stand slowly to join Catra, watching the stars fly by. Bow rests a hand on Glimmer's shoulder. She looks back, relieved to see him smiling just a little.

"Okay ."

Catra walks away from them, letting them have their moment. The ship glides along more or less smoothly, giving them at least a moment of reprieve to prepare for whatever comes next.

We're coming, Adora. Just hang on.

Krytis

Chapter Summary

"I'm not *giving up*. I just wish I could see a way forward." She wishes she could summon She-Ra. She swears sometimes she can feel the flicker of magic, but it's *different*. And it never amounts to much beyond a moment of warmth. "What if we're going to our deaths and leaving Etheria defenseless?"

"We're *not*," Glimmer says firmly. "We're going to get there, and save Adora, and everything is going to be okay."

"That still doesn't." Catra's voice drifts off as a new thought occurs to her. "Entrapta!"

The princess pauses in her attempts to discreetly pull the console apart. "Hmn?"

"Does this thing have like, a map or something? You know, for nearby planets?"

"Of course! The navigation system is extremely detailed, I bet I could find anything."

"Can you find a planet called Krytis?"

Chapter Notes

Two notes:

1) Obviously this isn't the save Adora chapter. I'm sorry! Next chapter, promise
2) The chapter count went up again because they're still in space and I just started writing chapter twelve. It is almost definitely going to go up again. Whoops.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Are we there yet?"

"We *just* left."

"Actually, we left twelve hours, fourty-two minutes, and eight seconds ago...nine...ten"...

"Okay Entrapta, we get it."

Catra huffs, staring out the window with a petulant pout. It turns out putting Glimmer and Catra in a small space together for an extended period of time is a *bad* idea. They probably would have considered that point if they hadn't all by terrified of dying in the launch.

Entrapta is standing at the console, oblivious to the tension, producing snacks from her pockets as she worked. "We still have approximately thirty-eight hours and twenty minutes to go, give or take an hour. Or day."

"Please don't remind them," Bow mutters into his hand. He'd taken up at the captain's chair, watching Glimmer and Catra exchange increasingly sarcastic barbs for ~~a~~ctually, he isn't sure how long it had been, and he certainly isn't going to ask now. Catra's only *just* settled by the window after pacing around and around for hours. "We should all get some rest," he says a little louder, pushing himself out of the seat. "I made sure there were blankets in the bunk room and everything so we can be comfortable."

"I'm not tired," Catra starts to say, but Glimmer is already walking over to her.

"Nope, that's a good idea, we can sleep a little and...and"...

She's grabbed Catra's arm...and nothing is happening. "Um." She blinks a few times, staring at her feet. "Hello? Magic? We're supposed to be teleporting now."

Nothing. There's silence for a moment, save for Entrapta's tinkering. Then Catra bursts out laughing.

"You can't teleport!" It's possibly the most genuine laugh anyone has heard from her in awhile. Glimmer looks at her hands in distress.

"We must be too far from the Moonstone. I didn't even think of that." She looks between Bow and Catra. "What do I do?"

"Walk?" Catra suggests.

"I *mean* when we get to Horde Prime. I can't fight without magic."

Oh. Another thing they haven't thought of.

"We have time to figure out how to fight him," Catra says, standing. "Come on, Sparkles. Do you even know how to make a fist?"

"Of course I know how to make a fist." Glimmer holds up her fist to demonstrate. Catra sighs, shaking her head.

"Yup, you're going to break your hand. Let's see if we can find you a staff or something to swing."

She heads to the door, listening for Glimmer to follow. The princess is clearly downtrodden as she catches up. "Chin up, princess. I've seen you swing a staff. You've actually got some weight behind it."

"I just" She huffs, frustrated. "You guys saved me because my teleportation is useful, and now I can't even do that."

"We didn't save you because your teleportation makes you useful. We saved you because we like you, and no one deserves to live like Prime's zombies."

"Yeah, but"—

Catra turns to look at her, arms folded, one eyebrow raised, the picture of unimpressed. "People aren't measured by how useful they

are. Where do you think I learned that?"

Glimmer pouts, squirming under Catra's intense gaze. "Um. Mom? Bow? Me?"

"So, why would it be any different for you?" Glimmer looks at the floor. "Look, I get it. You feel like you always have to prove yourself, and it's hard to stop thinking like that no matter how much people tell you otherwise. Especially since you let Shadow Weaver get in your head." She pokes Glimmer's forehead for emphasis. "I would've told you that's a terrible idea if you'd asked."

"I *know*"—

"I know you know, which is why this is the part where you say 'Catra you're so smart and so right, thank you for not letting me spiral into some self destructive hate thing.'" Glimmer glares at Catra, but there's no heat behind it. Catra smirks back. "Now come on. We need to find you a big stick to hit people with."

They find a room that could pass for a pathetic armory—most of the stuff is definitely too old to use, but Entrapta will probably enjoy it when they're back on Etheria and safe and don't need this ship to keep them alive. But Catra *does* find a staff for Glimmer.

"No magic, no teleporting." She throws the staff to Glimmer. "This is all you've got to try and take me out with."

Glimmer catches the staff, fingers tightening around it. Catra picks up another one, spinning it lazily. It's been *years* since she's trained with one of these—she'd ditched them in favor of her claws as soon as they moved on from basic training and into sims—but this feels nice. Simple.

"Ready?"

Bow is still on the deck of the ship, yawning and staring at his tracker pad. Catra and Glimmer have been gone for awhile, and that should *probably* worry him. But he hasn't heard any shouting, so it's probably fine. And anyway, the quiet is nice—

Wait. Quiet.

He looks up.

"Uh. Entrapta?"

She's gone. He's alone. That can't be good. The silence suddenly seems menacing. "Oooooooookay, this is probably fine," he says slowly, standing. "Absolutely fine, I'm sure."

The doors slide open in that moment, and Bow hears Catra laughing. He turns just in time to see her jump through the door, using a staff to defend herself from another blow, and jumping into the air.

"Come on, Sparkles, is that the best you can do?" she teases, landing in a crouch on the back of the captain's chair.

"Not even close," Glimmer calls back, running at her, staff raised.

"Stop!"

They both look over in surprise as Bow yells loud enough for his voice to crack. "Uh. . . something wrong?" Catra asks after a minute. Bow feels a vein in his forehead twitch.

"*Yes*, something is wrong. You two are running around swinging weapons on this incredibly old ship that we're depending on to get us to Horde Prime *and* back in one piece. You have to be more careful! And have you seen Entrapta?"

"I think we passed her a few minutes ago." Catra tilts her head, thinking. "She was asking for something."

"A rope, and a blow torch," Glimmer adds, ticking the items off on her fingers. "Not sure why she wanted them, though."

Bow slaps a hand to his face, groaning. "Okay . I'm glad you guys are having fun, but can you maybe do it in a way that *doesn't* involve violence?"

"What fun is that?" Catra asks, balancing her staff on her knees.

"And it's not violence, it's *training*," Glimmer says. "It's a completely different thing"…

Her voice drifts off as her eyes wander to the windshield behind Bow. "What? What's wrong?"

"Um." She points. Bow and Catra turn to see Entrapta floating by in a spacesuit, cackling.

"Hi!"

"Must be what the rope was for ," Catra says. Bow blinks a few times, just staring out the window.

"Entrapta." There's a forced calm in his voice. "What are you doing?"

"Well there were some problems that needed to be fixed on panels outside the ship!" she says excitedly , floating along. "So I made spacesuits for us, and then I fixed the ship from space. where I *am*!"

"Wait, you made spacesuits for us?"

"*Focus,* " Bow says through gritted teeth. "Entrapta, get inside. *Now* ."

"But there's still more work to do!" Entrapta protests, pouting. "Darla needs a *lot* of help."

"I dont – Darla?"

"Yeah, I named the ship Darla. It felt right."

Bow sighs, scrubbing his eyes. "Am I the *only one* who remembers that we're on a barely functioning ship carrying us through the *crushing void of space*?"

"The crushing void of space is all I can think about!" Entrapta calls, giggling maniacally. Bow just stares on in disbelief. "It's *amazing*!"

"Wow," Catra whispers, jumping off the back of the captain's chair. "I don't think I've ever seen Bow turn that color."

"Lord Prime."

He turns to see the small, white-clad figure on her knees in front of him, and smiles. "Come here, little sister. I need your help."

Adora stands, stepping closer. She looks so much better—~~fe~~els so much better—~~no~~w that she no longer has to pretend, to look *different* from Prime. "My drones reported a ship leaving the planet." He indicates the map behind him. "A ship of such ancient design that it is not detectable by my instruments. How can this be?"

He watches as Adora's brows furrow just slightly, trying to recall a memory that is nothing but a dream now. "I don't know, my lord," she finally says. Prime smiles serenely, beckoning for her to come closer.

"I know you would never intentionally lie to me, little sister. But I believe there may be an answer in your past life. If I may?"

He's not asking for permission. He doesn't *need* permission. But his siblings enjoy the illusion of choice, even knowing they don't have it.

"Of course," Adora says, bowing her head. Prime gently presses his hands to her temples, closing his eyes.

t' s hot. The sand feels weird beneath her boots, making it hard to move. They're approaching a large ship;sunlight glints off the sides, making her sqint.

"*Ae you sure this is a good idea?W e don't know what's in there.*"

"*t'll be fine, Scorpia.*" *Ad she' s pretty sure she knows exactly what's in there. O who's in there…*

"Ah," Prime says, arms falling back to his sides. Adora looks up, eyes blank and green. "A First One' s ship. That's qite interesting. Thank you, little sister."

"I'm honored to help, Lord Prime."

"Maybe we should have left her outside."

Catra and Glimmer are sitting on the steps leading up to the captain's chair, having been all but ordered to stay there while Bow tries to keep Entrapta from dismantling *Darla*.

"But there' s so much more that needs to be fixed!"

"Now isn't the time to fix it!"

Glimmer looks at Catra out of the corner of her eye. The magicat is a bit more sedate now, arms crossed on her knees, chin resting on her arms. "Y ou okay?" she asks after a moment. Catra shrugs. "W e're going to save her."

"I know ."

That doesn't sound very believable. Glimmer scoots a little closer , her knee nudging Catra's. "W e *are*. Don't get all depressed before we've even tried."

"I could get us there so much sooner if you would let me just"—

"No!"

"Okay. We're going to save her if we get there alive," Glimmer amends, watching Bow and Entrapta argue. Catra snorts.

"Yeah, that's important too." She closes her eyes, sighing. "I just don't know. We don't even have a plan for getting in, and what are we going to do when we get there? We've barely been beating his clones on Etheria. We can't fight him."

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. "You're giving up already? That's not like you."

"I'm not *giving up*. I just wish I could see a way forward." She wishes she could summon She-Ra. She swears sometimes she can feel the flicker of magic, but it's *different*. And it never amounts to much beyond a moment of warmth. "What if we're going to our deaths and leaving Etheria defenseless?"

"We're *not*," Glimmer says firmly. "We're going to get there, and save Adora, and everything is going to be okay."

"That still doesn't." Catra's voice drifts off as a new thought occurs to her. "Entrapta!"

The princess pauses in her attempts to discreetly pull the console apart. "Hmn?"

"Does this thing have like, a map or something? You know, for nearby planets?"

"Of course! The navigation system is extremely detailed, I bet I could find anything."

"Can you find a planet called Krytis?"

Entrapta tilts her head, and starts tapping away at the console. Bow and Glimmer look at Catra, surprised. "You want to detour? Now?"

"Yes." Catra walks to stand with Entrapta as she works. A screen popped up, flashing a red warning signal.

"There's something here, but it's locked. We need administrator approval."

Great. "How do we get that?" Catra asks, a bit impatiently.

"Well, it's She-Ra's ship, right? And you're She-Ra. Sooooo." A lock of hair pointed to a panel in front of Catra. It's a First One's ship, and there's absolutely no guarantee it's going to work, but Catra puts her hand on the panel anyway. Surprisingly, the screen blinks and turns green, opening a map. "Got it!" Entrapta says happily, tapping away. "It's not far away, but it's definitely off our current course. Probably another day."

Catra bites her lip uncertainly. It's a gamble. She hates the idea of leaving Adora with Prime even a second longer than necessary. But this could be worth it.

"Set a course for Krytis," she says, turning away from the screen. She just has to hope this works.

"Ow, owowowowow, *careful*"—

I *am* being careful. Why is your hair so big?

Entrapta had taken a lot of care in making Catra's space helmet, even including ears. But she hadn't accounted for her hair.

"Ow!"

"There!" Glimmer says triumphantly, standing back and examining Catra. Her head hurts, but the helmet is on, no hair is exposed. And the ear slots are actually comfortable. "Next time just put your hair up or something, yeesh."

Entrapta is bouncing as she waits for the others to finish suiting up. "We're going to see a *real* alien planet!" she says, clapping her hands together.

"There's not much to see," Catra warns her. "It's been abandoned for centuries."

"It's still new!"

"We all ready?" Bow asks. Everyone nods, and he hits the button to open the door.

Kytis looks exactly like it had in Catra's dreams? Visions? Mental visits? The landscape is grey and drab, debris and crumbling buildings surrounding them. "Whoa," Glimmer whispers, looking around. Entrapta is already bounding ahead.

"Hang on, it might be dangerous!"

A wave of faint amusement washes through Catra's mind. *The only danger here might be your friends to themselves*.

Catra jumps, straightening up. Then she grins and hurries ahead, hopping off the cliff they had landed on.

"*Catra*!"

She ignores Bow's distressed cry, continuing forward. *You truly are just like your ancestors*, Melog says as Catra rounds a corner. They're sitting there, perfectly still, like they were just waiting for Catra to come.

"From what I know, that might not be a terrible thing," she says, kneeling and holding a hand out. Melog steps forward confidently, bumping their snout into her palm.

Not at all.

"*Whoa*."

Glimmer, Bow, and Entrapta have caught up. Glimmer and Bow are staring at Melog in disbelief. Entrapta looks ready to burst with excitement.

"Oh my gosh," Bow whispers after a moment. "They're so *cute*."

Melog purrs proudly, tail moving languidly. *You have good friends*.

"Can they understand you?"

Only. My words are only for you.

"What *are* you?" Entrapta asks, walking around Melog, fascinated. Melog mewls, tilting their head to bump Entrapta's outstretched hand. Entrapta squeals. Melog looks quite proud of themself. Catra can practically feel the smugness radiating off of them.

"Shameless."

It has been a very long time since I had company .

Bow has also joined the petting at this point. Catra rolls her eyes, pushing herself up to look around. She imagines this planet could have been beautiful, once. If she focuses hard enough, she can almost see plush grass and large trees and a pink sky overhead. Voices echo, calling and laughing.

Wait. She shakes her head, blinking a few times. She hadn't been imagining that. Melog had been showing her. *My apologies if that was intrusive. But you seemed curious*.

Catra looks at them, and smiles. "It's all right. It was... nice." She reaches to scrub her eyes, then remembers the helmet. Ugh. Getting that off is going to be fun. "I... I need your help with something."

And you're worried I would deny you .

"I mean, I kind of feel like a jerk, coming here to get you just because I need something"…

Melog mewls again, and Catra *swears* they're smiling. *My kind were sworn to protect the magicats. It is only fitting that I continue now.*

Catra nods slowly. They're both the last of their kind, aren't they? It makes sense for them to stick together. And moreover, Catra's *happy* that she's able to keep her word. She had wanted to find Melog, to end their centuries of solitude. She'd wanted to come here someday. The schedule had just shifted a little with the recent changes.

And that's okay.

"What do you think?"

Catra's sitting on the bottom step up to the captain's chair., legs drawn to her chest. Bow and Glimmer had gone to bed, and Entrapta is...somewhere. But Catra can't sleep, so she's watching Melog, who's examining the mask. They sniff it curiously; a blue aura forms around it, lifting it into the air.

I can certainly feel the magicat magic in it. But it is largely foreign. Etherian magic, I assume.

"So magicats could, you know." Catra waves a hand. "Use magic?"

Yes. From what I've gathered, Etheria is extremely similar to Krytis. The magicats lived in tandem with the planet, taking care of it, and in return it gave them power. Eventually, the magic began passing through bloodlines, but everyone was raised with the same lesson. The planet was a living being, and it was up to them ~~-to~~ us ~~-to~~ protect it.

"Can… *I* use magic?"

There is *a sense of power within you, but it is not the same. I assume it is Etheria and She-Ra*, Melog says. *You are several*

generations removed from the last magicats who lived on Kytis. The magic likely waned as time went on.

Catra reaches for the mask, carefully taking it in her grasp and breaking the blue aura. "They really did understand Etheria, huh? The magicats, I mean. They always wanted to work *with* the planet, not against it or try to use it."

It is a lesson they brought with them from Kytis. They knew that magic is alive, not just a tool. It can be manipulated, but it will not be the same.

It could be manipulated. Exactly like the First Ones had done on Etheria. No wonder the magicats broke ties and disappeared – they were probably offended.

"*Ill try . Ipromise Ill try .*"

Can she really be as good as her ancestors were, though? Magic had always been a tool against her – punishment at the hands of Shadow Weaver and the Black Garnet. It's been so hard to trust it. The magicats had been inherently kind of and peaceful. Catra is neither of those things.

Melog nudges her cheek with their snout, making a small noise of disagreement. *You are more than what your past has made you*.

"That doesnt mean Ill be able to actually *do* anything."

True selves show in times of crisis. Judge yourself on how you react then.

Catra looks at the mask again, and sighs. "Yeah. Maybe."

She settles it back on her head, one hand absentmindedly petting Melog. Tomorrow theyll arrive at Prime's ship.

And then..theyll figure out what to do from there.

Chapter End Notes

Nextime - for real, I PROMISE - Save the Blonde!

Save the Blonde

Chapter Summary

Catra finds Adora

Chapter Notes

lezgo

"Is this how you usually treat invited guests?" Catra asks, scof fing, as two clones take her by the arms and tug her down Darla's ramp, into Prime's ship, while more go up the ramp to investigate. "Y ou wont find anyone. Im alone."

"Y ou will be brought before Prime," one of the clones says, pushing her forward. "And there you will receive your judgment."

"Sure." Catra grunts as she stumbles along. "Whatever you say ."

Silence falls over the area as everyone walks away. And Melog drops the cloak of invisibility. "I dont like this," Glimmer says qietly . "What if she gets hurt?"

"W e just need to trust her," Bow says. "Come on. W e dont know how much time we have, and we need to find that server room."

"Im on it!" Entrapta says happily , already making her way off the ship, nose nearly pressed to her trackerpad. Bow and Glimmer sigh before hurrying to follow, with Melog bringing up the rear.

"Y ou will go alone."

Catra glares at the clones, then steps through the open door, walking across the bridge and up the small ramp to Horde Prime's throne.

It's underwhelming and overwhelming at the same time. Catra has already seen Prime in hologram form, and the real thing doesnt differ much. He's sitting in his throne, tubes attached to his head, going back behind him, where clones are working.

"Forgive my unseemly state," Prime says calmly. "It is a tedious task, but a necessary one to maintain this vessel."

Catra's already forgotten him. Her eyes have drifted to another, smaller figure, clad in white and on its knees, a hood pulled over its head. "Ah, yes." There's a hissing noise as Horde Prime is disconnected, allowing him to stand. "I suppose you wont want to waste time. Rise, little sister."

The figure stands, pushing the hood back. Catra's breath catches. It's Adora, as she had suspected, but not *her* Adora. The stranger in front of her has a placated, distant smile, emotionless, solid green eyes, and short blonde hair plastered back against her head.

"*Why don't you just cut it?*" *Catra asks as she watches Adora fuss with her hair.*

"*Because I don't* want *to cut it." She ties it back, examining the ponytail. "I like it long."*

"*You* hate *it long. It gets in your face and your mouth and it's gross."*

"*That's what the hair tie is for. Duh."*

"Hello, Catra."

The vague, slightly too high-pitched voice drags Catra back to the present. She stares at Adora in horror, not even bothering to hide the emotions. There's no point. Prime knew exactly what he was doing. He had set everything up like this on purpose.

"What. What did you *do* to her?" she finally manages to get out, voice cracking. Horde Prime smiles serenely, resting a hand on

Adora's head.

"I brought her to the light and gave her peace. She was *so* conflicted before ~~—so~~ many desires at war with each other, tearing her apart. Now she need not worry. Isn't that right, little sister?"

Catra grits her teeth. *Little sister*. She's going to *kill* him.

"It's true." Adora starts forward. Catra wants to move back, but she feels rooted to the spot. "Lord Prime has *freed* me from the past, from all of it. I'm happy." She reaches both hands out, grabbing Catra's and holding them tight as she brings them up between them. "You can be happy too, Catra. Isn't that all you've ever wanted? To be happy and free?"

Tears sting the back of Catra's eyes. She forces them down, blowing out a breath and yanking her hands back. She looks at Horde Prime, dark fury taking over her expression. "Let. Her. *Go*."

He's still smiling that stupid, smug smile. Catra wants to claw his face off. "Would you really be so selfish as to take away her happiness? Haven't you hurt her enough?" A growl builds in Catra's chest. "Her need to protect you, to *save* you, was overwhelming. You Etherians truly are very emotional, aren't you? Too driven by your *attachments* to one another."

"And you're a higher form of life beyond emotions," Catra snaps. "I get it. What do you *want*?"

Prime nods, almost *approvingly*. "I have something you want. You have something I want. What would you say to a trade? You give me the little trinket on your head. And you can have your Adora."

Catra's hand automatically goes up to touch the mask. "What do you want this for? It's useless."

"I know you've broken the sword. She-Ra may be gone, the mask still contains elements of an old magic. It would be irresponsible of

me to allow that to continue to exist in the world I am creating. You understand, Im sure."

Understand, yes. Agree, *no*. "

Horde Prime sighs. It's such a condescending sound -the kind of sound Shadow Weaver would make right before she scolded them, like they were just stupid kids who couldnt possibly understand what she was going through. "I had hoped you could make this simple. Perhaps your Adora can change your mind?"

Years of fighting Adora -in training and on the battlefield -are the only thing that save Catra from a swift punch. She ducks and jumps away, growling. Adora looks just as serene and distant as she had before, as if she hadnt just tried to attack. "Why do you still struggle, Catra?" The voice makes Catra shudder. "It's time for you to start listening. Well all be happier that way."

Catra clenches her fist, looking into Adora's blank green eyes. "Over my dead body."

It's a challenge. One she's not sure she can follow through on. "If it must be that way," Prime says with a sigh, walking passed Adora and Catra, down the stairs Catra had climbed minutes before. "I'll leave you to get reacquainted. Let me know when you're ready to make a deal."

Catra doesnt look away from Adora;she simply listens to his fading footsteps.

Adora moves, and Catra falls into autopilot, dodging and returning the blow. Adora blocks and reels back to kick Catra, who jumps over her leg. She crouches low and sweeps a leg out, knocking Adora off balance. Catra springs up and tackles her to the ground, one arm bent behind her back. She can see the chip biting into Adora's skin, green veins crawling out across her neck.

"Come on, Adora, I know you're still in there." There's a hint of desperation in her voice. "I don't want to hurt you."

A sickening crack rings through the air as Adora's free arm moves in a way that it definitely *should not move*, grabbing Catra by the back of her shirt and throwing her off. Catra is caught off guard, and doesn't have time recover before she hits the ground with a pained *oof*.

"Don't want to hurt me?" Adora laughs a very low, creepy laugh. Catra looks up to see her already standing over her. "All you've ever *done* is hurt me. All the pain, all the misery, that was because of *you*." She stoops down with surprising grace, grabbing Catra by the hair and dragging her up. Catra let's out a little undignified, pained yelp. "All I wanted was to protect you. And I *suffered* for it."

Catra snarls, grabbing Adora's arm and shoving her away. Adora stumbles back a couple steps, releasing Catra, but otherwise seems unbothered. "But Horde Prime took it all away. I finally know *peace*. Don't you want that as well?"

She's reaching out again – tenderly or to throw another punch, it's hard to tell, but Catra doesn't wait to find out. She knocks Adora's arm away and jumps back, putting some distance between them. "How long do you intend to fight? Aren't you tired of this endless battle you know you'll never win?"

"I'm always tired," Catra says flatly. "But that doesn't mean I'm giving up on myself, *or* you."

She dives at Adora again, trying to tackle her to the ground, but Adora is ready this time; she uses her own weight to keep the momentum going, sending them both rolling along the slick floor. They struggle for a moment before Adora gets the upper hand, pinning Catra's wrists down near her head. "Lord Prime can heal you, Catra. All you have to do is *let go*."

Catra manages to bend her leg and kick Adora in the stomach, abruptly launching her away. Adora will forgive her. Probably.

"I know this isn't what you want," Catra says, panting, as she drags herself up. The faint crackle of electricity hits her ears.

"I have no *wants*," Adora says serenely as she picks herself up. "My desires don't matter. They have no place in the world Lord Prime is creating. He will free us all."

Catra grits her teeth, fingers clenching into fists. Adora jumps forward, and Catra ducks around her punch again. She turns, intending to return it, but Adora catches her by surprise. A hand flies out, grabbing Catra by the shirt, and pushing her back to stand on the very edge of the bridge. Catra yelps, feet sliding uselessly against the smooth floor. She looks up to see Adora smiling a cruel smile, and spots of light fill her solid green eyes.

"She was afraid, you know." Horde Prime's voice echoes under Adora's. "I tried to make it easy, but these bodies are so fragile."

"Let her *go*," Catra growls through her teeth. Adora-Prime chuckles.

"Still so selfish. Why can't you understand that this is for the best?" Horde Prime abruptly fades, leaving Adora. "This is better for *all* of us."

Catra manages to get her footing long enough to surge forward, grabbing Adora and tackling her to the ground once more. And there's a moment ~~-a~~ brief moment ~~-w~~here the chip flickers, and Catra sees Adora's eyes. The stormy blue-gray eyes that Catra had always known. Had loved.

And then they're gone, and Adora shoves Catra away. Catra slides uselessly against the floor before catching herself and straightening up to look at Adora. "No," she says, stumbling up. "I refuse to accept that."

"You've never been very good at listening," Adora comments idly.

"And I'm not going to start now."

An explosion rocks the ship, and they both stumble. Catra looks up, blinking. *What the hell are the others doing?*

Adora tries to take advantage of the distraction; Catra reacts without thinking, catching and shoving her right into a set of glass screens behind the throne. The screens crack, sparks flying. And Adora, weirdly, *laughs*.

"You are only fighting the inevitable," she says, looking up to meet Catra's gaze. "Lord Prime will reign triumphant over all the universe. It is destiny."

Catra's ears twitch as the sound of static fills the room, replaced with the horrifying screech of two bolts of electricity meeting—and Adora screams. The short-circuiting screens had caught the chip, Catra realizes in horror.

"No!"

She closes the space between them in one long step, grabbing Adora and dragging her away. Adora's legs go weak, leaving Catra to carry most of her weight. Catra does her best to hold Adora by the waist, covering her head as the screens start to explode, running away from the flying glass. The aftershock of the explosion sends them both tumbling to the ground.

Catra just lies there for a moment, listening to sparking screens until a new sound cuts through it all. A groan. She sits up quickly. Adora's face is pinched in pain, and when her eyes open... they're blue. Her blue.

"Catra?"

It's her voice. Not the sanitized, flat version, but *her voice*. Pained and confused, and at that moment, the loveliest thing Catra's ever heard. "W -What are you doing here?" Her voice cracks as she speaks. Catra moves without thinking, taking her hand.

"What do you mean what am I doing here?" She tries to inject some humor into her voice. "Do you think I'm going to pass up the chance to hold this over you forever? I flew into *space* on a questionably stable ship just to rescue you from an evil alien overlord. You're *never* going to top that."

Adora laughs weakly, turning her hand to take Catra's;she feels Adora's fingers spasm as the chip kicks in, her eyes flashing back to solid green. And now Adora has her trapped as she reaches out, finding a large piece of glass from the screen explosion. Catra tries to pull away, but it's too late —the shard is buried deep in her shoulder.

Did she just stab me?

Catra falls back for a moment, stunned, as she grabs the shard of glass to pull it out. She hears another crackle of electricity, and Adora screams;she looks up to see Adora stumbling, clasping the chip against her neck. It's damaged. She can fight. She can take back control.

"Hey , Adora!" Catra calls without thinking. She' s too close to that edge, and it makes Catra nervous. "Y ou just gonna let this loser control everything you do? Kinda sad, dont you think?"

Adora stops, entire body trembling;she turns as Catra approaches, eyes flashing back to normal. "That' s a bit low," she shoots back, voice strained, smile brittle, "even for you."

"Nah." Catra' s own smile is hopeful, fragile. "Y ou know nothing's too low for me."

That gets her a small laugh, even as Adora's eyes flash back to green, and she ducks her head. "I'm going to take you home," Catra says, daring to take another step forward. Adora forces herself to look up, eyes normal again.

"Promise?"

A single word. A word their relationship has lived and died on. A word whispered between them so many times, from protecting each other to saving a ration bar for one another. A vow. *Their* vow. To look out for each other.

It's time Catra makes good on that. She nods, holding a hand out. "I promise."

She watches anxiously as Adora raises a shaky arm, reaching out. She's there. She's right there. Just a couple more inches—

The horrible sound of breaking bones echoes in the air, mingling with Adora's pained yell as she stumbles back, gripping her head. After a moment she raises her head with another sickening crack. Her eyes are green, white pupils glowing in the middle.

"Disappointing," Horde Prime declares, voice almost drowning out Adora's. "Some creatures are destined only for destruction."

And then he's gone. The green is gone. Their gazes meet. And electricity explodes out of the chip. Adora screams.

The world feels like it's moving in slow motion. Catra is running forward, already knowing it's too late. Adora's entire body sags, like a puppet whose strings have been cut. And she falls. Right over the edge, into the darkness. Catra misses her by inches.

There's no hesitation, no questioning it. Catra jumps right after her.

"*You're stuck up there, aren't you?*

Catra sticks her tongue out at Adora, rolling her eyes. " No. *I climbed up here on my own, I can get* down *on my own."*

"*Then why don't you come down?" Adora challenges.*

"*Because I don't* want *to."*

"*Oh, because you're stuck."*

Catra growls, standing, and jumps from the piece of machinery she had been sitting on. Adora screeches, half in surprise, half in horror — but Catra lands easily on her feet, straightening up and shoving Adora.

"There. *Happy?"*

"*You* jumped*! And you landed, and you're not hurt!" Adora sounds fascinated. "How far up was that?"*

Catra shrugs, looking back up. "I dunno. Twenty feet?"

"*Do you think you could jump further?"*

They look at each other, and exchange grins.

Sixty feet.

That had been the golden number — or at least, that had been about the time a force captain found them and demanded they do something less life-threatening than continuously jumping from higher places. And *no*, it didn't *matter* that Catra landed on her feet every time.

This must have been more than sixty feet, Catra thinks blearily as her eyes slowly blink open, and she sees the platform overhead. Everything hurts, and she definitely broke at least one bone in her leg, but it doesn't matter. None of it matters except…

Adora.

Catra's head snaps around. Nothing can quite prepare her for the sight of her friend's broken body, laid out across the floor, still. Too still. She looks so small. She looks…

No. Catra tries to push herself up, only to immediately fall over again as pain lances through her legs. *Fine*. She picks herself up the best she can and crawls to Adora, eyes fixed on her the entire time.

"Adora." She barely breathes the name once she's close enough to reach out, to try and find a pulse. They'd learned basic first-aid. She knows how to find a pulse, make a splint out of wood and cloth, and she knows not to move someone who might have a back injury.

The pulse beneath her fingers is thready and weak. Adora lets out a weak, rasping gasp in a desperate attempt to breathe. "No, no, no," Catra whispers, voice shaking. "I've got you, Adora, I've got you, it's going to be okay"…

And, against all the training she had ever been through, she carefully pulls Adora into her arms, cupping the back of her head, letting her rest in her lap. Adora barely reacts.

They'd also been taught how to recognize when it was too late to save someone. Assess and move on if the person can't be helped. There was no time for anything more on the battlefield.

Catra's tears spill over, and she pulls Adora closer, burying her face in Adora's neck. Her scent has been warped by whatever Prime did to her, but Catra can still find it under everything. The familiar, comforting scent that had been Catra's anchor to sanity for so long.

There are footsteps. She knows she's surrounded. She doesn't care. "I am sorry for the needless waste, Catra," one of the clones says in an almost mocking tone of fake concern. "It did not have to be like this. Are you ready to cooperate?"

Catra holds Adora closer, her lower lip trembling. She'll kill him. She'll kill him, and she'll save Adora, and…

"*They knew She-Ra wasn't something to be controlled. They knew more about Etheria than the First Ones ever bothered to learn.*"

"*Even unconsciously, you have more control.*"

There is *a sense of power within you, but it is not the same.*

"*I promise I'll try*."

Something warm fills Catra's chest. Her grip on Adora relaxes slightly as she feels it – the *magic*. It overflows, filling the air around Catra. She lowers Adora, keeping her steady in one arm as she pushes herself up and raises a hand. The mask is glowing brightly, illuminating the dark space and the suddenly fearful face of every clone.

"For the honor of *Grayskull*!"

She feels the hilt of the sword in her hand. It's different – slimmer, *easier* to wield. The transformation is different. It feels natural – less like putting on a costume. Like she's pretending.

It's like this is what she's supposed to be.

The clones get over their shock and attack. Catra pulls Adora closer, making sure she's secure, before she dares to move. The first clone to reach her is kicked, the second elbowed, and two more are taken out with an easy swipe of the sword. It's over before it really begins. They never stood a chance.

Catra approaches one of the clones, kneeling and using the hilt of the sword to tip its head up. White light fills its eyes. The great Lord Prime was listening. *Good*.

"No deal," she says coldly before smashing the end of the sword into the clone's face.

This really couldn't have gone more disastrously wrong if they had tried.

Glimmer, Bow, Entrapta, and Melog skid around a corner, trying to find an escape. Entrapta still has the poor clone they accidentally fried held tight in one of her ponytails.

"More clones!" Glimmer yelps. They're trapped from the front. They're trapped from the back. "What now?"

"We need to get back to the ship."

"How!?"

"Um"…

They look to see Entrapta raising her hand, looking just a *little* sheepish. "I've got an idea, but you have to promise that you won't be mad that I maybe, possibly," she pauses, then quickly rushes out, "One-hundred percent disregarded all those times you told me not to tinker with the ship."

The clones are closing in. Melog snarls, mane flaring red, trying to shield everyone. "Entrapta," Bow says anxiously. "If you get us out of here, you can tinker with the ship as much as you want!"

Entrapta lights up, screeching. "Great! *Hey Darla*!"

She puts her fingers in her mouth and whistles loudly. The world explodes a moment later.

Or that's how it feels, at least, as the ship literally crashes through the ceiling, bringing dust and debris. Melog grows to try and shield them all from *that*. The clones quite literally have no idea what hit them. Darla's ramp extends to meet them.

"Good girl!" Entrapta says happily, starting up into the ship. Glimmer stares, making a few disconnected noises, until she feels Bow's hand on her shoulder.

"We need to find Catra and get out of here, *now*."

Golden light fills the hallway, and a figure steps out on top of a pile of debris. They jump, turning to look in shock

"*She-Ra*," Bow breathes in disbelief. And it *is* She-Ra, there's no denying that, but she looks… *different*. A fully red outfit has replaced the mix of dark colors she wore before, with golden knee and arm bracers, and a golden chest plate with a red jewel in the middle. Her mask is glowing brightly.

"She's back," Glimmer whispers.

They watch, stunned, as the goddess steps down, and notice Adora in her arms for the first time. It takes a moment to recognize her. Catra spares them a brief, small smile before they're interrupted by clones climbing out of the rubble. Bow takes Adora without being asked; he and Glimmer turn to run up the ramp while Catra turns to deal with whoever thinks they really stand a chance in this fight.

"What did he *do* to her?" Glimmer asks quietly as they kneel on the floor of the ship. Bow carefully sets Adora down, a little afraid of breaking her. He doesn't have an answer.

Alarms are blaring overhead, screeching about hull integrity. Makes sense, considering what had just happened. Catra — *She-Ra* — walks passed them, straight to the console, and puts her hand down on the scanner. Everything immediately stops, and the ship hums.

"*Administrator detected. Hello, She-Ra.*"

"Hey, Darla." It's *almost* casual. "Get us out of here."

"*Affirmative.*"

The ship shakes as Darla raises into the air. "And maybe make it quick."

Melog slinks in behind Bow, making a low, worried noise at the state Adora is in. They know how important this particular person is to Catra. Bow raises a hand to gently pet their head. And finally, Catra turns back to them, her eyes zeroing in on Adora. She walks over to kneel with them, gently pulling Adora back into her arms.

"Time to wake up, Adora," she says quietly, moving in so their foreheads meet. "The world isn't ending yet."

The air around them burns bright as energy whirls, enveloping them both. Everyone waits, holding their breath…

The light fades, and it's Catra holding Adora now, watching her anxiously. She's not moving.

It's too late. It's too late, she's too late, she's *always too late*, she can't just do this *one thing* right—

Adora coughs.

A weight lifts off her chest as she watches her best friend grimace, taking a moment to catch her breath and groan before her eyes flutter open. Her normal, wonderful, beautiful blue eyes. Catra nearly laughs. Or cries. It's a little hard to tell.

"Hey Adora."

Adora smiles weakly, tilting her head to rest against Catra's chest and letting out a long breath. "Did you come all the way to space just to save me? You must *really* like me."

"Shut *up,*" Catra scoffs, ignoring the tears filling her eyes. "This was *not* because I like you."

"Mmmm. Feel like the princess club might say different."

Catra wants to say something, to argue playfully, but Adora already looks exhausted. Her eyes are struggling to stay open, her teeth gritted in stubborn determination. And so Catra stays quiet, simply pulling Adora to her chest and hugging her as tight as she can. Adora's immediate response is a surprisingly strong grip as unseen tension drains from her body. She's home.

They're home.

Reality

Chapter Summary

> Adora and Catra navigate several misunderstandings. And create a dozen more along the way .

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's eyes fly open.

She gasps, nails digging into the bed under her —wait. Bed? When was the last time she had felt a *bed*?

Her eyes stay on the ceiling as she carefully probes around with her hands, taking stock of her situation. Definitely in a bed. Under a blanket. There's a light hum in the air. The room is dark, warm, comfortable. She's…

Where *is* she?

A soft shuffling grabs her attention;she slowly , carefully turns her head, and a small smile pulls at her lips. It's Catra, curled up against the wall, cheek resting on her knees as she fidgets in her sleep. She's usually so still in her sleep. Adora wonders what Bright Moon did to her that's turned her restless.

Adora sits up very carefully, mindful of the dull aches and echoes of pain. Catra had said *something* about She-Ra's healing taking away the physical injury but not the pain, but Adora hadn't been entirely coherent. The only thing there'd really been room for in her mind was surprise when Catra easily scooped her up to carry her here.

Catra jerks suddenly, gaze still half-glazed as she lifts her head, blinking rapidly. She stares at Adora for a moment before really

registering anything. "Hey , Adora." The two words sooth Adora in a way nothing else has ever been capable of. Like a call home. "How're you feeling?"

"Um." She runs a hand through her hair . It's not quite as slicked back anymore, and the length is already bothering her. There's no way this is enough for a ponytail, though. "I'm okay ."

Catra snorts, pushing herself up. "You still can't lie worth a damn. What's wrong?"

Adora stares at Catra for a long moment. *What's wrong*. A little bit of everything, honestly. She had been trapped in that dream world for who knows how long, then taken by Prime... how long had it been since she'd really been *herself*? Her fingers rest on the back of her neck. On the chip. She shudders.

"Entrapta will get that off soon," Catra says quickly . "She's just gotta... um, something about the ship. I'm not really sure, you know what she's like."

"Yeah," Adora says quietly . "Do you think she ever sleeps?"

"We've been on this hunk of metal for like four days, and I'm pretty sure she hasn't even closed her eyes."

"That sounds right."

And silence. They both look at the floor, not sure what to say. It's not the comfortable silence they're used to in each other 's presence. They hate it.

"Was... Horde Prime telling the truth?" Catra finally asks, looking up. "About... the portal, and... and us"…

Heat rises in Adora's cheeks. "I- I... um... yeah. Kinda. I mean, yes," she babbles, fingers curling around the sheets. She can't look at

Catra as she speaks. Not that it would matter – Catra's always been better at hiding her feelings. "Yeah. We were... ya know."

"Yeah." Catra's tone is evenly neutral. Adora can't stand the tension.

"Do... Do you think maybe you could ask Entrapta about the chip?" She doesn't *really* care. She's not even sure the thing will actually come out. But *anything* is better than this.

"Oh, yeah." Catra shuffles, hurrying for the door. "Yeah, I'll see if she's... I'll be back in a few, okay?"

"Okay," Adora says quietly, but it doesn't matter. Catra's already out the door. Adora sighs, dropping to lie back on the cot.

We were married. *And now she* knows *about it*.

It had been hard to imagine seeing Catra again – hard to imagine anything when she was trapped on Prime's ship – but Adora had *definitely* never intended to let Catra find out about the portal world. She was probably mortified by the thought. *Them?* Married? It's ridiculous! And Prime had just *told* Catra everything, cruelly, callously, trying to hurt her. And now Catra can't look at Adora.

Tears fill her eyes. She quickly wipes them away, dragging the blanket back up to cover her head.

Catra leans against the wall, claws digging into the metal surface. She hates the sound, but she's barely aware of it at the moment.

It was true. Everything he said was true. She... She spent years *with some* better version *of me, and now she's back, and stuck with* this. *She couldn't even look at me!*

Something gentle brushes against her hand. She looks down to see Melog staring back up at her, mane flowing in different shades of

blue and purple. *You're distressed*. It's not a question. Catra quickly straightens up, running her hands through her hair.

"I'm fine."

There isn't much point in lying to me, Melog points out as they follow Catra through the hall.

"Fine, I'm not fine, but there's nothing anyone can do about it, so there's no point in *talking* about it." Melog chuffs, clearly unimpressed with the answer. "Don't make that noise at me. We've got bigger things to worry about anyway."

The doors to the console room slide open. Entrapta is still plucking away at the console. Bow is in the captain's chair, talking to Glimmer. They stop when they see Catra approaching.

"How's Adora?" Glimmer asks.

"She's all right. She woke up, but I'm sure she's still tired. Kinda wants that chip off, though."

"We need functioning shields," Bow points out.

"I *know*." Catra's reply is snippy. "Does anyone have an ETA on that or anything?"

"Soon, hopefully!" Entrapta calls happily from where she's crawled *into* the console. "Wrong Hordak, blow torch!"

Catra blinks, staring at the clone who's apparently Entrapta's new assistant. "Are...Are we really keeping that?"

"We *did* kind of mess him up," Bow says uncertainly. A screen pops up in front of him, and he looks down. "Entrapta, what does this mean?"

Entrapta pops back up to look. "I dunno, what does it say?"

Catra leans over to get a look at the words, which are in First One's language, of course. "Uh...gearing up for light speed."

"*For what?*" Bow screeches.

"Oops!" Entrapta ducks back under the console. "Just a minute, it's *fine*"…

The pop up disappears. Bow slumps back in the seat. "I dont suppose either of you want to drive."

"Uh"…

"Pass."

Catra goes to sit on the steps, curling in slightly on herself. Melog settles at her feet. "Hey , it's okay." Glimmer joins her , sliding an arm around her shoulders. "Adora's going to be fine"—

"We were engaged."

Bow chokes on air. Glimmer blinks, staring in disbelief. "In the portal world," Catra continues, oblivious to both of them. "It created our perfect world, and apparently that included us getting *married*. And it kept *going* while Adora was stuck there. She...She lived *years* in that dream. We had a kid."

Glimmer and Bow exchange looks. "That's...That's a lot," Bow says after a moment.

"And I was so much *better* in that world. I mean, I was the princess of Half Moon, so it wasnt *totally* perfect, but I was a better person." She's starting to ramble now. "We both had *good* lives, together and apart. I had two moms, and they were great, and they *loved* me. *Adora* loved me."

"Yeah, but...none of that happened."

"But it *did*. It happened for Adora. She lived through it. Years and years of a good life. We were going to be the *queens* of Half Moon. She had *such* a better life there. And now what? She was dragged out of there by Prime, almost died, and she's stuck with *me*."

"The *you* who's her best friend," Bow points out helpfully. "You grew up together, you've known each other your entire lives. It wasn't perfect, but you had each other."

"Exactly!" Glimmer agrees. "Sure, maybe it was a nice dream, but you're still the most important Catra in her life."

Catra's eyes flick between them, and she groans, shoving herself up. "And it's so *messed up* that *this* is what I'm worrying about when she just—when she— *ugh*!"

She kicks the console, ignoring the way Bow squeaks in protest. "Catra and Adora log five," Catra hears Entrapta whispering into her recorder. "The nature of their relationship continues to elude me, although the evidence also continues to suggest"—

"Aren't you supposed to be fixing the ship?" Catra snaps, whirling around. Entrapta's already stopped recording and disappeared. The clone is staring almost adoringly at Catra. "What?" No answer. "Um, okay." Catra backs away. "Are we *seriously* keeping that?"

"It's fine," Bow says reassuringly. "Everything's fine. Adora is fine, and Wrong Hordak is fine"—

"*Wrong Hordak?*"

"And Entrapta is going to fix the ship and get the chip off Adora and we're going to get home and everything will be fine!" Bow's optimism is clearly forced. Catra still appreciates it.

Ager.

The Magicat outwitted him. How dare *she. He will make her hurt.*

And She-Ra. Little Sister's memories had showed they were all convinced She-Ra was gone. This is an interesting development. But it doesn't matter. They won't make it back to Etheria. He'll make sure of that—

Adora's eyes fly open, a scream stuck in her throat, breathing labored. She stares at the ceiling, fingers digging into the mattress. She's fine. She's safe.

An odd mewling noise snaps Adora back to reality. She looks to her left…

"Ah!"

And immediately falls out of bed in her scramble to get away from the strange creature standing at her bedside. It has deep maroon fur and a weird blue mane of energy wavering around its head. Its eyes are the same solid blue.

"W -What are you?" she demands, voice shaking. The creature hops on the bed and glows, shrinking down to more of a cat-sized thing. It jumps down and approaches Adora, nudging her shin with its snout. Adora curls in tighter on herself. "H-How did you get in here? Are you some – some kind of alien? How did you get on the ship?"

It mewls again, half crawling into Adora's lap to lick her cheek. "W ait, *hey*! What *are* you?"

The creature *purrs*, settling into her lap. Adora stares at it for a long moment before carefully reaching out, petting its head once. She jumps a little when she feels a shock of magic. It's freaky, but it doesnt feel *dangerous*.

"Um, okay ," Adora says slowly , scritching the base of its ear. That had always been a good spot for Catra, and apparently this creature

shared that. It trilled, pushing its head into Adora's hand. She laughs a little despite herself. "Well it's nice to meet you. I'm Adora."

They sit in a peaceful silence for a few minutes, Adora losing herself in the rhythm of repeated petting, until the door slides open. "Okay, Entrapta's still working, but oh for fuck's sake, Melog."

Adora looks up, surprised, while the creature just purrs loudly and mewls. Catra blushes a little. "Shut *up*, that's not shut up."

"You can understand it?" Adora asks curiously.

"Yeah, they're um." Catra sits on the edge of the bed, clearly struggling with how to word things. "So, the Magicats came from another planet called Kytis. Melog and their kind were sort of protectors, I guess? They held off Horde Prime while the Magicats escaped, and Melog was the only survivor."

Melog crawls out of Adora's lap, growing a bit as they walk to Catra and rest their head on her knee. She pets them absentmindedly. "I'd met them a few times in visions or dreams or whatever you want to call them, and I knew they were alone, and we needed all the help we could get against Horde Prime, so…"

"You stopped and picked them up." Adora smiles a bit. "You're so soft sometimes."

"I am *not*!" Catra immediately says, straightening up. "Take that back!"

"Why? You don't want anyone to know?" Adora fake gasps. "Do Glimmer and Bow not know that you're secretly the softest person in the universe?"

"That's it," Catra growls, diving at Adora. Adora laughs as she scrambles up, barely dodging.

"Well clearly *someone* has to tell them. I can't believe you've managed to keep up your big old mean act this *entire* time"—

This time Catra catches Adora, shoving her to the floor. They're both laughing as they wrestle for a moment, then yell as Melog decides to join, jumping on top of Catra and squishing them both.

"Melog!"

"Get *off*!"

The ship bucks suddenly, throwing the three of them into a wall. "Ow ," Catra mutters, straightening up and rubbing the back of her head. "What the hell is Entrapta doing?"

A loud *bang* shakes the room again. Catra pushes herself up. "Stay here," she says firmly , looking at Adora and Melog. "I'll be right back."

"Wait"—

Adora reaches for Catra, but she's faster, disappearing out of the room before Adora can get a full word out.

"I thought they couldn't track us!" Bow's voice is almost shrill. Entrapta is working rapidly on her tracker pad.

"They shouldn't be able to, I'm not sure"…

Another laser hits the ship. They all yell, Glimmer clinging to Bow's arm. The door slides open, and Catra stumbles in.

"What's going on?"

"We've got tails." Bow brings up the radar to let Catra see the three ships closing in on them.

"*How*?

"We need cover!" Entrapta calls. "The shields are still damaged, we're not going to be able to take many hits."

"Cover . Great. How do we get cover?" Entrapta's eyes drift to the window, looking at the asteroid field they're floating by. "No," Bow says firmly.

"It's a good place to hide!"

"The ship is falling apart!"

"And it's going to fall apart faster if they keep *shooting us*," Catra cuts in. "Entrapta?"

"I'm on it!"

"Autopilot is still down," Bow reminds Catra. "We're going to have to fly through there *manually*."

"Only one of us," Catra points out. "And you're already in the chair, sooooo...no pressure or anything, but try not to kill us."

"Oh, *thanks.*" It's the closest to sarcasm any of them have ever heard from Bow. He slumps back in the chair, tapping a few buttons on the armrest.

"*Projected course not recommended.*"

"Acknowledged." Like he has any other choice. Computers whir to life as transparent gauntlets wrap around his wrist, screens popping up all around him, and the radar expands to show their current course. He whimpers, doing his best to very carefully steer. Catra makes her way to the closest window, looking out and watching the rocks drift by. Entrapta is practically starry-eyed as she does the same thing.

"Entrapta, the shields?"

"Oh, right." She quickly disappears back into the console.

"See, this is fine," Glimmer says brightly.

"Right." Bow lets out a long breath. "We can just hide out here, and it'll be fine. They won't be able to see us among the asteroids."

He'd barely finished the sentence before another laser strike hit them from behind. They all scream, grabbing the closest thing they can for balance. "Oh!" Entrapta pops back up with her tracker pad. "They can't track the ship, but there's something on the ship sending a signal back to Horde Prime."

"Something?" Catra's eyes widen. "The chip. Adora."

Glimmer's hand moves to the back of her neck. "If he's tracking that, he can follow us anywhere," Entrapta says. "It doesn't matter how well we hide."

"Can you get it off?"

"We still need to fix the shields," Bow reminds Catra in a high-pitched voice.

"*Fine*, can *I* get it off? What if I just like, dig it out of her neck? We've got a first aid kit, right?"

"Um." They all look at Entrapta, who's staring at the floor. "The chips fuse with their hosts' central nervous system. Glimmer's and Scorpia's were easier to remove because they hadn't been chipped as long, but it was still a delicate process."

"And we don't even know how long Adora's been chipped," Glimmer says quietly. Catra growls under her breath, claws digging into her palms.

"So we can't lose them without getting the chip off Adora, and we can't fix the shields if we can't lose the tails, and Entrapta is the only one who can do both things," she summarizes slowly. "What do we do?"

A long moment of silence follows.

"You could probably just give me to them and get away while they're distracted."

Everyone turns to see Adora in the door, Melog slinking behind her. Her eyes are on the floor, left hand clutching her right arm.

"What? No!" Catra protests. "We literally did all of this to save you—"

"And clearly it was a bad idea!" Adora snaps. "You said it yourself, only one thing can get done at a time—"

"So the answer is to just hand you back over to Prime?" Catra demands. "Can you stop with the self-sacrificing bullshit for like *two minutes* and just let us think?"

"Unless you can clone Entrapta—"

"If you *give us a minute* I'm sure we can come up with something. Why are you so dead set on just giving yourself up?"

"Because you never should have saved me!"

Catra's expression falls as she reels back. She tries to argue, but Adora isn't done. "None of this would have happened if you'd just left me in the portal. We never would've been pulled into this place, Horde Prime never would have found you—"

"And you would still be *in the portal*," Catra snarls. "Or would you rather still be in your *dream* than—"

Another shot hits them, throwing them all of balance. "Okay!" Bow yells in a high-pitched voice. "There is *clearly* some stuff that needs to be worked out here, but now is *not* the time! We need an idea that doesn't involve throwing anyone off the ship!"

Melog slips by Adora, surprisingly calm all things considered. *If I may*, they say, sitting and closing their eyes. Magic ripples to life

around them, glowing orbs filling the air. Everyone watches in disbelief as the energy ripples through them, and they slowly disappear.

"Whoa."

Catra looks around, eyes wide. She can still see the others and parts of the ship, but she knows to the outside, they've simply vanished into thin air. She rests a hand on Melog's head, letting out a breath she hadn't realized she'd been holding.

Thank you.

"They can still track the chip," Entrapta points out. "But if they can't see us, all they can really do is take shots and hope they get lucky."

"Then let's hope they don't get lucky." Catra looks at Entrapta, jerking her head. "Come on. Getting the chip off will make it easier to escape."

"Right." Entrapta hurries to the door, grabbing Adora with a lock of hair and dragging her down the hall. Adora lets out a squeak of surprise that's ignored. Catra sighs, turning away.

"You're not going with them?" Glimmer asks.

"No. Adora doesn't want me."

Glimmer stares at Catra for a long moment before crossing the deck, turns Catra to face her, and slaps her. Hard. Right across the cheek.

"*Glimmer*!" Bow protests in disbelief while Catra blinks, staring at Glimmer, opening and closing her mouth, trying to reconcile reality with what had just happened.

"I'm sorry, but *someone* had to do it!" Glimmer throws her hands in the air. "*Adora doesn't want me* – really? Really? *Really*? She *literally* sacrificed her life to save you! She had an entire dream about living a happy life *married to you*! It doesn't matter what

version of you it is. She cares about *you*! So suck it up and go hold her hand while Entrapta takes that chip out of her neck!”

Catra is still just staring. She makes a few incoherent noises before finally walking passed Glimmer and out the door.

“Experiment nine-eight-two part b – removal of an embedded Horde chip.”

Adora sighs. She knows Entrapta records and narrates everything but just this once, she *really* wishes the princess wouldn't.

“This is going to be particularly complicated, as we don't know how long the subject has been chipped, how fused it is with the central nervous system”—

She’s interrupted as the door slides open. Adora looks up, surprised to see Catra there. She doesn't speak;she just walks into the room and sits in front of Adora on the bed, silently reaching for her hands. Adora lets her have them.

Entrapta removes the covering, still narrating, as she carefully picks at wires. Adora winces every now and again, fingers flexing around Catra’s hands. Catra just holds on tighter.

“I don't care about the dream world,” Adora says finally, because if they keep sitting in silence she’s going to lose her mind. Catra looks up, surprised. “I mean, yeah, it was great while I was in it, but it wasn't *us*. And I can't say there’s nothing I would change about the way we grew up because there is… *so much* I would change, but you… I wouldn't change you for anything.”

Relief and disbelief are at war in Catra’s mind. *She’s just saying that. No, she means it. She can’t mean it after seeing how much better of a person you could be. She doesn’t care about any of that.*

“Adora, I”—

The room shakes, Entrapta's hand slips, and Adora lets out a pained yell, one hand flying to her neck. Even Entrapta looks a bit rattled. "I can get it out," she reports nervously. "But not like this. If that happens again I could end up paralyzing her, or worse."

Adora hadn't shown fear often in her life. It was a weakness she couldn't afford. But she looks terrified now. And Catra will do anything to take that away.

She gives Adora's hands one last squeeze before standing and heading for the door. "What're you doing?" Adora asks nervously.

"Making sure we *all* get home safe." She takes a deep breath and closes her eyes, trying to concentrate on that small flicker of energy. Maybe it's selfish, just to call on this power to save her friends. But maybe the magic will allow her a little leeway.

The flicker sparks, then bursts to life, filling the room with golden light. Catra smiles a bit, raising her hand.

"*For the honor of Grayskull*!"

Glimmer and Bow exchange anxious looks as an asteroid right next to them blows up. Horde Prime's scouts could still track them, but without a visual, all they could do was aim and hope for the best. Apparently those were odds they were willing to take.

"We can't just stay in the asteroid field. It's too dangerous."

"We're not in any condition to *move* either."

"But"—

Something flashes by the window. They turn, surprised, and Glimmer runs to the window just in time to see a large figure land on one of the scout ships.

"She-Ra!" Glimmer exclaims happily, laughing.

"What?" Bow calls from the captain's chair. "What's going on?"

Catra drives the sword through the ship and bot, then jumps before it explodes, landing on another one. A third ship bears down on her; she raises her sword, and a glowing beam bursts from the hilt, taking out the incoming ship, then slices through the one she's on and goes to the next, cutting it down.

There are a few more ships coming. It's fine. Catra could do this all day.

Adora's doing her best not to wince noticeably as Entrapta carefully works on the chip, but the last tug makes her yelp.

"Oh, did you feel that?" Entrapta sounds relieved. "Good, then there should be no permanent damage to your nervous system." She drops the chip in a vial, grinning. "And now that the scouts can't track this, I can finish fixing the shields! Everyone wins!"

It's not a pointed comment. Entrapta's too blunt to vaguely dance around a subject. But Adora still blushes, ducking her head. Yeah, okay, maybe *throw me off the ship* had been a *little* dramatic.

"Thanks, Entrapta," she says quietly as the princess heads for the door.

"Of course! Oh." She stops to look at Adora, rocking on her heels. "You probably shouldn't sacrifice yourself anymore. I think it makes Catra sad."

A beat of silence passes. And Adora laughs. Entrapta is rightly bewildered as she takes out her recorder and starts recording. "Catra and Adora log five-a. Every time I think I'm starting to understand them, something else happens that puts me back at the beginning of my research"…

Chapter End Notes

Hahaha so... I've hit my buffer. Chapter 12 is mostly written, but I've got nothing after that, and this fic is probably going to get longer than 15 chapters (IT WAS SUPPOSED TO BE 10). So um... I'm taking the rest of October off to get things in order. This seems like a good place to insert a small hiatus. Two weeks, that's it. If I'm not back on 10/29, it's because the cats have risen up and taken over. Wish me luck

(Reviews might keep them at bay)

ETA: I FORGOT TO LINK THE MAGICA TRA ART: https://crackedfishtank.tumblr.com/post/664534120813199360/smoke-mirrors-magic-catra-au-chapter-10

Magic

Chapter Summary

There's always something ready to go wrong.

Chapter Notes

Back with a new chapter and a new chapter count! And with any luck, that'll be the final chapter count. Who knows

"Adora?"

She looks up from her hands to see Catra standing in the door, watching her with…pity? Sympathy? Something uncharacteristic. "Are you okay?"

I'm fine. Of course I'm fine. I'm always fine .

She's so tired of being fine.

Tears burn in Adora's eyes as she looks away, letting out a shuddering breath. "I-I…um…m-my hair ," is what she manages to stutter after a moment. Catra's eyes immediately light up in understanding. She disappears, returning a minute later with a pair of scissors.

"Move."

She scoots forward so Catra can settle on the bed behind her. The sound of the snipping scissors is soothing.

"You did this for me once," Adora murmurs without thinking. Catra hesitates; Adora can imagine the confusion in her expression.

"What?"

The snipping stops, shaking Adora out of her fog. "Um...in the portal. The portal world, I mean. We were"... *Why can't you just keep your mouth shut?* "We were trying to give Finn a haircut, but they wouldn't let us, so you cut my hair to show them it wouldn't hurt."

Silence, and then the snipping resumes. "Finn, huh? That's a name."

"It was your grandfather's. Lyra's father, I think." The details have gotten a little hazy with time. Not that it really matters. None of it was real. Even if it had felt real at the time.

"Were they cute?" Catra asks. "Finn, I mean. Did we have a cute kid?"

"The cutest." Adora laughs shakily. "Absolutely the most adorable kid in all of Etheria. They had little *ears*, it was adorable."

Catra laughs. "Please tell me they had *your* eyes."

"They did. And my hair." *Snip snip snip*. "It was really floppy though. They always complained about it getting their eyes."

"And you never introduced them to hair ties? I'm *shocked*."

"Their hair never got long enough."

Snip snip snip. "So, were we queens?"

"Almost. The dream ended when Horde Prime took me, I guess." Adora shudders. She *wishes* it had *just* ended. *Snip snip snip*. "A bunch of soldiers invaded the castle and...and killed"...

The snipping stops again as Adora's voice drifts off. Her head feels lighter, neck slightly cold from being exposed, and there are fingers brushing through her hair. "There." Catra offers her a small mirror. "What do you think?"

Adora takes it, turning her head to examine her new haircut. It's *short* ~~a~~ little reminiscent of Scorpia's hair, actually, but a little

messier from Catra's "styling" of it. "I like it," she says after a moment, a small smile pulling at her face – a *real* smile.

"Great, because you're gonna hate this next part. You need new clothes."

"*What*?" Adora demands, looking at Catra in disbelief. "What's wrong with—"

Oh. Right. Her jacket is gone. She wilts a little, eyes drifting to the floor. Catra claps her on the shoulder. "I'm sure we can find something for you that's at least close. Not the jacket, though. That was definitely one of kind and not replaceable."

"Are you *sure* we can't make it back to Etheria without these… crystal things?"

Entrapta nods. "There's a forty-seven percent chance we could make it back, but we wouldn't be able to leave again, and that still leaves the fifty-three percent chance that we could sputter out and die in the void of space."

Well when she puts it like *that*. Bow sighs, scrubbing his eyes. "It's just a quick stop, right?" Glimmer asks, looking between them. She wants to get home too, but she also doesn't want to be stranded in space.

"Quick stop where?" Catra asks, making her way onto the deck. Adora is hovering behind her, looking just a little nervous. She somehow managed to find the closest thing she could to her old uniform – black pants instead of grey, and a white t-shirt.

"Apparently Darla is low on fuel and we need these crystal things if we want to make it back to Etheria."

Catra groans. "Seriously? I'm so sick of space."

"But there's *so much* to explore!" Entrapta says, sounding almost offended.

"Are you making this up so we don't have to go back to Etheria right away?" Catra asks suspiciously. "Also, where's your clone pet?"

"Of course I'm not making this up, and he's in the kitchen. And his name is Wrong Hordak."

There is a *lot* there that needs to be unpacked, and Catra doesn't have the energy for it. "All right, *fine*. Is there somewhere close by we can get these crystals?"

"Yup! I've already got us on course to get there."

"Uh," Adora raises her hand, looking more than a little bewildered. "Wrong Hordak?"

"Don't ask. Just...don't ask."

"*If we can take out the clones and get the citizens rounded up, I can use the Sea Gate to cut Horde Prime off.*"

"Right," Netossa says. She and Spinnerella had come in from the air, while Mermista went by sea. "And then we just wait for Entrapta to get back and get the chips off. Easy."

"What about Sea Hawk?" Spinnerella asks, ignoring the look her wife shoots her. They've all been very careful not to bring up Sea Hawk around Mermista.

"*I have eyes on him*," Mermista says. "*Just leave it to me*."

"Are you sure—"

"*Yes. Move on my signal*."

There’s a crackle as Mermista turns off her earpiece. Netossa and Spinnerella exchange uncertain looks. “What do you think the signal is?”

A funnel of water raises into the air. “I’m guessing that.” Netossa readies a netball. “Let’ s go.”

Mermista swings her trident, bringing the water down on the row of clones guarding the docks. She doesnt know if they can swim, but it wont really matter once they’re swept out to the middle of the ocean. She jumps out of the wave and lands on the now-clear docks. She’d been careful not to hit Sea Hawk, but that meant he’d had time to hide and—

Footsteps echo behind her;she whirls and catches Sea Hawk’ s saber with her trident. The metal weapons meet with a *crash*.

“Hello, my dear Mermista.”

That shakes her just slightly. Sea Hawk’s voice is always *annoyingly* cheerful and loud, not flat and without affect. It’s a poor, mocking imitation. Mermista scoffs, shoving Sea Hawk back. “Please. Is that the best you can do?”

He chuckles. It’s a chilling sound. “Y ou always have underestimated me, my beloved.”

He runs at her again, and again she blocks, but there’s more weight behind the swing this time;Mermista stumbles back a few steps, gritting her teeth. “I’ve always just been a *clown* to you, havent I?” Sea Hawk needles. “A bother? A nuisance?”

Mermista breaks away and swings her trident, bringing water up with it. Sea Hawk blocks the trident, but is still swept to the side by the water. He just laughs again. “Sea Hawk the clown. Sea Hawk the idiot.”

"That's not—" Mermista cuts off, ignoring the tight knot in her chest. It isn't *true*. Sea Hawk knows she doesn't think that. Okay, yes, he's an idiot, but she's never meant it like *that*. He knows that. He *knows* that. Right?

"Not what?" Sea Hawk teases. Mermista swings her trident to meet another blow. "Not true? Is that what you tell yourself to feel better? That you've never *really* meant any of the things you've said? All the times you've thrown me out or degraded me or ignored me? Is that how you show *love*?"

"Shut *up*!" Water rises behind Mermista, bearing down Sea Hawk and throwing him into a nearby wall. The earpiece in her ear beeps. She ignores it. "You don't know what you're talking about."

Sea Hawk laughs again, rising easily, with a weird fluidity that Sea Hawk himself has never possessed. "Of course I know. I have *all* the memories. I see everything."

Mermista's fingers tighten around her trident. "But you're not *him*." Because Sea Hawk knows…

Doesn't he?

"It's okay." Sea Hawk's tone was one of mocking reassurance. "Soon we'll all be under Prime's light, and you won't have to worry about these meddlesome *feelings* anymore."

A net hits Mermista, knocking her back into the water. She doesn't have a chance to yell in surprise before she hits the water.

What the hell, what the hell, what the hell—

She could still see the dock, distorted by the water. Sea Hawk was standing over her, face impassive, with a large number of clones on either side.

The net disappears, and Mermista quickly shifts to her mermaid fin, shooting off away from the docks and toward the surface.

"What the hell?" she snarls as soon as she can talk and turn her ear-piece back on.

"*It was a set up,*" Netossa says. Mermista can hear the wind whistling in the background. "*All the citizens have been evacuated already, from what we could tell. It's just clones.*"

Clones and Sea Hawk. Mermista looks back, eyes narrowed, but they're outnumbered. And she would have known that if she had actually listened to Netossa's attempts to contact her.

"Fine," she grits out after a moment, looking away from her home, her kingdom, her...everything. "*Fine*. Meet you guys back at the castle."

"I think I see a light. I'm gonna go toward it!"

Bow looks up from his tracker pad, alarmed. "Don't go toward the light!"

Catra slaps a hand to her face while Glimmer sighs. "It's not that kind of light," Adora calls back, exasperated.

"Just be careful," Catra says, shaking her head. "Dumbass."

Melog winds around Catra's ankles before jumping down into the crevice, sliding down to meet Adora where she had landed. She jumps, surprised, then laughs.

"Hey, Melog. You and me, then?"

"We'll have to find another way around," Glimmer says, checking their surroundings. Catra is still looking over the edge.

"I could—"

"No," Bow and Glimmer say firmly.

"Adora's through, she's fine," Bow adds. "And Melog is with her. What happens if there's another earthquake and you end up trapped somewhere?"

I will take care of her, Melog adds.

"*Fine*," Catra groans, turning to walk off. Glimmer grabs her and pulls her another direction.

"I think I see a cave this way, let's see where it leads."

Adora takes a deep breath, running one hand through her hair. The other is clinging desperately to her staff. Okay, this is fine. She can do this. She hates how short her hair is. Her neck feels exposed. She swears she can still feel the chip—

No. Focus. She shakes her head once, sharply, steels herself, and starts down the passage. It's fine. This is fine. She's—

A dagger flies past her, barely missing her face, embedding itself in the crystal wall behind her.

Tallstar, Jewelstar, and Starla actually arent that bad, once they stopped trying to hit Adora. And their food is pretty good.

"If he's on your planet, it's already over," Tallstar says dismally. "This place used to be a safe harbor for travelers across the galaxy. Then Horde Prime arrived. Now we're just scavenging the remains. Same as he did to our home world."

Starla cries quietly. Adora lets out a long breath, closing her eyes. Her connection with the hivemind is long gone, but faint memories are still there. She wonders which planet was theirs. Which planet *this* is. Who had lived here. Who had died here.

Melog nudges her should, shaking her out of her reverie in time to hear Tallstar speak again.

"If you're smart, you'll run away . Far, far away. Like we're trying to do."

Adora scowls, saying, "Well, I'm not!" "Wait. "Running away , that is. I *am* smart." Even Melog doesn't buy that. "Traitor. "Never mind. Listen, I *know* it's hard. He's powerful, he seems unstoppable, but he *has* weaknesses."

Tallstar scoffs. "Did you hit your head when you fell?"

Why does everybody ask me that? "No, I'm serious," Adora says, standing. "You're right, he's invading our planet, and he's captured a *lot* of people. I was one of them." That gets her startled looks from all three siblings. She rubs the back of her neck subconsciously. "I know, okay? I really know . It was terrible. It was"…

She blows out a long breath. Melog purrs, brushing against her leg, offering silent support. "But. But my friend, she's strong. She can fight him."

"No one is *that* strong."

"You don't know her . She's the one who saved me. She walked onto Horde Prime's ship and walked right back out again." Maybe. Adora hadn't been conscious for that part. Or possibly alive. She tries not to think too hard about it. She'd been completely unharmed the next time she'd opened her eyes, though. "There are still people out there fighting him. My friend is still fighting him. And I believe in her."

A long silence follows the proclamation. "That's a lot to put on one person," Glowelstar finally says quietly .

"She's not alone. She's got me." And the rest of the princess club, Adora admits begrudgingly. They're not monsters like the Horde had raised her to believe, but they're not complete idiots, either . "Horde

Prime has done a lot of terrible things. And he's going to do a lot *more* if we don't take a stand and stop him."

The siblings exchange looks; Starla wipes the tears from her eyes.

"Adora!"

She turns, relieved, to see Catra, Glimmer, and Bow hurrying out of a nearby hall. Melog immediately lights up, happily encircling Adora's legs right as Catra draws up short and stops, arms wrapping around herself, tail around her waist. A position Adora knows well.

"You um. You okay?"

She's very valiantly ignoring Bow and Glimmer trying not to laugh behind her. "Yeah." Adora smiles. "I'm okay. Why, were you *worried*?"

"Psh!" Catra immediately unwinds and shoves Adora away. "Hell no! You've landed on your head enough, I'm sure you're used to it by now. Anyway, where are these stupid crystals? I want to get out of here."

"Is this your friend? Tallstar asks. "She—"

"Doesn't seem very friendly," Starla finishes. It's Catra's turn to be smug.

"Aaawww, were you *talking* about me, Adora?"

"Just about how annoying you are," Adora shoots back, jumping at Catra to tackle her. They laugh as Adora locks her in a headlock, and Catra tries to shove her away. The Star siblings look at Bow and Glimmer, who shrug.

"Don't ask. I'm Bow, this is Glimmer. Nice to meet you."

Tallstar, Starla, Jewelstar. You too."

"Catra!"

The girls shriek and jump away from Entrapta, who seems to have appeared out of nowhere.

"Okay , how many of you are there?" T allstar demands.

"Several," Entrapta says cheerily . "I came as fast as I could to warn you. Darla's sensors indicate that this planet is a apparently a hotbed of seismic activity."

"No kidding," Catra says dryly .

"Darla and I figured out an algorithm to predict the tremors," the princess continues as if Catra hadn't said anything, tapping away on her tracker pad. "And we're sort of running out of time before the really big one hits. So, are we getting the thulite now or"…

Adora turns to the Star siblings, expression imploring. "Y ou know where the crystals are, and we can help. Please?"

The siblings exchange looks, and finally Sw elstar nods. "Fine. W e need to hurry. Let's go."

Catra gently scratches Melog's head as they walk. "Thank you," she says quietly . Melog trills, bumping their head into her hand.

Those who are important to you are important to me.

They seem particularly attached to Adora. Catra tries not to think too much about it. She's fallen to the back of the group; the Star siblings are leading and bickering, Bow, Glimmer, and Entrapta behind them, Adora immediately in front of Catra, walking in a very familiar way. Back straight, even steps, alert, ready. Adora the soldier. The front she puts on for the rest of the world.

The group stops. "There it is," Sw elstar says, point across the chasm. "That' s the thulite."

"We have to get over that?" Bow asks in disbelief, kneeling and looking down the hole. Starla follows his gaze.

"The chasm is wider than last time we tried. It's getting worse. This whole planet is falling apart."

Catra kneels on Bow's other side, tilting her head. "I could jump it," she says after a moment.

"And do what when you're on the other side?" Bow challenges. "You can't collect the crystals *and* jump back here."

"Says you."

"Another quake is coming!" Entrapta calls.

"What about a bridge?" Adora suggests, pointing to a nearby column. "If we knock this column over during the next quake, we could bridge the gap and get across."

Tallstar nods slowly. "It's risky, but it might work. Everyone, get ready."

They all braced themselves against the column as Entrapta counted down to the next quake. "Three. Two. One!"

The ground shakes, making it easier to send the column crashing to the ground. It just barely lands on the other side.

"Let's do this," Starla says. She, Jewelstar, Bow, and Glimmer jump up on the column, running across as aftershocks run through the cave. They hear cracking crystal; the entrance is starting to cave in.

"No!" Tallstar yells. "That's our only way out!"

Adora braces herself and dives forward, shoving her staff into the space between the caving entrance and the ground.

"I've got her ," Tallstar assures Catra, running to help. Melog also runs over, growing bigger to try and keep the entrance up. Catra looks back at the crystals, then at Adora, Melog, and Tallstar.

"Go!" Adora says, giving her a strained smile. "I doubt that princess can climb half as well as you."

Catra nods hesitantly, running across the column.

Glimmer has actually made pretty good progress, climbing up the rock face and clinging to it when everything starts shaking again. "What's happening!?"

"It won't hold!" Sparkle calls. "We need to turn back!"

"Jump!" Bow adds. "I'll catch you!"

Glimmer looks between them and the pink crystals. "We can't! This is our one shot!"

"Now is *not* the time to be a hero, Sparkles!" Catra yells back. She's halfway across the column, hesitating. How long can Adora, Melog, and Tallstar hold it up? Can Glimmer make it to the crystals?

"Please," Glimmer pleads. "Just trust me. Okay?"

Bow looks back at Catra, then up at Glimmer. He nods.

"Uh oh."

Catra's ear twitch when she hears the utterance. "Uh oh?" Adora repeats, voice hopping up a few octaves as she looks at Entrapta. "What do you mean *uh oh*?"

"Slight hiccup in my calculations. The seismic activity is increasing faster than anticipated."

"What does that mean?" Tallstar demands. Given the way the cave is shaking, Catra has a few guesses.

"We're out of time." Entrapta's voice is frantic. "They need to come back *now,* before this whole place breaks apart!"

Everyone needs help. Everyone is going to get hurt if Catra doesnt *do something*. Glimmer, Bow, and the siblings need to *get back here*, and Adora and Tallstar need help. Catra buries her hands in her hair, growling.

What am I supposed to do?

Trust yourself.

The reply surprises her. She looks up, meeting Melog's gaze. The entrance is collapsing. Adora's staff is cracking. Tallstar's arm falls apart as she collapses to the ground. Catra takes a deep breath, arms dropping to her side as she straightens up. And she jumps from where she's standing, bracing her landing with a hand. Melog does exactly what they need to do without being told; they jump across the chasm to rescue the others.

"Wait, I—"

Adora's words are cut off with a pained yell. Catra jumps into the space Melog left behind, thrusting her arm up to the collapsing rock…

And golden light erupted through the room. The weight disappears from Adora's shoulders, and she collapses, waiting to be crushed. But the feeling never comes. She squints, looking toward the source of light—Catra. Catra, her knees locked, her eyes closed, one arm over her head, a large, glowing shield on her arm. The light fades, and Adora sees that the entire entrance has been crystalized and fixed. *Healed*.

The shield disappears, and Catra falls to her knees, taking a few deep breaths. "Did…Did you know you could do that?" Adora asks uncertainly.

"Nope."

Tallstar is looking at her in disbelief. "Was that magic?"

Melog lands beside them before Catra can answer. "Time to go!" Bow says, voice cracking with stress. Glowelstar reaches out to help his sister onto Melog's back;Entrapta scrambles up, pigtails reaching out to drag Catra and Adora up as they all ran for the exit. They get back out to the surface of the planet right as the cave collapsed in on itself. The Star siblings side off Melog's back, staring at the rocks. Entrapta deposits Catra and Adora, and they straighten up to stare as well.

"Woohoo!"Starla yells, tackling Glowelstar and hugging him tight. "We did it!"

Adora looks at Catra, raising an eyebrow. "Are *all* of the Rebellion's plans improvised like that?"

Catra is silent for a moment before she laughs, falling back to lie on the ground.

"They were *worse* before I joined."

"Thank you for helping us get the fuel,"Glowelstar says as Adora approaches. "You Etherians are so reckless."

"Stubborn,"Starla adds.

"And brave,"Tallstar finishes, her eyes flicking to Catra, who's on the ramp watching Entrapta work. "Magic hasn't been seen in this universe in centuries. But your friend...do you really believe in her?"

Adora's shoulders hunch, her cheeks reddening slightly. But she nods. "She might actually be able to take on Prime. And we want in."

"We've spent our whole lives running away," Jewelstar says. "But not anymore."

"We're going to fight Prime and take back our home," Starla jumps in. Adora smiles.

"Congratulations. I think you're the first people in this universe to join the Rebellion."

They shake hands, and the siblings walk back toward their ship, talking excitedly.

"Sooooooo." Adora jumps as Bow slides an arm around her shoulders. Where did he even come from? The damn princess doesn't have her teleporting! "Does this mean *you're* part of the Rebellion too?"

"You kind of have to be after *that*," Glimmer adds from Adora's other side, grabbing her arm with both hands. They're both smiling wickedly. Adora yelps, jumping away from them.

"How did you two do that?!"

"Magic!"

Catra looks toward the commotion, a small smile pulling at her lips when she sees Bow and Glimmer messing with Adora.

"*Two light stores replenished*," Darla announces. "*Ship refueled*."

"And we're ready to go!" Entrapta says happily, dropping down from wherever she had been working. "Next stop, Etheria!"

"*Finally*." Catra pushes herself up, groaning. "Come on guys, we're getting out of here. Oh." She turns to look at Entrapta. "Where'd your clone go?"

"Clone? I don't have a clone."

"The Horde Prime clone you stole."

"Oooooh, W rong Hordak!" Entrapta beams. "I taught him how to do some maintenance, so he's been taking care of a few small things."

"Y ou're letting him mess with our ship!?"

"He' s qite adept," Entrapta assures her , as if *that* is Catra's biggest worry.

"He' s a Horde clone!"

"But he' s cut off from the hivemind. He's more like Hordak."

"That is *not reassuring*."

"What' s not reassuring?" Glimmer asks as they approach.

"She' s letting the clone do maintenance on the ship!"

Bow and Glimmer exchange slightly concerned looks. Adora looks bewildered.

"It' s *fine*," Entrapta insists. "Come on, Ill show you."

Catra yelps as she's once again manhandled by a lock of hair, and Entrapta drags her along. Wrong Hordak is indeed at the console, tinkering away with a wrench. At least it isnt a welding torch.

"Hello brothers!" he greets them cheerily .

"Hello!" Entrapta says happily . "How are the repairs going?"

"This is weird," Adora whispers behind Catra. She sighs, running a hand through her hair.

"Okay . ust.check after him before we take of f."

She collapses into the captain’s chair, sighing. She is *far* too tired for this. But this is it. Next stop, Etheria.

They’re almost home.

Coming Home

Chapter Summary

One last obstacle

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I don't like this," Castaspella says quietly as she follows Angella down the hall.

"Nor do I," Angella agrees. "But Catra seemed to think she knows something."

"That doesn't make the idea any better."

Angella knows. She sighs, opening the door. She resents that Shadow Weaver gets to sit in here as a prisoner while the rest of them fight a war. She's had it too easy for too long.

"Ah, Angella." The dry voice grates on her. "Castaspella. To what do I owe the pleasure?"

"Catra spoke with you before she left. She seems to think you know more about Etheria's magic than you're letting on."

"Is that right?" Shadow Weaver chuckles. "That's an amazing amount of faith she has in me. I never would have thought—"

"Save it," Castaspella snaps. "I *know* you know more. You always have."

A long silence follows. Shadow Weaver tilts her head thoughtfully. "You never asked the right questions. It was one of the many things that made you a poor student."

"Then what' s the *right qestion* "?

Shadow Weaver stands, looking between them both. "Catra, surprisingly, was on the right track. I suppose she's learned more during her time here than I could ever teach her."Angella bites down a scoff. She knows perfectly well that Catra has always been smart. Shadow Weaver is just a terrible teacher. "There was a disconnect between the First One's approach to magic and the magicats'. Everything we were taught in the Sorcerer's Guild was wrong. The First Ones and their technology didnt *enhance* the planet's magic, it weakened it. The magicats were the ones who tried to work with and enhance the magic."

That seems to line up with what Catra has also been thinking. Angella nods curtly. "Right"…

"The First Ones locked the magic away . They gathered it in the Heart of Etheria. If we could find a way to unleash it"…

"W e could use the magic to fight back,"Casta breathes, eyes wide. Shadow Weaver nods once.

"And why should we believe you wont simply take the magic for yourself"?Angella prompts, crossing her arms. Again, Shadow Weaver takes time to think before she speaks, looking at Castaspella again.

"Y ou never held a candle to Micah's power as a sorcerer."Casta scowls. "Neither did I."That catches both women by surprise."W e all know how dangerous he is now that his magic is controlled by the enemy. We won't be able to stop him. He could do irreparable damage to others. To himself. To his *daughter*."

Angella cant help the small gasp that works its way up her throat. Micah would never forgive himself if he hurt any of them, but especially Glimmer.

"Fine,"Casta says. "Then what do we need to do"?

"I'm afraid it'll involve a little trip."

"You can't be serious," Angella says in disbelief. "After everything you've done, you think we'll—"

"I'll go with her," Casta says, stepping forward and disintegrating the column of magic. "If there's even a chance she's telling the truth…"

Then they have to take it. Angella relents, sighing. "Be careful."

The smile Castaspella gives her is so, so reminiscent of Micah that it almost hurts. "I always am."

"Um. Problem."

Catra drags her gaze away from the ceiling. It's late, or early, or some terrible hour that no one else is awake at ~~all~~ except Entrapta. And Wrong Hordak, standing at the console with her. And Catra in the captain's chair. Even Melog is asleep next to her.

"Problem?" she repeats, standing. "What problem?"

Entrapta taps a few buttons, and a radar screen pops up in front of Catra. She can see a planet not far from their location ~~—~~ a planet surrounded by ships. It doesn't take a genius to figure out what the problem is.

"He has Etheria surrounded." Entrapta nods. "And if we try to go through that, we're going to be slaughtered." Catra presses a hand to her face, letting out a long breath. "Okay. She-Ra can survive in space, maybe I can—"

"Pretty sure even She-Ra can't survive getting shot," Entrapta points out. Catra huffs. She hates it when Entrapta is logical with her.

"Do you think we're in communication range of Etheria?"

Entrapta lights up. "Oh, maybe!" She grabs the communicator she'd left on the console, shoving the antenna at Wrong Hordak to hold up, and tapping away. "It's connecting!"

Catra runs over to stand at her shoulder as the calls connects, and the screen flickers to life, showing a worried Angella.

"*Entrapta? Catra?*"

"It worked!" Entrapta announces with a grin. Catra looks back at Melog, who's starting to stir.

"Melog! Can you get the others?"

"*What's going on?*" Angella asks. Melog slinks out with a telepathic grumble of confirmation, and Catra turns her attention back to the screen. "*Are you all okay?*"

"Yeah, we are. We've got Etheria in sight, but it's surrounded. How's everything there?"

"*Mostly the same, I'm afraid. Salineas has been completely taken by clones. We're not sure where the citizens are now. We still have Bright Moon, though.*" Angella pauses, clearly hesitating. "*Castaspella left with Shadow Weaver yesterday.*"

Catra clenches her jaw, trying not to grit her teeth. "For a good reason, I assume."

"*She says she has answers. Casta thought if there was even a chance she's telling the truth*"…

"She probably does. The *cost* of those answers is what worries me."

The bridge doors slide open, and Melog runs back in with Glimmer, Bow, and Adora right behind her.

"Mom!" Glimmer practically jumps on Catra's back to get a better look at the communicator. "Are you okay?"

"*Of course, dear. Are you?*"

"Yeah, definitely, but space is *terrible*. I can't do magic!"

"Focus," Catra says sharply. "We need to figure out how to get passed the armada surrounding Etheria."

"Yeah, that's a lot of ships," Bow says slowly, looking out the window. "We can't take them all on our own."

"*We may be able to offer some assistance from our position*," Angella says uncertainly. "*But I can't say how much good it would be.*" There was a pause, then a low murmur of voices as Angella sent a guard to get the rest of the princesses.

"Never mind that it would probably bring every single ship down on Bright Moon at the same time," Catra points out.

"*There is that as well, yes*."

"What about a distraction?" Catra looks back at Adora, who's rubbing the back of her neck. Catra wonders if she even realizes it. "The hivemind is kind of chaotic sometimes, especially when a lot is happening at once. Horde Prime can keep track of it, but even he's not perfect, no matter what he says. Things slip through."

Catra wants to ask more about that, but this isn't the time. She looks back at Angella. "You guys could launch an attack somewhere. Draw attention away from Bright Moon. Make him think there's nothing to worry about at the castle, especially if all the princesses are there."

Angella frowns, thinking for a moment. "*We've been avoiding the North since it gives Fosta a great advantage. But it's as far from Bright Moon as we can get.*"

"It's risky," Catra says.

"*I know. But if it gets you all home safe*"…

"*What's going on?*" They hear Netossa ask. "*Are the others back?*"

"*Almost.*" Angella looks back at the communicator. "*Stay where you are. We'll call you back when we have a plan*."

The screen goes blank before they can argue. Glimmer sighs, sliding off Catra's back and slumping to the floor.

"I hate leaving them to do this on their own."

"Me too," Catra says, sitting with her. "But we don't have much of a choice right now. We just need to trust them."

Adora walks to the window, staring out at the mass of ships, a hand still on the back of her neck. She remembers how *loud* the hivemind had been during attacks; it had almost been overwhelming, probably would have been if not for Horde Prime sedating her worries, assuring her that *he* had everything handled, and she had a simple job…

"Hey." Catra rests a hand on Adora's shoulder, jarring her back to reality. "It's okay. We're gonna get out of this."

"Huh?" Adora blinks before quickly catching up. "Yeah, I know. I'm not worried."

She's still a terrible liar.

"Guards and clones, same as usual," Spinnerella says as she lands beside the group. This is the first time they've gone North, but the general set up seems to be the same everywhere. Guards, if any were available, and clones. Salineas isn't the only place citizens have disappeared from at this point – Horde Prime seems to be taking all of them captive now.

"And Frosta somewhere in the palace," Netossa adds.

"We're not here to save her," Angella says regretfully. She wants to—the idea of leaving Frosta behind goes against everything in her—but they're already at a terrible disadvantage. They need to focus on their mission. Cause chaos. Distract Prime. Get their people home.

"Spinny and I will go in first." Netossa lays out the plan. "Scorpia, you back us up."

"Oh, uh, right." Scorpia rubs the back of her head. "Okay."

"Mermista brings up the rear. Angella, keep an eye out and cover us. I doubt he's going to keep Frosta inside."

Angella nods, tapping the trackerpad to call the others. Entrapta answers on the first ring. "*Hello!*"

"*Mmmm

Angella keeps her gaze fixed on the castle, listening to people chatter on the trackerpad and in her ear. She wants to go in, to take down every single clone standing in her way, to save Frosta from Prime's control. She's a *child*. She doesn't deserve this. Nobody does, but Frosta especially. How could Angella have let her just walk off like that, without any care if she was okay? Why hadn't she insisted on *in person* check ins? What kind of queen was she that she could let so many people be captured like this?

She hears the distant rumble of earth, sees snow falling from the mountains around her, and flies higher into the air just in time to avoid being hit by the ice spike that juts out of the ground.

"Frosta's attacking!" she reports as she weaves in and out of icy spikes. She can't see Frosta, but that doesn't mean much. Everything is chaos. She could be anywhere.

Or she could be right behind Angella, launching herself into the air on a pillar of ice and hitting Angella in the back of the head with an icy fist.

"Mom!" Glimmer screeches as they watch the trackerpad Angella had been holding tumble to the ground. It breaks when it hits, and the screen goes blank.

"Damn it," Catra hisses. "Entrapta, find an opening. *Now*."

"Um. Um." Entrapta is scanning the armada urgently. "No one's broken formation."

"Then make a hole!" Glimmer demands.

"And what, blast our way through an armada?" Catra shoots back with a scoff. "We can't help anyone if we're *dead*."

"What about Melog?" Adora speaks up. "They can make us invisible, right?"

Melog mewled an affirmative response. "Horde Prime knows we can do that," Catra says slowly. "But that doesn't mean he can do anything about it."

"Unless he's figured out a way to track us," Bow says.

Catra considers it for a moment before shaking her head. "Chance we've gotta take. Everyone get ready. We're going home."

She turns back to look at Melog, but her eyes find Adora first. The blonde gives her a small, uncertain smile, and for a moment, the knot in Catra's chest loosens.

They're going home.

"Sorry! Sorry!"

Scorpia yelps over and over as she hits guards. She doesn't mind fighting the clones, but the guards are chipped, just like she had been. It's not fair to hurt them. It's not fair she *has* to hurt them. Why can't she just fight the clones?

"Scorpia, I'm sure they'll forgive you!" Spinnerella calls helpfully.

"Really?"

"It doesn't *matter* right now!" Mermista yells. Angella has managed to recover, but they've lost contact with the ship. And Frosta is quickly overwhelming them. Why is she so strong?

"Give up," she taunts those clear enough to hear her. "You can not escape Horde Prime's light."

Netossa throws a net at Frosta, who easily blocks it with a spike of ice. Damn it. "Time to fall back. We need to get back in touch with the others"—

She cuts off as Frosta traps her between shards of ice. "No one is going anywhere." The weird monotone sounds completely wrong in Frosta's voice. "You will all submit to the light."

There's a brief flash of light behind Frosta. "Not a chance," Catra growls before pouncing, tackling Frosta to the ground. The princess yells in surprise, but quickly recovers; she slams her hand into the ground, and a pillar of ice springs to life beneath her, shooting them both up into the air.

Glimmer appears beside Netossa, teleporting her out of her ice prison. "Welcome back," Netossa says with a weak laugh. The ice pillar stops very suddenly, the momentum throw Catra off. She orients herself to land on all fours, skidding across the snow.

"Fucking *cold*!"

Another guard gets behind Catra, but this one is taken down but Adora hitting him in the head with a staff. "What, cant handle a little snow?" she teases.

"Shut up," Catra snarls, pushing herself up. "I'll last long after your freeze to death. Glimmer, get everyone back to the ship."

"On it," Glimmer says, grabbing Netossa's arm and disappearing once more. Catra turns back to Frosta.

"Let's go, Snowflake."

The ground rumbles; Catra jumps away to dodge an ice spike, then immediately jumps again to dodge another. "You will not win," Frosta informs her flatly.

"Neither will you, shorty."

Catra jumps at her, intending to push her to the ground, but another pillar of ice blocks her. She rears back and slices through it,

surprising Frosta. She dodges before Catra can hit her, hands out, and Catra runs face first into a wall of forming ice.

"Fuck!" she groans, stumbling back. She claws at the ice wall, but it immediately reforms. And then she realizes a dome is forming around her. And it's *freezing*. Catra growls, raising a hand.

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

Adora sees Catra disappearing under the dome of ice, and panics. "Catra!"

Glimmer's off doing *something*, so of course Adora does the only thing that makes sense – she runs at Frosta, staff raised, but she's still five feet away when the dome explodes in a burst of light. She skids to a halt, covering her eyes.

"You're so dramatic."

"Shut up," Catra snaps, sword at the ready. She quickly changes it to a shield to block Frosta's punch. Adora whirls to take down two more guards, then a clone. Catra uses the shield to deflect an ice ball and meets Frosta's eyes, glaring.

"You will *never* have Etheria," she informs the alien behind those eyes. A hand grabs her arm.

"Time to go!" Glimmer says. Then they're back on the ship. The vertigo isn't *quite* as bad as She-Ra, but it still sucks. Catra can hear ships outside, firing at them, but Entrapta is faster; they bolt off before any hits can land.

"We did it!" Glimmer cheers, tackling her mother and hugging her tight. The others laugh, relaxing slightly; Scorpia shoves her way through the crowd to grab Adora and crush her in a hug. Netossa is examining wrong Hordak with a fair amount of scrutiny while Bow tries to explain that Wrong Hordak is a *good* clone, really. Mermista claps Entrapta on the shoulder, smiling.

"Nice one, nerd."

Melog brushes up against Catra's leg, purring contently. *You are happy*.

Yeah. She is. It surprises her.

Perfuma is waiting anxiously when they return. She's no good in the snow, and someone needed to stay behind to guard the palace. And she did her best to stay calm and meditate, but she's worried about everyone.

It's a relief when the ship lands.

"You all made it!" she says as she hurries forward to hug whoever she can grab first ~~it~~ ends up being Glimmer and Bow. Catra hangs back, watching everyone reunite.

"That's a new look."

She jumps, surprised, and turns to see Angella watching her with a small smile. "Oh. Yeah." Catra looks down at herself ~~at~~ She-Ra. It's so strange. "Not too bad, though."

"You certainly seem more comfortable."

"Yeah," Catra says slowly. "I guess I am."

She hasn't thought about it before, but this really does seem more… natural. Even the sword feels better in her hands. Like it actually *fits*.

Angella makes her way down the ramp to join the others. "It's still so weird that you're just on a speaking basis with the Queen," Adora says conversationally, stepping up beside Catra.

"She's not nearly as scary as they make her seem in sims."

"Definitely not. Too pink."

They exchange uncertain smiles. Catra moves her tail without thinking, winding it a bit around Adora's arm. "Ready to be a good guy?"

Adora scoffs. "I'm just here for that cake you promised me."

"Wait you're She-Ra again!?"

Perfuma has finally noticed Catra, and apparently it finally draws the others' attention as well. Spinnerella and Netossa are blinking in surprise while Scorpia gasps in shock, covering her mouth with her pincers. Even Mermista looks caught off guard.

"Very observant," Adora mutters to Catra. "No wonder they were losing before you joined them."

Catra snorts, letting She-Ra melt away, falling back into her own skin. "Seriously."

"Tell us *everything*!" Netossa demands, darting up the ramp to grab Catra and drag her to join the others. Adora follows uncertainly; Spinnerella gives her a small, knowing smile, but doesn't say anything.

"Okay, okay, *fine*"...

Chapter End Notes

> Okay, don't get mad, but I'm doing the thing again - skipping next week (the 12th) and posting the week after (the 19th). I've written up to them going to get the failsafe (chapter fifteen) which means we're REALLY near the end of things, and it's... hard to write for a lot of reasons (partially because I'm sad to see it end, partially because this is where Adora and Catra in Magicatra are the most noticeably different from canon and that's saying a lot), and I just need time to work on it. Also it's NaNoWriMo and I'm working on something T O T A L L Y new for that (supernatural journalists/missing AU, very fun and

exciting), so there's just a lot going on and I want the last few chapters to be as perfect as they can possibly be.

So bear with me? We're getting into the eleventh hour, and I'm going to do my best to make it as good as possible. I just need a little time <3

Take A Break

Chapter Summary

Adora and Catra reconnect

Chapter Notes

This is, admittedly, a bit of a transition chapter, but on the plus side, that should be the last break I need to take! I'm almost done with chapter sixteen, and I pretty much have seventeen mapped out in my head, then the epilogue..... guys it's almost over. can you believe it?

"How long have they been gone?"

"A little over a day ."

"Are we sure Aunt Casta didn't kill her and leave her in a bush?"

Catra smothers a laugh with a cough. Angella shoots her an exasperated look before refocusing on Glimmer . "Honestly , no. But I doubt Casta would stay away if she did."

"I mean, I'd probably throw her a damn party ," Catra says wryly . She's sitting on the balcony railing, tail sweeping lazily through the air. It's late — Angella has been catching them up on everything that they missed. "I used to dream about that kind of shit."

"Y ou used to dream about murdering Shadow Weaver?" Adora asks, raising an eyebrow.

"Or punching her , but I've gotten to do that. A lot, actually ."

"Did she give *any* ideas about where they were going?" Bow asks, bringing them back to the topic at hand.

"No. We tried to ask before they left, but…"

"Shadow Weaver's evil, but she's not completely stupid," Catra says bitterly. "She knows how to play her cards close to her chest. She did it for years in the Horde, and probably longer before that in Mystacor."

"You think she was being honest?" Adora says in disbelief.

"She was being half honest, at least," Catra corrects. "She manipulates and she only tells the parts of the stories and she exploits shit, but she doesnt completely lie. She knows something. Whether we like the answer is another thing entirely."

"Like Half Moon," Bow guesses.

"Exactly like Half Moon. She had answers, she didnt lie about it. She just didnt add that the truth would make me want to claw her eyes out."

Melog, who is sitting beside the railing, lifts their head to nudge Catra's clenched fist. They dont need to ask – the memories are at the forefront of Catra's mind, and Melog can easily see them. They let out a small, mournful noise, bowing their head. They had already known Catra is the only magicat left. Knowing who's responsible just makes it worse.

"There's no point in worrying about it now," Angella says after a moment. "I'm sure none of you have rested well since you left Etheria."

Or before that, really. "A real bed," Glimmer moans, slumping over the table. "I've missed that so much."

"What's your definition of a real bed?" Adora asks skeptically. Catra snorts.

"Yeah, the beds here suck."

Glimmer rolls her eyes and teleports away. Bow is smiling as he leaves, tapping on his tracker pad. "I believe I'll call it a night as well," Angella says, standing. "Catra, I assume you can show Adora to her room?"

"What? Oh. Y eah." Right. Adora has a room. She'd had a room before this entire mess. She can go back there to sleep. Or to any of the other guest rooms this place has. She has no reason to stay with Catra at all.

They sit in silence for a few minutes after Angella leaves. It feels better. More comfortable. "This place is stupidly bright," Adora said after a minute.

"Y eah. Guess it earns its name."

"*W* *ow* . How long have you been waiting to break that one out?"

"J ust came to me, actually . Pretty good, right?"

Adora rolls her eyes, but she's smiling. Something warm bubbles in Catra's chest at the sight. Which means, of course, that she has to ruin it.

"Do you remember anything from being here before?"

"Y eah," Adora says quietly . "I was still aware. It' s hard to explain, and a lot of it feels like a dream now. But I remember." She pauses, then adds, "I definitely remember an entire room dedicated to me."

"Shut up," Catra says, waving Adora of f and pointedly ignoring her smirk. "I didn't make that. It wasn't even my idea. Angella did it because she thought it would make me *feel* better."

"Did it?"

Yes. "Shut up. Come on, I'm tired."

Catra launches herself off the railing, Melog trailing behind her. Adora follows with that annoying, smug smirk still in place. "Did you spend a lot of time there? I didn't realize you'd miss me so much. You must *really* like me—"

"For fuck's sake, Adora!" Catra snaps, whirling to glare at her. "Yeah, I missed you, okay!? Because you were fucking *dead* as far as I knew, and a stupid fucking painting on a wall was all I had!"

Her words ring off the walls, echoing around them. Adora is no longer smiling; her shoulders drop, her head bowed. "Sorry," she says quietly. "I didn't mean—of course it was hard for you. That was stupid."

Catra feels a pang of regret. She hadn't meant to snap. Why does she always yell at the people who care about her? "No, you're fine, it's—it's fine," she mutters. Stupid, stupid, stupid. Adora doesn't need her shit on top of everything else. "Come on, let's just get to bed. I'm tired."

"Same." Adora rubs the back of her neck, looking up. "I don't know if I can sleep alone, though. I mean, these rooms—who needs a *waterfall* in their room? What's it even for? Showering?"

Something shifts, and Catra laughs. She can't help it. She's tired, she's run the entire gambit of emotions in the last few days, and there is *finally* someone here who really understands what it's like to be in this weird, foreign place with all it's weird, useless decorations.

"Come on. Angella's not going to freak out if she catches us sharing a bed."

Shadow Weaver had. They both remember the consequences a little too well. Even Adora had been slapped, then coldly informed that such acts among cadets weren't *appropriate*.

Catra never talked about what Shadow Weaver did to *her*.

It's nice, being back in her own room. Nicer to be with Adora. Adora, who's looking around, taking in all the small parts of the room that make it Catra's own – the sleepwear thrown hastily at the bottom of the unmade bed, the curtains that hadn't been in the guest room, the wooden Catra figurine Bow had made for planning sessions sitting on the dresser. Melog walks over to the bed, shrinking down and jumping up. They're just as tired as the girls, and easily fall asleep. Catra slides her mask off, yawning, and drops it on the bedside table before collapsing as well.

"All of this is really... a lot."

Catra wonders if Adora is talking about the room or... everything else.

"Yeah. This place thrives on excessive."

Adora sits carefully on the edge of the bed, pressing her hands into the soft mattress. "How do you sleep on this?"

"Usually I'm too tired to care. Sometimes I sleep in the window, though." Catra nods to the window nook where she'd spent so much of her time in the beginning. Adora looks at the window, then at Catra.

"You really have a whole life here, don't you?"

"Yeah, that happens when you live somewhere."

"It wasn't like this in the Fright Zone." Adora looks at the ceiling. "There's nothing there that's *us*."

"That garbage pile isn't anyone's home," Catra points out, sitting up. "And that's not true. We drew our faces on our bunk, remember?"

Adora snorts, coughing to cover a laugh. They had decided they wanted pictures of themselves on their own walls, but the only photos that existed in the Horde were for medical files. So they'd

taken it upon themselves to create masterpieces on the side of their bunk. Their *marks*.

"That was so dumb," Adora says fondly.

"You're only saying that because mine was better."

"It was *not*!" Adora protests, offended. "Take that back!"

"It's not my fault I have such amazing artistic prowess"…

Adora dives, tackling Catra to the bed. They laugh as they wrestle around for a moment, until Adora eventually ends up on top, half resting on Catra's chest. Something softens in Adora's expression, and she lays her head down, content.

Oh.

Catra doesn't even dare to breathe. Adora realizes her mistake and jolts up, blushing furiously. "Um, I um…sorry."

She rolls away, back to the edge of the bed, curling up tightly on herself. Catra sits up slowly, watching her. "Is it…weird?" she asks after a moment. "I mean, remembering the dream and everything?"

"Yeah," Adora mutters. "Not just with you. I grew up with Glimmer in that world. The king and queen were basically my parents. All of the princesses were my friends – our friends. Sometimes I wake up and wonder where Finn is, because they always jumped on me if I slept too late and demanded I get up *now*. Sometimes on the ship, I'd wake up and it'd be dark, and it would feel like being back in Half Moon. Even just seeing myself in the mirror…it…was *ten years*." Her voice cracks. "Nothing feels right here."

Catra scoots closer, resting a hand on her arm. "I know it's not the same, but…you've still got me."

Adora smiles weakly. "I know. Thank you."

"Not sure if that's something to thank me for."

"Oh, shush," Adora murmurs, nudging her head against Catra's shoulder. The purr that bubbles up in Catra's chest is completely involuntarily and she hates it.

But she doesn't do anything to stamp it down.

No answer.

Bow sighs, turning off his tracker pad again and leaning on the railing, watching the sun rise. Of *course* they're not answering. How can a bunch of the smartest people he knows not know how to pick up a call? His brothers are fine, he's sure—more than likely, they're all in parts of Etheria so far out that they haven't even heard of Prime. But George and Lance are at the library, in the Whispering Woods…

Maybe it would be okay. Maybe he's worrying for nothing. George *was* a soldier, after all. He fought for the Rebellion. He can protect them, right?

He threw out his back trying to lift a pile of books once.

Right.

"Bow?"

He jumps, surprised, and turns to see Glimmer standing behind him. He *had* kind of snuck out, it isn't really a surprise she came looking. "What's wrong?"

Because of course she knows something is *wrong*. Bow sighs. "I…" He waves his tracker pad uselessly. He doesn't want anyone else to worry. They've all got enough going on without putting his problems on top of things.

But again, Glimmer knows. "Your dads?" she guesses. He nods, sighing.

"I haven't been able to get ahold of them, and they're right in the middle of the Whispering Woods, and I just wish they'd answer."

"Do you want to try and find them?"

"No, it's fine, they—the library's really well hidden. And there's enough to worry about here."

Glimmer folds her arms, raising an eyebrow. "They're your *dads*. This is just as important as everything else. We can just teleport over and be back before anyone knows we're gone. But I'll still tell Mom before we go."

Bow smiles weakly. "Yeah. That's probably a good idea. Thanks, Glimmer."

Glimmer smiles back, getting on her tiptoes to wrap her arms around him and holding him tight. "We'll find them. Don't worry."

"Why didn't they get me!?"

Angella is very calm, sipping her tea as Catra rants. How is she *drinking tea?* They're at *war*! "I believe they were considering it a chance for you to take a break," she says very patiently.

Catra throws her arms up. "You people and your *breaks*! Horde Prime is out there trying to take over the planet and I'm supposed to *what?* Take a nap!?"

"What do you propose?" Angella asks. "Would you like to go to Salineas? The North? Mystacor?"

"I mean, no, going to those places is basically suicide at this point."

"Perhaps you'd like to try and take Thaymor back?"

"I am so sick of Thaymor ."

"Then maybe a break is best."

Catra lets out a high-pitched noise of frustration. "Are you kidding me!?"

Adora taps the top of Catra's head a couple times. "Hey , betcha cant beat me."

"What?"

"At sparring. Bet I can still take you."

"Y ou can not ~~-g~~et out of here, we dont have time for this."

"What, are you scaaaaaaaaaared?" Adora draws out the word, teasing.

"Shut *up*." Catra shoves her away . "I'm not scared of *you*."

"Are you sure? Maybe being She-Ra' s made you *soft*."

That does it. Catra dives at her, pushing her to the door. "I'll show you who's gone *fucking soft*"—

Angella hides a smile behind her tea as the girls hurries out of the room, probably heading for the training grounds. That girl is good for Catra, she decides. Even if it is just taking her outside and beating her up, it's a distraction. And it's the kind of thing Catra is used to, the things that had been familiar and comfortable in the Horde.

And it's Adora. That alone must be enough to bring some relief to Catra's constant stress.

"T oo late to call winner?"

"Netossa already did. An hour ago."

The princesses had been slowly drawn out to the training field, where Catra and Adora are still going at each other like they're fighting to the death. But they're laughing and calling teasing barbs at each other, so it can't be *that* serious. Must be a Horde thing, they all decide.

It's a good way to work off the nervous energy, though. Catra feels slightly better, slightly less jittery. And it's nice to spar with Adora again. No one else quite offers the same challenge. She knows they pull their punches, which is *stupid*. But she's never been able to convince them to cut loose and go.

"So," Mermista says slowly, still watching the girls. "Those two. Totally in love, right?"

"Absolutely," Netossa says wisely while Spinnerella nods.

"I've been documenting their feelings for each other for three years!" Entrapta pipes up from where she and Wrong Hordak are tuning up Emily – teaching him freedom has been a slow process, but Entrapta is surprisingly patient.

"Probably." Scorpia sounds a bit wistful. Perfuma rests a reassuring hand on her arm.

"Do you think they know that?"

"Definitely not."

Melog is lounging in a patch of sun, tail lazily swishing as they watch Catra and Adora and listen to the princesses. They would have laughed at the conversation if they could have; instead they just let out an amused chuff.

Your friends are very interested in your feelings for Adora.

The words catch Catra off guard, resulting in Adora hitting her in the head with her staff. She went down. Hard.

"Catra! I'm so sorry , I thought you were blocking, what—"

Catra blinks a few times, dazed. *Feelings? What feelings?*

Melog simply trills, returning back to their sunning. "Catra?" Adora leans over into her line of sight. "Are you okay?"

"Fine," Catra grumbles, raising an arm. Adora grasps her hand, pulling her up.

"I thought you had that blocked. What happened?"

"Nothing." She shoots a glare in Melog's direction. "It's nothing."

Adora still has her hand. Catra doesn't feel any need to back away , even with the audience that had gathered throughout their fight.

The echo of bells disrupts the moment. "Meeting!" Glimmer says loudly, grabbing Catra's shoulder and teleporting them all to the war room. Catra groans, slumping against Adora.

"I *swear*, Glimmer—"

But Glimmer is already gone, probably to get the others. Catra waits for the world to stop spinning before she finds Bow sitting at the table.

"Your dads okay?"

"Yeah." He sounds relieved. "I tried to get them to come with me, but they want to stay where they are in case there's more to find."

"They found something?"

Glimmer reappears with the others, bouncing excitedly . "There's a failsafe!"

"A what?"

"George and Lance found some old First One runes. Mara wasn't the only person going against the First Ones – there was a whole group! Serenia was a person!"

Catra perks up slightly, ears twitching. "Seriously?"

"She left a message," Bow confirms. "It must have been after Mara moved Etheria, she was talking about Mara buying them time – but that's not the point. There's a failsafe for the Heart of Etheria. It would stop Prime from getting access to the magic. It could save the entire universe!"

For the first time in a very, very, very long time, Catra feels *hope*. "Where?"

"That's the difficult part." Of course it is. "It's a place called Ariya. The First Ones had different names for everything, and my dads have never heard of a place named that."

"*Great*." Catra lets out a long breath, digging the heels of her palms into her eyes. "So we just have to what? Go over all the First Ones' maps and find a place called Ariya? That's fine. Oh *wait*, I'm the only one who can read First One writing, so—"

"Always so dramatic," a familiar voice drawls. Catra's lip curls in disgust before she even turns to see Shadow Weaver and Castaspella standing in the door of the room. "Have you ever considered you only make your own problems?"

"I'm going to take *care* of one of those problems unless you have something really good to say."

Melog is on the balcony, growling, mane rippling red. Maybe Shadow Weaver herself hadn't killed anyone, but she had led the army that had wiped out the Magicats. Their blood is on her hands. Adora carefully slips out onto the balcony, resting a hand on their head. And Shadow Weaver's attention is drawn to her.

"*Adora*." Her tone immediately changes to that same, disgustingly sweet voice that she always used when trying to look like she cared. "It's so good to see—"

"*Enough*," Catra snarls. "You don't talk to her. You don't even *look* at her. Got it? If you don't have anything good to say, then we can just put you back in your room."

"We know where Arix is," Castaspella gently cuts in, knowing it's not a good idea to let Catra keep going. Catra looks at her, surprised.

"How? Where?"

"Mystacor."

Of *course* it was Mystacor.

Failsafe

Chapter Summary

Field trip to Mystacor

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I don't like this."

Castaspella sighs. "Believe me, I don't either. But you know as well as anyone how she is about doling out information."

Catra huffs, folding her arms and glaring at the door. Shadow Weaver is on the other side, being guarded by Netossa and Spinnerella to make sure she doesn't try to escape. Not that she will. She has leverage over them. She's exactly where she needs to be.

"But Mystacor," Glimmer says softly, looking to the balcony.

"It's where Micah is," Angella finishes the thought.

"So we'd need to get through Mystacor to wherever this secret place is," Bow summarizes slowly, "all without being seen? I don't like our odds."

Melog purrs, resting their head on Catra's knee. *I believe I may be of service*.

"And after *everything* she's done, we're really going to trust her?" Glimmer asks, frowning. Angella and Castaspella exchange long looks.

"She knows more about Mystacor than anyone. She spent years there, studying it, learning about it inside and out. I don't *like* it, but

she might as well put that knowledge to good use."

"This is a waste of time," Shadow Weaver says from the hallway. Netossa starts to tell her to shut up, but Catra cuts in.

"No, you know what? Let her talk."

She stands, going to the door and throwing it open to glare at the sorceress. "Go on, get it over with. Talk about all the ways I've fucked up and *you're* the only one who can fix it."

Shadow Weaver scoffs. "At least you're *aware* of it. Perhaps you've learned something after all this time. You've allowed Prime to take too much ground. If he gets to the Heart, it's over."

"I didn't realize you cared so much about being a good guy."

"I *care* about not allowing the Heart to fall under his control. Think what you will of me, Catra, but I appear to be the only one here with their priorities in order. *You* need to stop being selfish, and do your duty to this planet and all of its people."

"You don't—"

A very audible, continuous growling catches Catra's attention; she turns, surprised, to see Melog standing beside Adora, mane and eyes glowing red, expression drawn into what can only be a furious snarl.

"Melog?" Adora rests a hand on their head, trying to calm them. It doesn't work. "What's wrong?"

"Oh." Catra turns back to Shadow Weaver, lips twisting in discuss. "*You* led the attack on Half Moon."

"Ancient history," Shadow Weaver says, waving her hand dismissively.

"Not to Melog. They're from the magicats' home planet. Their kind were guardians to the magicats, and they were almost completely wiped out trying to stop Prime from taking the planet while the magicats escaped."

Adora is the first one to understand – she gasps, sliding out of her chair to gently hug Melog.

"And?" Shadow Weaver asks impatiently.

"*And* if you step out of line, they'll rip you apart. And if you think I'm going to stop them, then you *really* don't know me." Catra looks back at the rest of the room. "We'll go invisible. The rest of you stay here and—"

"*Stay here*?" Glimmer repeats incredulously.

"You can't *seriously* think we're going to just let you leave alone with Shadow Weaver," Bow adds.

"I'm not alone, I have Melog."

"You're not going without me," Castaspella says. "That's not negotiable."

Catra groans. "*Fine*. But there's no reason to drag everyone else into—"

"We're going," Bow and Glimmer say together. Adora stands, resting a hand on Melog's head. She doesn't have to say the words. And Catra really can't argue.

"Fine. Fine. We're leaving in half an hour. Everyone get ready."

She shoves passed Shadow Weaver without another word. Melog slinks after her, snarling at Shadow Weaver, and Adora follows without hesitation.

"Hey ," she says as she catches up, resting a hand on Catra' s shoulder. "Are you okay?"

"I dont *love* the idea of depending on Shadow Weaver, but otherwise yeah, Im great."

The words are dripping with sarcasm. Adora squeezes her shoulder a little tighter. "What she said. Youre not selfish, Catra. None of this is your fault."

Catra's shoulders drop as she sighs, reaching up to take the mask off. "I dont know . Maybe it is. Im the one who tried to *fix* everyone's mistakes, and look where that got us." *Look where it got you*.

"Y ou didnt know ," Adora insists. "How could you? Especially with Shadow Weaver hiding everything."

"But she' s *right*. Everything Ive ever done has been selfish. I didnt leave the Horde to be some great hero — I just wanted to get away from her. I pulled the lever because I wanted to stop feeling guilty for everyone else's choices. Fuck, Adora, I went to space just to save you. How is that *not* selfish?"

Adora's quiet for a moment; a not quite growl is still rumbling through Melog, echoing in the hall. "Do you remember ," Adora finally said, "when we were thirteen and started really training as cadets? And what a mess Kyle was?"

Catra snorts. "Of course I do. Man, he sucked so much."

"Y eah." Adora laughs quietly . "He did. And he kept losing his rations because he wasnt doing well, and the Horde didnt see any point in wasting rations on a soldier who couldnt handle himself on the field. And the rest of us just went with it, because it's what we were told to do. But *you* didnt. Y ou threw your ration bar at him and told him to eat. You were the one who thought hey, maybe *starving* a person isnt the way to get a better performance out of him."

"I just did it because I didn't feel like listening to him whine about how hungry he was."

"But that's my *point*." Adora grasps Catra by the shoulders, turning her to meet her gaze. "You are *so good*, Catra. You always have been. All these things you think you do out of spite or selfishness? They're *good* things. You left the Horde and helped the Rebellion. You pulled the lever because you thought it was the right thing to do. And you came to save me because... because..."

Catra watches anxiously as Adora drifts off, suddenly very interested in the wall. "Because that's how you are," she finally finishes. "You're a good person, no matter what Shadow Weaver says. Okay?"

"Yeah," Catra says quietly, trying to smile. "Okay. Thanks, Adora."

Neither of them notice the hidden, familiar gaze watching them from around the corner.

Catra swears she can hear every single person breathing as they stand in the hallways, watching the Mystacor acolyte. She can't see them, but it feels like those solid green eyes are boring right through them.

Finally, she walks away. "Okay," Catra whispers when the footsteps are long gone. "Let's go."

She hates letting Shadow Weaver lead, but it's preferable to having Shadow Weaver *behind* her. She knows the others are on her side, and they'd throw Shadow Weaver to the wolves immediately if it came to it. But the sorceress still made her feel like the kid who thought she could earn love if she just tried hard enough.

She hates that even more.

Shadow Weaver stops, sweeping an arm out to signal to stop them as well. At the end of the hall is Micah, walking through an intersection. Catra hears Glimmer gasp behind her, and has to resist the urge to turn back. She cant take her eyes of f the threat right in front of them.

But Micah moves on, and so do they. They stop at the door of a room with a raised platform, peering in.

"It' s clear," Catra says after a moment, straightening up. "Let' s keep
"—

She doesnt see the sorceress who steps out of from a blind spot. All she sees ~~a~~ll she *feels* ~~is~~ Shadow W eaver's hand grabbing her, her other hand grabbing her mouth as she restrains her and hisses, "*Kep your voice down* ."

Melog, to that point, has managed to keep their temper in check. Shadow Weaver crosses a line when she grabs Catra, though;they roar, diving at the sorceress and knocking her down while Catra stumbles away, and the invisibility falls.

"W atch out!" Adora grabs Catra to pull her out of the way of an oncoming spell, and she finally turns to see their attacker. It's Meg, the healer who *had* been trying to help her. She's not sure why that shakes her up so much.

"Y ou guys get back," she orders, raising her hand. "For the honor of Grayskull!"

Nothing happens. "What?" she gasps, lowering her hand to stare at it in shock. *Focus, focus, focus* . Why wont the sword come?

Castaspella quickly takes Meg down before she can do any more damage. "Get this thing of f me," Shadow W eaver snarls. Melog has her pinned down, but to their credit, they havent torn her apart yet.

"Melog." Adora gently reaches out, resting a hand on their snout. "We have to go, quick."

The alien cat growls quietly before stepping off of Shadow Weaver. She immediately stands, grabbing Castaspella's arm as she closes the space between them in large strides.

"We need to hurry."

They run down another hallway, stopping in front of a mural. Shadow Weaver looks at Castaspella. "Follow my lead."

"Would a please kill you?" Castaspella grumbles as she raises her hands to mirror Shadow Weaver's casting. The mural on the walls glows before it cracks open. They run into the dark hallway, and the doos close behind them. Glimmer casts a ball of light to illuminate their way, lighting up the symbols scrawled along the walls.

"Whoa."

Adora looks at Catra out of the corner of her eye. She's gone completely stiff, tail lashing, expression stone. "You okay?" she murmurs, moving closer to nudge Catra with her shoulder. Catra steps away, eyes fixed forward.

"I'm fine."

They walk in silence, staring ahead at the others. "I'm sorry I let her treat you like that for so long," Adora finally says quietly.

"It doesnt matter anymore."

"It matters that she hurt you."

Catra lets out a long breath, her shoulders relaxing slightly. "It's fine. Let's just get this over with."

"What is all this?" Bow is saying as they walk ahead.

“We're on the right path,” Castaspella said. “The Crystal of Aria was rumored to be the key to reaching deep magic within Etheria. Many have tried, and failed, to find it. But those who hungered for more power have long sought other ways to obtain the deep magic.” She glares at Shadow Weaver, “With disastrous results.”

“The Spell of Obtainment was a mistake,” Shadow Weaver says nonchalantly. “One for which I've paid the price. I don't see why you keep bringing it up.”

Casta stops, her expression dark as she turns completely to look at Shadow Weaver. “You roped my brother into your twisted dark magic when he was only a child. You could've killed him.”

“It would have worked had he not broken the connection,” Shadow Weaver replies. “Micah was an exceptional sorcerer, even then. It's a shame it didn't run in the family.”

Casta grits her teeth, shoving passed Shadow Weaver. They round the corner, and Catra catches a glimpse of something glowing purple on the ground. Adora’s foot is inches from it.

“Watch out!” She darts forward, grabbing Adora and dragging her away right as a column of flames light up. The girls stumble back, Adora half falling into Catra’s arms.

“Oh! Okay.” Adora laughs shakily. “It’s fine, I’m okay.”

Glimmer steps forward, putting a hand close to the flames, then through it. “It’s an illusion!”

“Some of the fire is illusory, and some is real,” Shadow Weaver says, gesturing around. The walls of lit up in flames as well. “Everyone, be careful.”

Catra looks at Adora, who’s still in her arms. They both blush slightly before Adora quickly straightens up and hurries forward. Catra

follows, looking around. Everything about this is freaking her out a little.

Melog walks beside her, bristling, a low growl in their throat. *Their* feelings probably aren't helping much, but Catra doesn't blame them.

"I hate this too," Catra says quietly, resting a hand on Melog's head. "But we don't have a choice."

"You don't have a choice because you allowed this to go too far," Shadow Weaver scolds her. Catra looks up, hissing at the sorceress who has fallen back to talk to her. "Or are you still refusing to accept responsibility for your actions?"

"I've accepted it," Catra shoots back. "When will *you*?"

She draws herself up and shoulders passed Shadow Weaver, intent on leaving her behind. "This has always been your weakness, you know," Shadow Weaver says, ignoring the intent behind Catra's movements. "You're too emotional. You've always let it drive your actions. Whether it was scratching other cadets or pulling a lever with the potential to end the world, you've seen it all through your *feelings*."

"And?" Catra demands, stopping to look back at Shadow Weaver. "What's your point?"

"My *point* is that your feelings are going to doom us all. She-Ra is a being of pure magic. To unleash her full strength, you must be focused, clearheaded. But you are letting your emotions pull you in too many directions." Catra's lips pull back in a snarl, but Shadow Weaver isn't done. "Etheria can't afford to have you *distracted*. It doesn't need *Catra* right now. It needs *She-Ra*."

"And it *has* her."

"Does it? Can you transform right now, on demand?"

Catra falters for a moment, looking at her hands. No, she can't. She still doesn't understand how she accessed the sword the way she had. She doesn't want to answer. But she doesn't really have to. Shadow Weaver knows.

"If you care about your friends—if you care about *Adora*—then you'll let go of these emotions and focus on what you *need* to do. And what you need to do is *stop him*. Prime before your feelings get us all killed."

Catra glares, then turns on her heel and starts back down the hall. "I'll keep that in mind," she says coolly, hoping Shadow Weaver can't hear the tremor in her voice.

What if she's right? What if Catra messes this all up *again* because she doesn't trust herself? Because she's not strong enough.

Melog nudges her thigh, mewling. *The shadows lie*, they remind her gently.

"The shadows tell half truths and manipulate," Catra replies quietly. "I don't think she's ever straight out *lied*, though."

You know better.

Does she? She reaches up, carefully taking the mask off to look at it. She had promised she would try, and she's been nothing but selfish since then. What if she really can't save anyone?

Melog bounds ahead suddenly, weaving through Adora's legs and purring loudly. Adora stops, startled, then laughs, reaching out to pet their head. An uncertain smile pulls at Catra's lips as she puts the mask back on.

Shadow Weaver takes the lead again, and they walk through the flames in silence until they reach a large room with a giant crystal sculpture against one wall.

"Whoa," Bow murmured.

"*That's* the Failsafe?" Glimmer asks in disbelief.

"It's bigger than I thought it would be," Bow adds. "How are we gonna get that to the Heart?"

Shadow Weaver's tone is full of impatience that Catra recognizes well. "The Failsafe is a code. It's stored inside of the Crystal, protected by a password." She turns to look at Catra. "I think you already know what it is."

She does. She steps forward, up the stairs, and presses her hand to the crystal. "We're friends of Mara," she says quietly. The mask glows briefly before the crystal cracks open, separating into three section, connected by a triangular light. There's writing on the crystals.

"That's not First Ones' writing," Bow says slowly. Catra stares at it, wide-eyed.

"It's Magicat," she whispers, voice shaking. They really had been helping the entire time. Melog lets out a low, mournful mewl.

"What does it say?" Glimmer asks. Oh, right. Catra squints at the words.

"Um. Someone needs to go inside and accept the Failsafe?" Her ears are flat against her head as she reads. "What does that mean?"

"And are we sure that's safe?"

"We can't turn back now." Shadow Weaver dismisses Bow with barely a wave of her hand. "The Failsafe is within our grasp."

Catra glares at her for a moment before looking back at the crystal. And she starts toward it.

"Wait."

A strong hand grasps her wrist, pulling her back. She looks in surprise to see Adora holding her back, stony gaze fixed on Shadow Weaver.

"Adora, now is not the time for your ridiculous savior complex." That's the first time Shadow Weaver's directed that amount of annoyance at Adora. It's surprising. "Someone must take the Failsafe."

"Then you do it," Adora says, fingers tightening around Catra's wrist. No answer. "You knew exactly how to get here. We didn't get lost once, not even when we had to run away. You knew where to go. You've been here before, haven't you?"

Still no answer. Catra stares at Adora, wide-eyed, then looks at Shadow Weaver. "You could've taken the Failsafe yourself and gotten all the power you've ever wanted," Adora continues. "But you didn't. Why?"

"You're being paranoid," Shadow Weaver starts to dismiss her, but Catra speaks over her.

"All you've *ever* wanted is power. There's no way you'd pass up the chance to get all of this unless—" She waves her free hand uselessly. "Unless it would hurt *you*."

Shadow Weaver starts to step back, only to bump into a suddenly large and snarling Melog, whose mane is flaring red. Glimmer and Casta both have their hands raised in anticipation of a fight, and Bow is reaching for an arrow.

"Well?" Casta prompts. She's not going to get away, and she knows it.

"Whoever uses the Failsafe must absorb the full magic of the Heart when it is destroyed," she said. "That much raw magical power would burn any mere mortal apart. None of us are strong enough."

D . "But She-Ra is," Catra says quietly . It's not a question.

"Only She-Ra can hope to survive the process. No one else can do it."

Don't be selfish. "And if I don't survive it?"

Adora's hand is tighter around her wrist. "Then the magic will be restored to Etheria through your sacrifice. You will give us the power to bring us victory. Prime will be defeated. Your friends will be free."

And there it is. Her *duty* to this planet is to die. She hears the others yelling, feels Adora tugging her further from the crystal.

Don't be selfish.

"I'll do it."

Her voice is quiet, almost inaudible. But it still stops everyone cold, eyes turning to look at her. Catra stares at the floor, unwilling to look at any of them.

"What?" Adora's voice is faint. "Are you serious? She's *sacrificing* you!"

"It doesn't matter ." Catra pulls her wrist from Adora's grip, stepping back. "I don't matter . We're out of time. If this is the only way to stop Prime, I don't have a choice."

Don't be selfish.

Her ears twitch, and her head snaps up at the same time Melog growls, turning to look at the door.

"Well, look who it is," Micah says calmly . He's flanked by two sorcerers. Instinct fuels Catra's next actions; she's been on the receiving end of spells enough times to know what it looks like when someone's about to hit her with one. She shoves Adora away just in time for her to avoid being hit by the black, binding ropes. Catra falls

back with yell, struggling against the burning magic biting into her arms. She loses track of the world for a moment as she struggles, barely hearing the fight going on around her.

Don't be selfish.

She manages to get herself sitting up, and the magic dissipates as Micah is bowled over by Melog. They need help. *She* needs to transform.

But the power isnt there. Not like it was before. What is she doing *wrong*? Why cant she get this right?

Don't be selfish.

"W e have to get out of here!" Bow yells as he dodges a spell and fires another arrow.

"The Failsafe!" Shadow W eaver has priorities, of course. "W e cant!"

Catra looks back at the crystal. *Don't be selfish*.

She *will* get this right. She stumbles up, hurrying for the crystal.

"Catra!" she hears Adora calling behind her . She ignores it. She has to.

Im sorry .

She steps into a circular symbol beneath the crystal, and a light beams down on her.

And fire lights up her veins.

It's worse than any spell Shadow Weaver has ever used. It's like lightning under her skin, trying to rip her apart. Is it supposed to hurt this much?

It doesn't matter. You don't matter. Get your teeth and bear it. Just like always.

A flash of panic runs through her mind – Melog. She forces her eyes open, gasping, and sees everyone tied down by Micah, writhing under dark energy.

No!

Now she feels the power, intertwining with the Failsafe code burning in her skin and shining bright around her. She forces her hand up.

"*For the honor of Grayskull!*"

The light washes through the room, dissipating the spell. Catra steps out of the light, raising the sword and swinging it. A burst of energy sweeps through the room, hitting the possessed sorcerers.

"We need to get out of here," Catra says quickly, reaching for Adora. "I've got the Failsafe. We're good."

Adora picks herself up, staring at the glowing symbol on Catra's chest. She gets up without help and hurries out. Bow and Glimmer are behind her, half carrying Castaspella. Catra waits to make sure Shadow Weaver is in front of her before following them out.

Chapter End Notes

Almost there, guys. Who's ready?

Selfish

Chapter Summary

The end begins

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

You are the last Magicat.

Catra tears her eyes away from the sky to look at Melog. They're sitting on the balcony, Catra resting against the alien cat. Adora had gone back to her own room. Catra tries not to be too hurt by that.

"Yeah, I'm aware."

Is there a reason you're so ready to die?

"Do you think I *want* this?" Catra asks, sitting up to face Melog fully. "You heard Shadow Weaver. I'm the only one who *can*. What I want doesn't *matter*."

You keep saying that. Do you think this is the path your ancestors would want you to take? Mara?

"They're all *dead*."

That doesn't answer my question.

"What do you *want* from me?" Catra demands, standing and storming back into her room. The glowing symbol on her chest lights up the area around her as she collapses onto her bed, yanking the mask of her head to stare at it. It doesn't matter what Mara or her ancestors would want. It doesn't even matter what *she* wants.

She has to do this.

Don’t be selfish.

Melog walks over, nosing her hands until she rests on their snout. “Do me a favor?

Of course.

“If I… if something happens, please just take care of Adora. I know she’s going to do something stupid, and Bow and Glimmer will try to stop her, but they’re not great at that kind of thing. I need to know she’ll be okay.”

Melog let out a sad, mournful sound, pressing closer to nuzzle against her. *Nothing is going to happen*.

Catra smiles, holding them a bit tighter. “I don’t think you have much control over that, buddy,” she says morosely. “It’s okay. And if something happens, and I don’t… you didn’t fail, all right? No matter what anyone says, you did your job right up until the end.”

A ripple of sadness runs through Catra’s mind. She lets out a long breath, resting her forehead on Melog’s head. Their ethereal mane tickles her fur. She could’ve had a completely different life if things had gone just a little to the right. She could have grown up on Krytis. Grown up with Melog, or another guardian watching over her while she grew and learned and explored their beautiful planet. She could’ve lived in a universe where she never knew Etheria, or the Horde, or pain. Or Glimmer and Bow, the other princesses, Angella. *Adora*.

Maybe, despite everything, this universe is the better one.

“And that’s it. I think.”

They’ve gathered in the war room, looking up at a projection of Prime’s spire. “Once Entrapta gets those chips deactivated, we should be able to turn everything around.” Catra can’t sit still. Instead

she paces, not looking at anyone in particular as she talks. "And while you guys do that, well go to the Heart of Etheria"…

"And release magic back into the world and save the day and everything will be great!" Bow says brightly . No one else had been told about Catra's possible death being part of this plan. There's no reason to mention it.

"Hell definitely bring out Frosta for this. Probably Sea Hawk, too. Whatever he can do to trip us up." Catra looks at Mermista as she speaks. There's a determined fire in eyes as she nods. "And Micah." That goes in Angella's and Casta's direction. They both nod, exchanging looks.

"All we have to do is hold them of f until Entrapta deactivates the chips. And once the magic is released"…

Once it's released, theyll win. The cost is just still undetermined.

"Okay ," Catra says after a minute. "Let' s get ready and"—

"I'm not going with you."

Everything goes utterly and completely still. Catra stops mid-sentence, mouth hanging open as she seeks out Adora. She's been very… *qiet* since the night before. Kind of avoiding Catra. But it' s kind of to be expected. *This*, though? This is out of nowhere.

"I think Ill be better use with the princesses, holding of f the clones." Adora is looking at the ceiling as she speaks. There's something hard and unreadable in her steely blue gaze. "There' s nothing I can do at the Heart."

"What?" Catra' s throat is completely dry;her voice cracks on the single word. "But you.I..I need you."

Adora closes her eyes, letting out a long breath. "No you dont." The three words are said with such finality, they might as well have been

a door slamming in Catra's face. The Alliance sees one raw moment of complete devastation flash through her expression before she squeezes her eyes shut, running both her hands through her hair. And when she opens her eyes again, her guard is back up.

"Okay. Take Melog." She looks at the alien cat standing beside her. "They'll be able to help you guys get around."

She isn't wrong, but no one is fooled. She's sending Melog to watch after Adora. Melog nods, making a small huffing noise. Catra rests a hand on their head.

"It'll be okay."

Catra feels small as she steps into the Crystal Castle for the first time since she destroyed the sword. She's still scared of this place. Even if it can't control her anymore, even if she's stronger as She-Ra now than she was before, it still scares her.

"Are you guys sure about this?" she asked, looking down at Bow and Glimmer. "It could be dangerous, and—"

"And we should just let you walk into danger alone?" Glimmer scoffed. "Come on, Catra. You know us better than that."

"We're with you," Bow added, taking her hand. "Right to the end."

Glimmer took her other hand. Catra took a deep breath and smiled before they take another step forward, and a hologram pops up.

"*Warning. Planetary facilitator Light Hope protocol offline. Manual administrator access not recommended at this time.*"

"We're friends of Mara," Catra said shortly. "And we don't have time for this. Show us where the Heart of Etheria is."

There's a moment of pause as the hologram scans Catra, and the symbol on her chest glows a little brighter.

"*Welcome, friends of Mara*."

An opening appeared in a wall. Catra gave Bow and Glimmer one last questioning look, and with a nod, they all stepped in.

—

Adora pauses, looking at the ground. "Hang on. What's this?"

The others look down to examine the strange symbols in the dirt. "No clue," Mermista says after a moment. Perfuma and Scorpia shook their heads as well.

"I'd almost say it's a spell," Casta murmured. "But you said Horde Prime doesnt use magic."

"Nope, very anti magic." Adora looks at Melog. "Cloak us so we can get closer?"

Melog nods, spreading their invisibility to cover the ground, and they start forward carefully. The symbols lead them to a giant contraption ~~a~~ huge, green, triangular blade hangs in a structure pointing down at the ground with clones standing guard. There's a purple light beneath the probe, shining from a cluster of crystals buried underground.

A sudden burst of green light washes over them. Adora shudders, resting a hand on Melog's head and trying to keep her breathing steady. The blade is whirling now, lowering to the ground, and sickening green light is spreading through the symbols under their feet.

"They're using the planet to get to the Heart," Perfuma whispers in realization. "If they get through first"…

"Catra, Glimmer , and Bow are screwed," Mermista finishes. "W e need to let them know."

All eyes turn to Adora. She blinks in bewilderment. "What?"

"This is the part where you pick up and go back," Mermista explains.

"Why *me*?"

"W ell I could list off some reasons, but I think we all know the obvious one."

Adora feels her cheeks heat up as she looks away. "It' s not like that." What do they know, anyway? "She' s.W e're..not like that. And now isn't the time for this."

"Y ou're right," Angella says lightly . "Which is why you should be going to find Catra right now."

That throws Adora for a moment. The queen talking to her with such familiarity..it feels so much like her dream. "I..I'm not"…

It is, surprisingly, Scorpia who jumps up and grabs Adora by the shoulders. "Adora, you're wasting time!" she says as she shakes the blonde. "Y ou spent *two years* chasing Catra, are you seriously going to give up *now*?"

"She' s got a point," Mermista says.

"Agreed," Perfuma pipes up. Angella and Casta just exchange knowing smiles. Adora has *never* felt this exposed in her entire life. What do they all think they know?

Melog carefully nips at her fingers before grabbing her by the sleeve and dragging her closer. There's a spark of magic in the back of her mind –something warm. Something soft. Something Adora' s felt for as long as she can remember, even when she wasn't allowed to feel it.

She nods, turning to look at Melog. "Come on. I have an idea."

"This place is creepy ," Glimmer says, pushing a little closer to Catra. "Y ou okay?"

"Y eah." There' s no conviction in Catra's voice. "Just really hoping this works."

"W e'll be with you the whole way," Bow assures her . "When we get back, it'll be a whole new world."

A whole new world. If Catra lives to see it.

Her ears twitch at the sound of faraway footsteps and childish giggles. She'd know that sounds anywhere. "Adora?" She whirls to look down the hall, heart hammering. No one is there. But she can still hear the giggling.

"Catra, what—"

Catra runs off without a word. She follows the footsteps, gritting her teeth as a voice echoed around her.

"*I* am *your friend, Catra. Im always going to be your friend."*

"*Nothing really bad can happen as long as we're together ."*

She turns a corner and skids to a halt, stunned. There's Adora, standing, waiting for her. She smiles when their eyes meet.

"Hey Catra."

Everything in Catra knows it's fake. She can hear Glimmer and Bow calling for her, can hear her own heartbeat in her ears. And all she can do is stare at Adora and *wish*.

"*You and me, together at the end of the world*."

Except the world is ending and Adora isn't here. Even as she approaches, and Catra somehow shrinks down, allowing Adora to take her face in her hands, she knows she's not really here. And yet she indulges. She lets out a long, shaky breath, reaching up to touch one of the hands…

The hologram glitches and disappears. Catra is She-Ra again. Alone. At the end of the world.

"Catra?" Bow and Glimmer have found her. "What are you doing? The trail's that way."

Catra closes her eyes, swallowing the tears that threaten to rise. "Light Hope used to project images for me to fight when I got bored with bots. I guess this place is still doing that. We have to be careful."

She pushes passed her friends, determined to carry on.

Leaving Shadow Weaver in her cell, alone in Bright Moon, had maybe not been the *greatest* choice. But there's nothing else for her to do ~~–~~she certainly wasn't going to *help* them ~~–~~and it serves Adora well as she kicks the door open, storming to the sorceress.

"Ah, Adora. What brings you to—"

"*Nope*." Adora yanks her out of the blue column, gripping her robes and shoving her into a wall. "I don't have time for you or your messed up mind games. Prime's doing something to the planet, trying to hack into it to get the Heart, and Catra's on her way there *right now*. If you've *ever* cared about anything besides yourself, then now's the time to prove it. We need to find her and warn her before it's too late."

Melog growls behind Adora. They hate this plan. There's nothing the sorceress can do to redeem herself for the part she played in the magicats' destruction, but if she helps save Catra, they'll consider letting her live.

Maybe.

The images are still projecting.

Catra assumes they're pulling straight from her memories – the roof of the Fright Zone, her room in Bright Moon, the black garnet chamber, the tomb that had once been Half Moon, the barren wastes of Kytis…

"Catra, what's going on?" Bow asks as he and Glimmer jog to keep up. Catra hasn't spoken since she ran off, and she's shown no signs of stopping now.

At least until the images finally settle on the Whispering Woods, and she sees the sword – the old sword – in the ground, tangled in vines.

Just a joy ride on a skiff to celebrate Adora's promotion. That was all it had been.

"*Slow down, we need to make sure we have enough gas to get back!*"

"*That's future Catra and Adora's problem*."

Catra almost laughed. She had never really gone back. The sword owned her the moment she saw it for the first time. And it still owned her now. Nothing had changed.

"Catra?" Glimmer speaks this time, her voice quiet. And Catra, strangely, begins to laugh. Tears are burning in her eyes, running down her cheeks, and she laughs.

"It's me. I'm doing this. I was never good enough to be She-Ra, I just happened to be the only person left on the planet who could take the sword. Everything's always been leading here, hasn't it?"

"That's not true," Glimmer protests.

"Just come back with us, and we'll try to get out of here," Bow adds. Catra shakes her head.

"I can't. There's no *going back*. There never has been. This is never going to end if I keep running away and being selfish." She stops, taking a deep breath, and puts on a wavering smile as she looks back at Bow and Glimmer. She's still crying. It doesn't matter. "Thank you. Both of you. You were the worst captors ever, and I've been grateful every single day for it. Do me a favor, okay? Enjoy the new world. You've earned it." She reaches for the hilt of the sword. "I love you both."

Her fingers grip the sword, and in a flash of blinding light, she disappears, along with the hologram, leaving Bow and Glimmer alone in the hall.

They've barely left the castle grounds when the giant hologram of Horde Prime lights up over them, addressing the planet.

"*Rejoice, Etheria, for your day of reckoning has come. I offered you mercy. But you have spurned my good graces. So be it.*"

He drags Entrapta into view; she whimpers as he tugs at her hair and says, "*I'm sorry*," in a quiet voice. She hadn't finished. Everyone is still chipped. Adora's stomach drops at the thought.

"*Your resistance has been for naught. Your* She-Ra *has abandoned you. All that is left for your world is a terrible and eternal night.*"

The hologram disappears. Adora whirls to look at Shadow Weaver.

"We don't have time for this. Get us to Catra *now*."

"It doesn't *work* that way—" Shadow Weaver starts to say. Adora cuts her off.

"No, you've always held back, I know you have! You left me in the Fright Zone, and you could always find us when we were kids – that wasn't the Black Garnet, that was *your* power, and up until now, all you've used it for is to hurt us. So try doing something *good* for once in your life and help me find Catra before it's too late!"

Shadow Weaver looks her over for a moment before pulling something from the pockets of her robes. She reaches for Adora.

"Come here."

Adora glares at her before stepping forward and taking her hand.

The hall shakes as Glimmer and Bow run down it, trying desperately to find Catra, but she's just… *gone*.

No, not gone. They'll find her, even if they have to rip this place apart piece by piece.

They run over a shadow sigil, and immediately stop to look back at it, braced for a fight. It's a surprise when Shadow Weaver, Adora, and Melog appear. The sorceress falls back against the wall with a groan. Adora whirls to look at Glimmer and Bow.

"Where's Catra?"

"She... She left," Glimmer says, voice trembling with tears. "She said she has to do this alone and she can't be selfish."

Adora stares for a moment, mouth working silently, before she lets out a laugh utterly devoid of humor. "Of course. Of *course* she did. She's always just... just a stubborn *brat*!"

The words are accompanied by Adora furiously kicking the wall. The hall shakes again. "*What* is going on?" Bow demands. Adora takes a deep breath, running her fingers through her hair.

"Prime's figured out a way to...to hack into the planet. He's going for the Heart." Bow and Glimmer exchange horrified looks. "And he has Entrapta."

"Which means everyone is still chipped," Bow concludes. "Frosta, and Sea Hawk"…

"*Dad*," Glimmer breathes, eyes wide. Angella and Casta are out there. They can't fight him. They *won't* fight him. They need help.

But Catra needs them too.

"You guys go," Adora says before they can try to argue. "I'll find Catra."

"But"—

"This is what we do, okay?" Adora clenches her fists, looking away. "We're idiots, and we protect each other. I let her down for a long time. There's a lot to make up for."

Glimmer wants to protest, but Bow rests a hand on her shoulder, stopping her. He nods to Adora. "Okay."

Adora takes a deep breath, looking back at them. "Take Melog." Melog mewls in protest, and Adora swears she can *feel* their unhappiness in the back of her head. "I know, I know." She kneels to meet their gaze. "But they need you more than I do. I'll find Catra, and I'll bring her back. I promise."

Melog considers this for a long moment, then leans in to lick her cheek and touch their forehead to hers. There's an odd tingle of magic, but it feels warm, loving. Encouraging. Melog believes in her.

She won't let any of them down.

"Take care of them," Adora says, pulling back and resting a hand on Melog's head. They make a noise of agreement. Adora stands, and

is almost immediately tackled by Glimmer. The princess hugs her tight.

"Be safe," she whispers. "And *both* of you come home."

Adora softens, returning the hug. "I'll do my best. Good luck."

"The four of us don't need luck," Bow says as he wraps both girls in a hug. "We're the Best Friend Squad."

It's exactly as bad as Super Pal Trio, but it makes Adora smile nonetheless.

She steps away, and Melog circles protectively around Bow and Glimmer. They give Adora small, encouraging smiles before disappearing in a shower of sparkles.

Catra stares out at the lush, green trees. She's standing on the edge of a cliff, everything else miles below her. Etheria, she realizes. Before the First Ones. Before the magic was taken. This is what Catra's meant to fix

She feels more than sees or hears the person who appears beside her. A quick look out of the corner of her eye confirms it's Mara, her dark hair and skin standing out starkly against the white uniform. Her version of She-Ra, Catra realizes. She's glad she got to skip the white.

"This is what you wanted to protect, isn't it?" she asks quietly.

"Etheria was a beautiful place at one time." Mara sounds sad.

"It will be again." Catra clenches her fists, swallowing hard. "I'm going to fix this, and stop Horde Prime. Everyone will be safe."

"At what cost?" Mara challenges. "I never wanted to die, Catra. I sacrificed myself so you wouldn't have to. Why are you doing this?

What kind of question was that? Because. Because this is what I'm meant to do." Second-best. Cannon fodder. Nothing had changed. Her entire life has always been coming to this moment. "I'm She-Ra. I can't be selfish."

"Is it really that selfish to think of yourself?" Mara takes Catra's hands, finally forcing her to look at her. "You're worth more than what you give other people. And you're so close. Don't give up."

"What do you"…

Catra's ears twitch as the air shifts, and her head snaps around to see Horde Prime approaching them. "Catra." He sounds amused. "So this is where you've come to hide."

Catra squares her shoulders, ready to fight. "You're not here. You can't stop me."

He walks right through her, stopping in front of Mara. "How strange," he muses, cupping a hand to her cheek. "I must have fought her, must have known her face. But I have no memory of it."

Something in the woods shrieks; Catra whirls, heart pounding. *Don't be selfish. Don't be scared*.

"I've seen so many like her over the years," Prime continues without pause. "One by one, all their faces have been lost to oblivion. Just as yours will be."

Something too fast for Catra to follow shoots out of the woods; pain burns in her side as it slices through her skin. She yells in pain, doubling over and falling to her knees as She-Ra falls away. The scenery around them disappears, revealing the tentacled monster.

"A parting gift from the First Ones." Prime explains smugly. "Their old security system. Capable of taking out even one as strong as She-Ra. You will never make it to the Heart, Catra. The First Ones made sure of that. Goodbye, my oldest enemy."

He disappears, leaving Catra on the ground, staring up at the monster. Vulnerable.

Alone.

Chapter End Notes

It's fine :)

At The End Of The World

Chapter Summary

The last stand

Chapter Notes

I won't keep you guys. See you on the other side <3

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Mermista whirls, summoning up water to shoot at Frosta. The girl easily freezes it and drops it to the ground. "We're surrounded!" Perfuma calls from the middle of a cluster of clones. "We need to retreat!"

"Retreat *where*?" Netossa yells back, taking down a few clones then trying to throw a net at Frosta. She cuts through it with an ice shard from what had been Mermista's water.

"Okay, new plan, the water princess does *not* fight the ice princess!" Mermista yells, backing up. "Someone else's turn!"

Angella swoops in, hands glowing brightly;she doesnt touch Frosta, but it still throws the princess back, giving Mermista a moment to back away and take down some more clones.

Then she sees a flash of blue and red among the white.

She summons her trident just in time to block the swing of Sea Hawk's saber, pushing him back.

"We're not going to be able to hold ground forever!"Netossa yells. "We need a plan"—

A shower of sparkles burst to life overhead, and Glimmer appears. She clenches her fist as she drops down, yelling, and slams it right into the ground. Magical shockwaves take out all the clones within a fifty foot radius, as well as Sea Hawk and Frosta.

Glimmer straightens up, smiling. "Hey guys."

"Glimmer!" Angella lands beside her daughter, hugging her tight. Glimmer throws her arms around Angella in return. "Is everyone okay?"

"I mean, I could use a hug," Netossa says dryly. Spinnerella wraps her arms around her, kissing her cheek. Mermista turns to look at Sea Hawk, who's straightening up, preparing to fight again. Mermista holds her trident at her side as she approaches him.

"The night we met, I tried to kill you."

Sea Hawk runs at her, saber raised, and she deflects another attack. "You were stupid." Another swing, another block, "and *annoying*," swing, block, "and you were the first person in years who didn't immediately drop to their knees and bow when they saw me."

This time she summons up a bit of water with her swing, knocking Sea Hawk back a few feet. "You've never treated me like royalty, not the way the others do." Mermista steps toward him. "You just act like your stupid, annoying self."

He scoffs, pushing himself up. "And you claim to *care* despite all that?"

"No." Mermista stops, dismissing her trident. She's well aware of how vulnerable she's about to make herself. "I love you because of it."

The green in Sea Hawk's eyes flickers, probably as the part of his mind that's still *him* short circuits. A vine raises out of the ground, the tip of it driving right into Sea Hawk's chip. It sparks, and he yells,

staggering forward. Mermista dives to grab him as he collapses. She settles on her knees, letting him rest in her lap, then turns to look back at the others. They're all smothering smiles.

"Shut up."

"Uh, guys?" Scorpia breaks the spell. "Where'd Frosta go?"

They all look around, and sure enough, the girl isn't there. "I'm going to help Bow," Glimmer says, starting to step away from Angella. "Y ou all"—

She turns, and freezes when she sees dark energy wrapping around Castaspella, freezing her in place. It' s creeping over the others as well, closing in on Angella and Glimmer. Glimmer quickly grabs her mother and teleports them both outside the radius. They reappear just in time to see black and purple smoke rising from ground. And from it steps Micah.

"Hello, baby girl. Darling."

Catra peeks out from behind the rubble, watching the monster smash around, trying to find her. The gash on her side isn't healing, and worse, it's a sickening green. She groans through her teeth, trying to muffle the noise, but it's no good; a tentacle sweeps the rubble aside, exposing her .

No. This can't be how it ends. She has too much to do. Everyone is counting on her. She…

She's shaken out of her spiral as a smoke bomb hits the creature in the face. It shrieks as it stumbles back, and then…then Adora is there, looking so small with nothing but her staff to defend herself. She dives out of the way of an attack, coming to a halt in front of Catra. The smile she gives her is weak.

"Hey , Catra."

She's here. She's the only person Catra wants to see, and she's *here*, and she can't be, it's dangerous, what is she *doing*? "Adora, you can't." She struggles to push herself up, still gripping her side, and almost immediately topples over again. The arms that catch her aren't familiar, and Catra's vision has gone dark for a moment, but she knows exactly who she'll see when she looks.

"Shadow Weaver?"

The creature roars. Adora turns back to it, readying her staff. "Get Catra to the Heart."

"*What*?" Catra's voice cracks. "You can't seriously expect me to—"

"You need to go, Catra." Adora looks at the ground as she speaks. "I'll be right behind you. Promise."

Shadow Weaver is surprisingly silent as she leads Catra to a hallway, ignoring her weak struggles. "No, no, no," she groans. "Adora!"

But Adora is already running back into the fight.

This is how the world ends.

Not at Prime's knees, not making one last bid for victory, but at the hands of a lost husband. A father barely known.

Glimmer teleports out of the way of an attack, getting closer to Micah and almost managing to blast him. He shields it at the last second, and another burst of magic throws her a few feet away. Micah starts toward her, but a burst of light knocks him back, blinding him.

"Glimmer!" Angella lands beside her daughter, helping her sit up. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah." Glimmer straightens with a groan, then gasps and teleports them just in time to avoid taking another hit. They land behind a boulder, safe. For now. "We can't fight him."

It's the first time she's ever felt truly paralyzed by the thought of a fight. Everything up until this point had been running head first into danger and hoping, praying for the best. But now, when it matters most? Now she's scared. Now she can't move. Now she's aware of every weakness and flaw she has, and there are *so many*.

Angella wraps Glimmer in a tight hug, kissing the top of her head. "It's okay, dear."

Why are children fighting this war?

"Everything is going to be okay." Angella slides her hands up to clasp Glimmer's face between her hands. Glimmer meets her gaze, wide-eyed. "I need you to listen to me. Get as far away from here as you can. Find Bow. And finish what Entrapta started."

"Mom?..."

Angella kisses her forehead, smiling. "I love you so very much, Glimmer. Please be safe. And take care of each other. *Go*."

Glimmer is frozen to the ground as Angella rises into the air, flying back toward Micah.

"Ah, my beloved." The words are almost a sneer. A mockery of the warmth and love that were vital parts of Micah's entire being. Angella knows it's not him.

It still hurts.

"You may wear his face," Angella says calmly, raising a hand. "But I know my husband, Prime. And *you* are but a pale imitation."

A shield of light blocks the shadows that lash out at her, then compresses into a beam and launches at Micah. He cuts it down

with a shield of his own;a pool of shadows spreads out from his feet, and Angella takes to the air, trying to outrun the tendrils of shadow which follow. Focusing on escaping and attacking at the same time is hard, but she manages to get a few well-aimed strikes in. She knows she cant win. But if she can even weaken him enough to stall him until Bow gets Entrapta's program working or Castaspella can take him down, then this will have been worth it.

The shadows finally get her, wrapping around her ankle and bringing her down. She hits the ground hard, biting down a pained noise. Micah is in front of her before she can move, grabbing her by the neck and sqeezing hard as he lifts her into air . It's impressive, she thinks distantly, given their height difference.

"Dont worry , dear,"he says mockingly , holding his free hand back. Shadowy energy crackles menacingly around it. "Ill make this quick."

He holds her neck a little tighter. Angella just hopes hell be able to forgive himself one day.

A blinding flash of magic hits Micah from behind;he staggers forward, and Angella slips from his grasp, collapsing in a heap and gasping for air.

"Leave her *alone*!"

Glimmer. Sweet, stubborn, *determined* Glimmer. She takes another shot at Micah while he's still off his guard, then teleports closer and a few feet to the left, hitting him again, and pushing him away from Angella. He snarls, straightening up and readying his shot again. This time Glimmer isnt fast enough to dodge.

"No!"Angella yells, watching her daughter fall to the ground. She starts to stand, only to be pulled down again by shadows. Micah, assured that she isnt going anywhere, turns his full attention to Glimmer, rearing back to hit her again. The shadowy magic bears down on Glimmer, faster than the last one, stronger…

And in a flash of light, she summons her staff —Micah's staff —to cut through it. "You can't keep me down. You *won't* keep me down."

The shadows spread from Angella, moving toward Glimmer. She slams the end of the staff into the ground, countering it with her own, bright purple light. She grimaces against the onslaught, but steels herself, and takes one step forward.

"Mom raised me to be brave." Another step. "My friends taught me to be kind." Another step. "And I learned to be stubborn from you." Another step. "Every day you weren't there was another reminder of the war cost us." Step. "And every day I swore I would end it. For our kingdom." Step. "For Mom." Step. "For *you*."

She's only an arm length away from Micah now; she reaches out, pressing her hand to his chest. Her expression softens just a little.

"I love you, Dad."

The shadows are washed out in a purple glow, allowing Angella to sit upright. Micah lets out a yell of surprise and pain as magic surges through him; it fades after a moment, and he collapses, unconscious. Angella is barely quick enough to catch him and lower him into her lap. She cups his cheek, then looks up at Glimmer, unabashed *pride* in her expression. Glimmer grins back. "I love you."

"I love you too, sweetheart." Angella holds an arm out, and Glimmer dismisses the staff to throw herself into her mother's embrace.

Bow types away diligently while Melog watches his back. Frosta is looking for them, eyes still glowing the same, menacing green. *Just a little more*…

"Ha! I got it!"

He realizes his mistake at about the same time he's hit with a ball of ice, throwing him and Melog back as the invisibility drops. He looks

up at the girl standing over them, shivering slightly.

"Frosta." No response. "I know how frustrating it's always been for you to be the youngest. It feels like no one thinks you're powerful enough. Prime thinks he can use you because you're young and weak. But we know that's not true. *I* know that's not true. I know you're strong. And I need you to trust me, and be strong for a couple more seconds. Okay?"

There's a brief flash in Frosta's eyes as the green fades, and she screams. Bow immediately reaches to slam his hand down on the confirmation button.

And one by one, all around Etheria, the chips begin to fall harmlessly to the ground. Mermista looks over Sea Hawk's head in surprise, eyes wide. Castaspella is hurrying to Glimmer, Angella, and Micah when his chip falls off, and Glimmer beams. *Bow did it*.

Frosta collapses to her knees as her chip clinks against the metal floor. Bow waits anxiously for her to open her eyes and look around.

"What's going on?" She sounds confused. Probably a little scrambled. Bow grins, diving forward to hug her.

"Welcome back."

He's surprised when she actually hugs him back, hiding her face in his neck. He rubs her back for a moment before pulling away to meet her gaze and grinning.

"There's something I have to do, and then we're going to go and kick some serious clone butt. You ready?"

Frosta grins mischievously. "Absolutely."

"Is he okay?"

"I think so."

Angella reaches to pick up the chip as Casta fusses over her brother. Glimmer sees something flickering in the air high above them and grimaces, expecting another stupid Horde Prime broadcast…

"*Hey everyone*." Her heart jumps into her throat. "*I'm Bow*."

"*Prime is probably trying to get his channel back. I have to make this quick.*" Eyes move to the skies of Etheria one by one. "*Prime's controlled the universe for a long time. Right now, we're the only thing standing in the way of him controlling it forever. You might be feeling hopeless. You might be thinking 'we don't stand a chance.' And maybe we don't.*"

Glimmer stands, looking around to see battalions of clones appearing. She looks at her mother, who nods.

"Go."

"*Prime's too strong. His army is too powerful.*"

Mermista holds Sea Hawk a little closer as clones bear down on them, and summons her trident.

"*But that's not gonna stop us. We need to show Prime we're not afraid of him, because we have each other. And we have love.*"

Netossa, Spinnerella, Scorpia, and Perfuma look between each other, then back at their surroundings. Glimmer appears in front of them with a grim expression.

"*We can't give up. And if we go down, we go down together. We need you. All of you.*"

"Everybody ready for this?"

"Heck yes. Let's go."

“*It's time to take back our world. It's time to fight. For She-Ra, for our homes, for each other!*”

Adora pretty much already knows she’s not walking away from this fight alive. She hates breaking a promise to Catra. Even if it helps her *keep* another one.

And she’s *trying*. She’s managed to avoid most hits, or blocked them with her staff —her poor , pathetic staff. She’s never been this out of her depth in her entire life. But it doesnt matter . All she has to do is stay alive and keep this thing busy so Shadow Weaver can get Catra to the Heart.

A tentacle shoots out at her and she drops, launching herself into a roll to get away from the thing. They have to be almost there, right? Just a little longer—

The floor lights up in a sickening green beneath Adora’s feet. She gasps, straightening up and turning to follow the glowing light to the hallway Shadow Weaver had taken Catra down. A green shield blocks her as she tries to run to it.

“*Oh, little sister .*”She whirls to see a hologram of Horde Prime giving her a look of mock pity. “*What a shame. I had such high hopes for you.*”

Adora blocks another sharp tentacle, but this one breaks through her staff. Her only weapon.

No .

Shadow Weaver is doing most of the work dragging Catra along. She’s *trying* —like hell she wants to depend on *Shadow Weaver* to carry her. But her legs feel like jelly, the wound in her side burning. Sweat is soaking her hair and fur. Everything’s a little blurry. She just wants to rest…

"*Focus*," Shadow Weaver hisses, shaking Catra out of her haze. "We're so close."

Catra blinks heavily, squinting as rainbow light washes over her. She clutches weakly at the Failsafe symbol on her chest as it pulses. Almost there…

A scream echoes down the hall. And all of Catra's exhaustion is immediately washed away as she whirls around.

"Adora!"

She shoves away from Shadow Weaver without hesitation, staggering back the way they came.

"Catra, *wait*!"

She doesn't listen.

"*So brave, risking yourself for Catra*."

The tentacle is wrapped around Adora's ankle, dragging her back to the monster, completely ignoring her struggles. She manages to free her dagger from her boot and stab it through the tentacle, but it doesn't accomplish anything.

"*But it will make no difference. The Heart is almost mine, and when it is, your Catra will die.*"

The creature lifts Adora into the air, letting her dangle upside down over its mouth. Her lower lip trembles as tears fill her eyes. Another promise broken. *I'm sorry, Catra*.

"*So tell me, little sister. Was it worth it?*"

One tear escapes, sliding down her cheek. *Yes*.

And then she's falling. She hopes it's quick, that it just bites something vital and she dies…

The ground is *very* hard. "What?" Adora gasps, straightening up just in time to see Shadow Weaver burst through the green force field as if it's nothing. "Sh-Shadow Weaver?"

"Take Catra and run," the sorceress orders before aiming another attack at the creature to drive it back. Adora stares at her in shock.

"What are you?"..

"I told you to run," Shadow Weaver snarls. "Now *run*!"

A blast of shadowy magic throws Adora just beyond the hallway threshold. Her bruises are going to have bruises. But it doesn't matter. She stumbles back up, intent on running back into the fight, only to be stopped by a purple barrier this time.

"What—" Adora gasps, kicking the shield angrily. "What are you *doing*?!"

"Please, Adora." Shadow Weaver's voice is soft. Almost gentle. "You need to make sure Catra reaches the Heart. The magic must be set free."

The creature snarls, breaking free of the bindings Shadow Weaver had cast. She stumbles back, groaning, but raises her arms to keep the creature back with pure magic. Adora punches the shield, then reaches for her dagger. It's still on the other side of the force field.

"You can't do this!" she yells, as if that will stop Shadow Weaver. "It's going to kill you!"

"It's too late for me." Adora pauses, blinking. *What?* "But you? This is only the beginning for you."

There are tears in Adora's eyes. Why is she crying? She wipes them away angrily, rearing back to punch again. But a weak hand grabs

her wrist.

"Adora?" It's Catra. Of course. "What's going on?"

She doesn't answer, but she doesn't have to. A roar draws their attention to the fight going on just a few feet away. Shadow Weaver is still holding off the creature with one hand, the other raising to take off her mask so she could look at them both, and smiled.

"You're welcome."

And then she's engulfed in flames, the creature lighting up with her. Adora's knees go weak; she slides slowly to the ground, hand covering her mouth, while Catra just watches, wide-eyed, pupils reduced to little pinpricks.

The light fades, and the chamber is empty. Adora takes a few shallow breaths, tears streaming down her cheeks. It's another moment before she collects herself and reaches out, taking Catra's limp hand. She pulls herself up.

"We need to go."

Catra meets her gaze, nodding numbly. Adora steps forward to wrap her in tight which she returns, before they start down the hall together.

The walk feels twice as long to Catra's heavy limbs. Adora has one of Catra's arms slung over her shoulder, and her own arm is encircled around Catra's waist, hoisting her forward. The familiar scent is comforting. She raises her eyes to give Adora a smile, and is surprised when their gazes meet. Adora smiles back.

Rainbow light washes over them, and they look up at surprise to see the Heart pulsing overhead.

"Ready?" Adora breathes. Catra nods, drawing herself up and rallying the last of her strength to stand on her own, stepping forward. She flexes her fingers, takes a deep breath, and raises her hand. She sees the flicker of the sword—

And burning pain runs down her arm. She lets out a pained scream, staggering back, knees weak. "Catra!" Adora catches her, keeping her upright. "What's wrong?"

"I-I dont know, I—"

The room around them rumbles, flickering green. Catra sucks in a sharp, labored breath. "It's Prime's virus. It's keeping me from transforming."

"What does that mean?" Adora demands, grip tightening on Catra's arms. "What about the Failsafe? Dont you need She-Ra for it?"

Need her for the Failsafe? No. Just to survive. Catra blows out a long breath, straightening up and stepping away from Adora. "No. I can do it without her."

She reaches up, taking the mask off to stare at it. She forces a small smile as she turns to look at Adora, fighting through the tears in her eyes. "You need to go."

"What—"

Catra steps forward, pushing the mask into Adora's hands. "Get as far away as you can. Find Glimmer and Bow. Tell them everything is okay."

Adora feels like someone punched her in the chest. "You. What are you going to do?"

"What I have to do." Catra steps back, smile wavering even as she struggles to keep the tears in check. "It's going to be okay. I promise."

She's lying. "No," Adora said forcefully, stepping forward. "Together at the end of the world. Remember? I'm not leaving."

Stubborn, stubborn Adora. Catra can't bring herself to argue, though. She doesn't want to die alone.

Adora takes her hand, and they look up at the Heart together. Catra has no idea how to do this. Does she have to get up there somehow or?...

Pain.

It flares in the Failsafe symbol and spreads like fire. Catra chokes out a scream, staggering forward and dropping to her knees. She hears Adora calling her name, feels hands grabbing her, turning her over. But all she really comprehends is *pain*.

Adora watches in horror as the Failsafe symbol on Catra's chest flickers a sickeningly green. "No, no, no," she muttered, pulling Catra into her arms. "No, Catra, please, *please*—"

She grimaces, forcing her eyes open. Her gaze is glassy, not quite focused. "Adora?"

"Yeah, I've got you," Adora says, adjusting to let Catra lie in her lap. "I've got you, I'm not letting go. It's okay."

A bolt of green energy hits the Heart above them, and Catra lets out a strangled groan. Adora holds her a bit closer, looking back at the Heart. It doesn't look good.

It's the least of her worries.

She looks back at Catra, resting a hand on Catra's cheek. Catra raises her hand, claws latching weakly onto Adora's hand, just breaking skin.

"I'm sorry," she whispers, eyes fluttering close, the call of her name echoing in her ears.

"Mom. Mooooooom!"

Something is pulling at her arm. Wait, no. Some*one*. She looks down to see a hopeful little magicat with messy blonde hair and bright blue eyes, tail swishing eagerly. They're in a room. A room in Bright Moon, she registers as her ears pick up on the sound of rushing water. And arguing.

"Mom, are you *listening*?" Finn demands, folding their arms. "Aunt Glimmer's gonna kill Mama. You gotta do something."

What?

A door bursts open before Catra can speak. "No, absolutely not!" Adora squeaks as she hurries out of the room. "You are *not* putting that thing on me. What if being a princess is contagious?"

"Oh come *on*!" Glimmer huffs, one hand on her hip, the other holding a tiara.

"You don't make Catra wear a tiara!"

"She bites."

Finn laughs, running to hug Glimmer around the waist. "Can I wear the tiara?"

Glimmer beams. "Absolutely, Finny. Here." She rests it on their head, adjusting it to make sure it fits. "Perfect. Thank you for being more mature than either of your mothers."

Adora walks backward away from Glimmer and Finn, sticking her tongue out before whirling on her heel to smile at Catra. Glimmer has talked her into a dress, at least, but it fits her, Catra thinks. It's a simple white dress, but elegant. Just like her.

"Come on guys," Bow says as he walks in. He shoots Finn a quick thumbs up in approval of the tiara. "Scorpia's going to kill us if we're late."

Glimmer tucks herself into his side as they leave, Finn running out behind them. They look *very* good in their tux and tiara. Adora starts to follow, then stops, turning to look back at Catra. She smiles, offering her hand.

"You coming?"

With you? Anywhere.

Catra relaxes, smiling and reaching out to take Adora's hand…

And it goes right through.

She jumps back with a yelp of surprise as Adora glitches, and the room around her shimmers. "A beautiful wish." Everything goes dark, then green, as Horde Prime appears in front of her. "But there will be no future. Not for you."

The ground shakes, and Catra staggers back. Fire burns through her; she collapses to her knees, curling in on herself, screaming.

No future.

Tears well in her eyes.

"Catra!"

Her head snaps up in surprise. The ground has split, creating a gap between her and Adora. Adora, balancing right on the edge. Adora, trying to reach her. Adora, who's never given up on anything.

"You have to wake up, Catra. Please!"

Is she crying? That's not right. Nothing should make Adora cry. She's reaching, Catra realizes. She wants Catra to take her hand. She can

do that…right?

The simple act of moving her arm is almost impossible. Her limbs are heavy, burning. She can't even do this one, easy thing. She's useless.

"I can't," she says weakly, barely resisting the urge to just fall over and sleep. "I'm sorry."

"*No*!" Adora says fiercely, inching closer to the edge. "You have to hang on, do you hear me? You can't give up!"

She's trying. She's failing. Why can't Adora just let her go?

"*Please*." Damn it, she hates it when Adora sounds like that. "You don't give up. You're too stubborn. You're *not* going to die here!"

The tears spill over as Catra strains. Their fingers are so close, but she can't reach…

"I love you!" *No*. It feels like a weight is lifting off her body. "I love you, and I need you, and…please just… *stay*!"

Catra almost falls forward, and her hand finally touches Adora's.

Adora curls tight around Catra's limp body, waiting for the strike of green lightning to hit them…

But it never happens. She dares to look up, and is surprised to see Catra's arm extended, the shield summoned to cover both of them. Adora opens and closes her mouth a few times, stunned, before looking back to see Catra blinking her eyes open, staring at her in disbelief.

"You…You…love me?"

Adora laughs. The sound is choked with tears. "I was *married to you* in a dream for ten years. How am I the one who gets called an idiot

all the time?"

Catra is still just staring, eyes wide. Her voice is trembling a little as she speaks.

"I love you too."

And, well. Adora had kind of known that already. Sort of. Subconsciously. But *hearing* it, out loud, for real, outside of a dream... is still the most surreal experience. There's only one way she can respond to it. She cups Catra's cheek in a move that's both foreign and well practiced, leans in... and kisses her.

Catra is stunned for only a moment before she responds, almost eagerly, curling into Adora, using her hands to steady herself on Adora's shoulders.

Together at the end of the world. Except it doesn't feel like the end. Actually, Catra's starting to feel stronger. There's a warmth filling her chest, light spreading out to every inch of her…

It's not the end of the world, she realizes as magic swells around them. It's only the beginning.

Later, no person on Etheria will have the exact same story about what happened. Even the people who witnessed it aren't *completely* sure. They remember the blinding light, and Catra, and the sword in the ground…

Entrapta is the only one who actually sees Catra purge Horde Prime from Hordak's body. And she's not currently answering any questions.

The grass under their feet is comfortable and lush, the air filled with magic. The princesses are celebrating, laughing. Netossa dips Spinnerella into a kiss. Mermista helps Sea Hawk up, blushing and pointedly ignoring his wonder-filled gaze. Glimmer teleports to her

parents and aunt, and Angella wraps them all in her wings, giving them a feather-soft hug.

And Catra just watches it all, feeling disconnected, but *good*. There's a smile on her lips as she looks around, seeing her friends. They're happy. The entire planet is happy. She can feel it.

Melog winds around her legs, purring loudly. She rests a hand on their head, letting She-Ra slip away.

It would seem you were enough after all.

The sound of footsteps pulls Catra's attention away, her gaze landing on Adora. She pauses, giving Catra an uncertain smile. Melog bounds forward to get behind Adora and shove her toward Catra. She stumbles, and Catra grabs her, scooping her into a tight hug.

"Oh!" Adora yelps, giggling. She throws her arms around Catra's neck, pulling her close. "Hi."

"Hey, Adora," Catra whispers, smiling, arms winding around Adora in a tight hug. There'll be time for questions and insecurities and all that later, but now…

Now is a time to just be at peace.

Chapter End Notes

> And... that's it.
>
> There's an epilogue I might publish this weekend instead of waiting until next Friday, but this is it, the main part of Magicatra, done. 5 seasons, 3 stories, 57 chapters, 211,578 words. Y'all.... this has been a TRIP. I started writing it in July 2020, less than two months after I watched the entire show, and I only planned on writing ONE THING - Bow and Glimmer capturing Catra,

because I thought it would be a fun dynamic to explore. And then I wrote the entire first season in a week.

And I'm trying to not be too emotional but TT this has been such a big part of my life for the last year and a half (and definitely kept me sane through the worst of quarantine). Writing it, figuring out how to accommodate important story points with my changes, what to change... it's been such a blast. The encouragement and kind words I've gotten have absolutely blown me away, and I'm so grateful to everyone who took the time to let me know their feelings - I thrive off the tears of my readers. And the happiness. Thank you <3

What's next? ¯_(ツ)_/¯ Once the epilogue is up, I think I'm going to take a small break and figure out what I really want to focus on. I've got a couple dozen half-baked AU ideas, including a canon divergent one I literally just came up with like an HOUR ago that might be fun. I've got a few modern AUs, including a supernatural journalists story that I'm really proud of, and like a bunch of others. I'll probably be bumming around Tumblr and Twitter asking for opinions on what people want to see, so ya know:

Tumblr: catrasredemption
Twitter: catrasredeemed

And since I know there are going to be questions:

-Best Friend Squad roadtrip!?
Yes, it happens. Bow and Glimmer show up like two seconds after the end and throw themselves at Catra and Adora. But I liked ending it where it was. It felt right.

-Glimbow?
Of course

-Is the epilogue happy?
It's so fluffy you're going to die

By The Victors

Chapter Summary

The future, the beginning

Chapter Notes

Decided to post this early because I'm excited and also don't want to make people wait a week. My feelings about this officially being over are bittersweet, but this entire thing is fully sweet fluff

See the end of the chapter for more notes

—Five Years Later—

"Get *up*!"

Catra and Adora yell as their bed very suddenly disappears out from beneath them, depositing them in a heap on the floor.

"*Sparkles*," Catra growls. "I *swear*—"

"You're going to be late if you don't get moving *now*!" Glimmer insists, her hands on her hips.

"Five more minutes," Adora mutters sleepily, grabbing for the blankets that hadn't been teleported away *with their bed*.

"No more minutes!" Glimmer teleports behind Adora, grabs her by the shoulders, and disappears with her. The sound of water running, followed by a yelp, tells Catra that Glimmer just pushed Adora into the shower. She appears back in front of Catra. "If you guys are late, I'll ~~I'll~~ ~~ba~~nish you from Bright Moon!"

"Do we even *live* in Bright Moon anymore?" Catra asks dryly. "Besides, you wouldn't last five minutes without me helping you organize things."

Glimmer makes a frustrated noise. "Just get *moving*!"

And she's gone—hopefully to harass Bow, Catra thinks as she picks herself up and looks around.

"Where the *fuck* is our bed?"

The running water stops, and Adora stumbles out of the bathroom, still clothed and dripping wet. "I take it all back," she says seriously. "Glimmer is *not* allowed to just teleport in whenever she pleases."

Catra snorts. "About time you got on board with me. Come on, let's get ready before she decides to teleport us into a waterfall or something."

Catra loves Bright Moon. She really, *really* does. But after a year of post-war castle life, she and Adora had both *needed* an escape. They couldn't live there anymore. Building a small cottage on the edge of the Whispering Woods had been a great outlet for Adora, Bow, and Micah, who all had serious problems with sitting still. Glimmer had been distraught when they left, and Adora had *stupidly* assured Glimmer that she could teleport down to see them *whenever she wanted*.

Adora goes to get a *proper* shower while Catra sets about getting their clothes ready. They'd picked out their outfits weeks ago—a white suit with golden trim for Adora, and a light red dress shirt with black pants for Catra. She was even *wearing boots* for that brat. Glimmer can never say Catra doesn't do anything for her.

"And you're *sure* we don't have to do anything, right?" Adora asks as they switch, her going to get dressed while Catra showers.

"Absolutely not. I asked Bow three times, and Angella four times. I am *sure* we don't have to do anything except be there so that little vein in Glimmer's forehead doesn't explode."

"Okay , okay..wait, where' s—"

"No clue."

They're not even close to being late, but Catra still showers fast, and is out before Adora's finished buttoning her shirt. "Y ou're hopeless without me," she says with a snicker , going to help.

"I am *not*. Just because we don't all roll out of bed and get dressed without opening our eyes—"

"Sssssshhhh." Catra bats her hands away to finish buttoning up the shirt. "Save your brain cell. Y ou'll need it."

Adora huffs. A wave of amusement runs through Catra's mind. *Be nice.*

Oh good, I was starting to worry Glimmer took you with the bed .

Melog trills happily as they slip into the room. *I sensed her coming and escaped.*

"Could've warned us first."

Adora looks at Catra, then at Melog. "W ait you knew she was coming and ditched us, didn't you?"

Melog just mews innocently.

Catra dresses, grumbling to herself about the *stupid boots* and *that sparkly pain in the ass is lucky I love her* , while Adora finished getting herself ready. Her hair has grown back and a little beyond what it had been pre-Prime. Glimmer had been *gleeful* about introducing her to hair accessories, and Adora had taken quite well to a couple of simple clips that pinned her hair back behind her ears

while letting it hang free. Catra, ironically, has enjoyed pulling her hair back into a loose ponytail after being forced to admit the mask isn't exactly practical for her new lifestyle. Now it hangs over the mantle—a dedication to the people who made it.

"Ready?" Adora asks as Catra finishes lacing the boots.

"Almost—hang on."

She grabs her Bright Moon pin from the dresser, carefully attaching it to the lapel of Adora's suit jacket. "Were you gonna try and pretend to be single today?"

"*What*, and pass up the chance to show off that I'm dating *She-Ra* to every person there?" Adora kisses her quickly. "Never."

Catra rolls her eyes and offers her arm. "Shall we?"

It's a nice day, making for a nice walk to the castle. The breeze is gentle, soft, ruffling them without messing up all their hard work. It's warm and peaceful.

The castle is the opposite.

"Catra! Can you help—"

"Nope!" Catra says, tightening her arm around Adora's and heading for the stairs without looking at Castaspella. "You guys said you had this, you have it. Today is my day *off*."

"Is it really a day off if you're going to help Glimmer get ready?" Frosta calls from where she's working on the ice statues.

"I'm just going to ask her what she did with our bed."

Glimmer is pacing around the bedroom and freaking out. "What if I mess up somehow? What even *is* the Queen's Chamber? You never told me about that!"

"Yikes, did we already miss the good part?" Catra whispers to Bow as she and Adora join him on the bed. He nudges her with his shoulder, chuckling.

"Be nice."

"She *stole* our *bed*, Bow."

"It's *really* going to be okay, dear," Angella tries to assure her distressed daughter. "This is all mostly formalities—"

"But what *is it*? None of the books gave me any clues!" Glimmer throws her hands up, walking passed Micah, who tries and fails to put a tiara on her head. "Are you *sure* it's okay for me to bring Bow? Or is this some rite of passage thing I *have* to do alone? And if I *can* bring Bow, who else can come? Could Catra—"

"I'm just here for the cake," Catra calls. Glimmer snaps around, as if realizing for the first time that Catra and Adora are *there*.

"You came through the castle! How many people are there? Is everything ready? Aunt Casta was saying something about flowers a few hours ago—"

"The *literal flower princess* is going to be here if she isn't already. I'm sure they've got plant life covered. And yeah, there are a lot of people down there. I think I saw Bow's entire family."

"I *told* them they didn't all have to come," Bow says with a groan.

"What about other decorations? Food! We need to be able to feed people!"

"Why don't I go check on things?" Adora says with a small smile, heading for the door. She gives Catra a pointed look before leaving, and Catra sighs. So much for a day off.

"All right Sparkles." She stands, dusting her hands off. "Pep talk time."

"From *you*? This day is already ruined."

"Ignoring that." Catra crosses the room and takes Glimmer by the shoulders to look her in the eye. "Listen. Something is almost *definitely* going to go wrong today."

"Worst pep talk ever."

"And you know what? It doesn't matter. Maybe the flowers aren't great or Frosta's ice statues melt, but none of *that* is important. What's important is that the end of the day, *you*—" She pressed a finger to Glimmer's forehead. "You are going to walk down into those chambers, do whatever weird test thing this is, and go to bed tonight as the Queen of Bright Moon. Everything else is a small detail that doesn't matter."

Glimmer meets her gaze, eyes filling with tears. "What if I'm no good at this?"

"You're going to be *great* at it. And if you suck, I'll let you know in all my official capacity as your adviser, and you can fix it. Okay?"

A small giggle bubbles up in Glimmer's throat. "Okay."

"Great!" Bow jumps up to wrap them both in a giant hug.

"*Hey*!"

"Bow, my make up!"

Angella and Micah exchange small smiles. The decision to retire hadn't been an easy one, but Angella knows she's making the right choice and leaving the kingdom in good hands.

Catra leaves Glimmer to finish getting ready and find her girlfriend. She is, predictably, at the buffet table, sneaking some treats. She pauses mid-bite when she sees Catra watching her, eyebrow raised.

"Taste testing."

"Uh huh."

"It might be poisoned. Someone needs to check."

"*Sure*, Adora."

She has about half a second to register a very floral scent before a voice exclaims, "Adora! Catra!" and they're both scooped into one large hug. They groan.

"Hey Scorpia," Adora wheezes, resting her head on Scorpia's shoulder—the only way to return the affection since her arms are trapped against her side.

"Lovebug," Perfuma calls with barely suppressed amusement. "I think they need to breathe."

"Oh, right!"

Scorpia quickly sets them down, giving them each a pat on the back as they catch their breath. "So how's it going? Have you seen Glimmer? Is she excited? Do you know what she has to do? Do *all* kingdoms have some kind of weird trial or was that just a Scorpion Kingdom thing? What about?—"

Perfuma, the absolute traitor, slips away to help with flowers while Scorpia talks Catra's and Adora's ears off. Their rescue comes in the form of a happy squealing about ten minutes later.

"Tiny treats!"

"Nope!" Catra calls, grabbing Entrapta by the back of the suspenders and pulling her away from the table. "Tiny treats happen *after* the big event, remember?"

"Social customs are ridiculous sometimes."

"I agree. Nice bow tie."

Entrapta practically preens as she straightens up, fixing the bow tie with one hand. "Thanks! I was inspired by what Adora wore to Scorpia's coronation."

"Aaaawwww," Scorpia and Adora say together . Catra barely resists the urge to roll her eyes.

"Awesome. Thing One and Thing Two having a boys' day in?"

"Thing 2?" Entrapta tilts her head, thinking. "Oooooooooooooh, you mean Hordak and Wrong Hordak! Wrong Hordak really wanted to come, but Hordak didn't think he'd be welcomed in Bright Moon." And he wasn't wrong about that. They'd all... more or less come to terms with everything that had happened, and exile to Dryl for the rest of his existence was barely a punishment, but some things could never really be fixed. He *had* attended Scorpia's coronation, surprisingly, and everything had been civil enough. But it's probably best he stay home today. "They're keeping an eye on some of my latest experiments. There's been some *fascinating* evolution of quickly growing artificial life – one of them tried to kill us last week!"

"Amazing, I already regret walking into this conversation," Mermista says dryly as she approaches. "There *must* be a reason we don't get together more often."

"But we *should*!" Scorpia says. "I miss seeing you guys! I don't want to wait until the next big event – what would that be, anyway?"

"Well, if no one else wants to be queen , it'll be Princess Prom."

Adora groans. "*Please* don't say that too loud. I think Frosta is still mad at me."

"She is *absolutely* still mad at you. You'll have to blow up Scorpia's ball room so she knows it's not personal. No stabbing, though. I'm going to be pissed if you stab me again."

"Are you seriously—

"Waitwaitwait," Scorpia interrupts. "*My* ballroom?"

Catra tilts her head toward the queen, raising an eyebrow. "Yeah, I found some records about the old princess proms. There's a set rotation order for who hosts. Bright Moon, Plumeria, Salineas, Snows, Scorpion Kingdom. Dryl used to be part of it – not quite sure why they were taken out, but I can guess. Anyway, you're next on the roster."

Scorpia looks positively terrified. "*I* have to host the next Princess Prom?! When's that?!"

"About three years. Better get started." Catra pauses, then looks back at Adora. "Remind me to retire before Glimmer's turn to host comes around."

"Yes ma'am."

The distant sound of singing reaches their ears. Everyone looks at Mermista, who makes a disgusted noise. "I *told him* no singing!"

Catra and Adora bite down laughs as she storms off to, presumably, get her husband under control.

Everyone starts clapping as Glimmer and Bow step out of the chamber. Outwardly, nothing has really changed about Glimmer, but there's definitely something *different*. It's her magic, Catra thinks, nose twitching. Not a bad smell at all, but something to get used to.

Glimmer looks at everyone, grinning, before teleporting away. Catra feels a hand on her shoulder, and then in a sickening turn, she and Adora are standing on stage with Glimmer and Bow.

"*Sparkles*." Catra moans, leaning on Adora and waiting for the world to stop spinning. It hasn't gotten better. Catra doesn't think it ever will.

"Thank you all for coming." Glimmer ignores Catra, starting her speech. "Today is a special day, for obvious reasons." She hadn't let Catra help write this, and Catra still thinks that's a mistake, but *fine*, let the newly crowned Queen of Bright Moon humiliate herself five minutes after taking power. "But the most important thing actually *isn't* my coronation. Today also marks the five-year anniversary of the day the war ended."

Catra looks at Adora, who shrugs back, then around the room. Bow is the only one smiling like he knows what's happening. "Now, I'm not saying I purposely put this off just to use this as an excuse to *also* celebrate Catra. Her ego is big enough." Glimmer smirks when she hears Catra hiss. "*But* I think it's important that these events share a day. The end of the war was the day magic was brought back to the planet. It was a turning point for not only Etheria, but for the entire universe. It was a new beginning ~~a~~ chance for so many people and relationships to begin or start over, for kingdoms to begin rebuilding. It was the start of second chances and new lives. And today is another starting point. My mother ruled over and protected Bright Moon for my entire life, and long before it. She saw us through a war, and even in the darkest times, did whatever she had to do to keep us safe."

Tears fill Glimmer's eyes as she seeks out her mother and father and the crowd. "I hope someday I can be half the queen she was. And I want to start off right, by making sure everyone understands what happened the day the war ended. While it is, of course, true that the combined power of the Princess Alliance, our allies, and all of Etheria helped drive away Prime's forces, there's an important detail that's always been left out, and that's the role Catra ~~n~~ot just as She-Ra, but as herself ~~p~~layed in it all."

Glimmer turns, holding a hand out to Catra. She hesitates before taking it and letting her friend pull her forward. "Catra was the one who brought the Princess Alliance back together. She helped us remember that our strength is, and always has been, in our ability to depend on our friends and the people we loved. And we made

mistakes —we lost track of those bonds, or let them be overshadowed by outside forces. But we always found our way back to each other. *She* brought magic back to Etheria. And Im proud to call Catra my friend, and my adviser. I hope youll believe —or at least give us a chance to prove —that Bright Moon will be in good hands under our charge.

"So."Glimmer squeezes Catra' s hand, smiling. "Is there anything you'd like to say?"

How about Im going to kill you? Catra *hates* being put on the spot like this. She had *never* wanted to be a hero, or to be recognized or famous. There was a reason she had retreated into the background after the war ended, only coming out at times when She-Ra was absolutely needed or she *had* to be somewhere. Her strength had always been in strategy and planning. She didnt *want* attention.

Something slinks through her legs. She looks down to see Melog wrapping around her, purring gently, projecting a sense of calming peace.

And she knows exactly what to say .

"History is written by the victors."Her voice rings loud and clear throughout the silent chamber. "It' s something I heard a *lot* when I was learning to be She-Ra. History was written by the First Ones, the self-proclaimed heroes who were willing to sacrifice a planet and all of its people because they didnt understand magic.

"But not everyone agreed with what they wanted. There was a rebellious group of First Ones led by Mara —the previous She-Ra —in an attempt to stop the First Ones from getting what they wanted. They were aided by the Magicats —by *my* people —who had been forced to abandon their planet when Horde Prime had been invaded. I never saw Krytis before its destruction, but Melog"— She pets Melog's head with a small smile, "says it looked a lot like Etheria does now —teeming with life and magic and happiness and *love*. Mara, her rebellion, the Magicats.they *loved* Etheria. It was a

special, beautiful planet to them. The Magicats always understood that magic is a *companion*, not a tool, and that we accomplish so much more when we work *with* it instead of forcing it to do what we want. And while they're all gone now —Mara and her rebellion died centuries ago, the Magicats were wiped out by the Horde —their memories still remain.

"And today , *we* stand here, the new victors of what will one day be history. We have a chance to tell it right this time. To make sure Mara and the entire Grayskull squadron are appropriately honored instead of being remembered as disgraced rebels. To make sure everyone knows that my ancestors cared so much more about Etheria than the First Ones ever did. They fought for this planet to their last breath. They were heroes. They deserve to be remembered that way. No more lies or half truths. No more burying history. We need to be able to properly learn from it so we never make these mistakes again. And I"…

Damn it, her voice was cracking. "I don't know if I was always the hero Etheria deserved. I guess history will tell that as well. But I hope. I hope I can be remembered at least somewhat fondly . For all the mistakes I made —and there were so many —I hope the good will be remembered as well. I understand now why my people loved Etheria so much. *I* love this planet. And I will do everything to protect it to the very end. I hope history will remember me favorably. I hope history will look back on all of us and be proud of where we ended up."

Silence follows, and Catra is ready to run before someone in the back finally starts clapping, then another, then another, until the entire room is cheering.

"Y eesh, I had *time* to write my speech and you still upstaged me," Glimmer mumbles.

"Payback for putting me on the spot."

Adora slides her arms around Catra's waist, pulling her close and kissing her forehead. "That was amazing."

"You *have* to think that, or I'll make you sleep on the couch."

The clapping is punctuated by Frosta calling, "Can we *eat* now?"

"Yes!" Glimmer yells back. "It's a celebration, let's get celebrating!"

The crowd disperses, flocking toward the tables, the food, and to the newly crowned queen and king. Catra takes Adora's hand and pulls her away before they can be cornered.

"Are you okay?" Adora asks as they slip into the hall.

"Yeah, just... need a minute."

She tucks herself under Adora's chin, letting out a long breath and holding her close. Adora squeezes her into the tightest hug she can manage.

"You're an amazing hero, you know," Adora points out after a minute. Catra scoffs lightly, thumping her tail against Adora's leg. "You *are*. You're exactly what Etheria needed and deserved. The Rebellion didn't just need another soldier, it needed someone capable of caring and understanding it. That's you."

Catra hums, turning to rub her cheek lightly against Adora's shirt. "I guess. You getting sappy on me?"

"I'm allowed a *little* sappy every now and again, thank you very much."

"Sure." She pulls back to meet Adora's gaze, smiling. "I love you."

"I love you too." Adora swoops in to kiss her, then takes a step away. "We should probably get back there before *the queen* sends a search party." She holds out her hand. "You ready?"

As long as I have you, I am. "Yeah. Let's go."

She reaches for Adora's hand, lacing their fingers, and they walk back into the ball room - into the future - together.

Chapter End Notes

The End :')

I did most of my sappy stuff in the last chapter, but again, I just want to thank everyone who took the time to read/review/kudos/etc. Reviews really did change how I approached parts of the story - the input was so valuable, and also just watching people speculate has been fun. I'm really bad at replying to reviews and I know it probably makes me seem like a jerk, but I swear I love and appreciate every single one of you. Keep being your amazing selves <3 And I'll see you in the next story, whatever that ends up being

Also there was a TON of stuff that didn't make it into the final cut, and I posted about a lot of it on tumblr - highly recommend checking it out: https://catrasredemption.tumblr.com/post/670400794443628544/magicatra-notes-and-extras

End Notes

Reviews make the writing gremlin happy. Feed it reviews.

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